

THE NEW INDIA MANIFESTO

ROHAN DESHMUKH

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AN ADMISSION

While this narration is built on and around a true legend of Solapur, and who is also my father, Subash Deshmukh, some names have been altered in this book to maintain the privacy of people.

DEDICATION

This book is dedicated to my father
For Subhash Deshmukh.
Who never needed this book.
And built everything anyway.

and my mother, Smita Subash Deshmukh.

There are no words in my vocabulary to describe the gratitude I have for them.

I just pray that my Life journey will find its approval.

I owe my wife, Komal, a debt of gratitude. I came into Pune when I married her, and I came into a new world that was completely different from the world of my childhood, my entire experience. If I did not feel like an alien in a strange world, it was because of her patience and her love.

Dedication

This book is also for my 3 beautiful and beloved children – I hope one day that this book might also awaken in them serious questions. Questions that challenge. Questions that bring forth solutions.

Questions that Awaken.

A NOTE BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Some books arrive at exactly the right moment. This is one of them.

The New India Manifesto is not a comfortable book. It will not flatter you or tell you what you want to hear. It will not offer the easy consolations that most writing about India's future traffics in — the reassurance that things are improving, that the right people are in charge, that someone somewhere is handling it.

This book does something harder and more necessary. It asks what *you* are doing about it.

Rohan Deshmukh writes from a place that most books about India's transformation never visit — not from think tanks or conference stages or the comfortable distance of analysis, but from Solapur. From Wadala. From the fields and factories and cooperative branches where real India

actually lives and works and struggles and, when given half a chance, builds extraordinary things from almost nothing.

The philosophy in these pages was not developed in a classroom. It was inherited from a father who sorted dead chickens before dawn and went on to build a sugar factory that the record books had to acknowledge. It was tested in a cooperative with 150 branches and thousands of members who trusted it with their savings and their futures. It was refined across two decades of feeding the hungry, funding the overlooked, and watching what happens when someone simply refuses to accept that the circumstances they were born into are the circumstances they must die in.

What emerges is a manifesto in the truest sense — not a policy document, not an academic argument, not an inspirational collection of quotes. A direct, demanding call to the youth of India to stop waiting for someone else to build the country they claim they want to live in.

You will be challenged. You will be uncomfortable. You will be asked to examine the gap between what you believe and what you actually do.

That discomfort is the point.

Read carefully. Complete the exercises honestly. Take the pledge seriously.

And then — as Rohan Deshmukh would say — begin.

THE NEW INDIA MANIFESTO

BY ROHAN DESHMUKH

FOREWORD

**I am not Che Guevara.
I am Che Deshmukh.**

*I do not come from the jungles of South America.
I come from the soil of Solapur.*

*I do not fight with bullets. I fight with ideas.
I do not carry a gun. I carry intent.
I do not call for war. I call for responsibility.*

*This is not Havana. This is Hindustan.
This is not Cuba. This is Solapur.
This is not a guerrilla struggle. This is a grassroots revolution.*

**And you — the youth of India — you are the
revolutionaries.**

*Not rebels with rifles, but builders with resolve.
Not fighters of destruction, but fighters of dignity.
Not warriors of anger, but warriors of awakening.*

**My comrades — my brothers and sisters — listen
carefully.**

The enemy is not foreign invaders: The enemy is not a flag.
The enemy is mediocrity.
The enemy is complacency.
The enemy is the shrug that says, "Chalta hai."

Every time you say, "What can I do?" — India dies a little.
Every time you scroll away another hour, India loses a
dream.
Every time you surrender to comfort, India surrenders a
future.

**But every time you act, India rises: Every time you build
— India awakens.**

Every time you dare — India is reborn.

**I am not here to entertain you.
I am not here to inspire you.**

I am here to recruit you

***Recruit you into the Fourth Revolution —
The Revolution of Responsibility.***

Where our weapons are skills.

Where our bullets are ideas.

Where our targets are poverty, hunger, ignorance, and mediocrity.

Where our victory is not bloodshed, but dignity.

**My young friends —: Do not ask "When will India
change?"**

Ask instead: "When will I change?"

Do not ask "Who will build New India?"

Ask instead: "Why not me?"

This is your manifesto: This is your battlefield.

This is your pledge.

The world will one day ask —

"Who led the revolution of New India?"

And the answer will not be one man.

The answer will be millions of youth.

The Answer Will Be You: Raise your voice.

Raise your hand.

Raise your intent.

Say it with me —

YES! I AM IN!!!

FOREWORD EXERCISE

Before you read a single chapter, do this one thing. Get a book.

Exercise F.1: Your First Declaration

Open your notebook. Write today's date at the top of the first page.

Then write your honest answers to these three questions:

What do you want India to look like in twenty years?

What are you currently doing — specifically — to help build that India?

If you are doing nothing or very little, why?

Do not write what sounds impressive. Write what is true. This entry is not for anyone else. It is a baseline — a record of who you were the day you picked up this book. You will return to it.

Standing Commitment #1: *I will be honest with myself about the gap between what I want and what I am doing.*

THIS BOOK IS FOR THE YOUTH OF INDIA

For the educated but unemployed.

For the talented but aimless.

For the connected but directionless.

*For every young Indian who scrolls through life,
wondering if tomorrow will be better.*

This book is about New India

It is the story of a man called Rohan Deshmukh.

Born in Solapur. Built for Bharat.

It traces his roots, his beliefs, his vision.

And it calls for a New Revolution.

Like Swatantra Bharat was once a whisper, an impossible dream

—

So too is New India today.

Then, independence was unthinkable.

Today, mediocrity is unacceptable:

This book is not a biography.

It is not a success story.

This book is a call.

A call for Revolution.

A call to Awaken:

A call to Rise.

Led by a voice called Rohan Deshmukh.

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BEFORE THE FIRST PAGE TURNS

*I have a dream
To Incubate a 100,000 Entrepreneurs
From amongst our Youth
Who'll Rise Like Phoenixes
Who'll Create Wealth
In This Land
That is Maharashtra.
— Subhash Deshmukh*



My father was not a poet.

He was a man who could barely afford school fees, who dropped out at seventeen after a cricket ball shattered his eye and with it every comfortable assumption about how his life would unfold. He was a man who began his working life

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in the dark and fetid interiors of a poultry factory in rural Maharashtra — sorting dead chickens, breathing in ammonia, earning just enough to eat and nothing more.

And yet. One day, on a piece of paper tucked inside a folder of old documents, he had written a poem. A dream. A declaration so fierce and so clear that when I read it, I had to sit down.

**A hundred thousand entrepreneurs. From our Youth.
Rising like Phoenixes. In Maharashtra.**

Not a hundred. Not a thousand. One hundred thousand. This man — who had no blueprint, no venture capital, no MBA, no safety net — had dared to dream at a scale that most people in corner offices with whiteboards and PowerPoints would call delusional.

He was not delusional.

He was right.

And this book is the proof.



A New India. But Which India?

When India won her freedom in 1947 — after nearly three centuries of British rule — the minds of those first leaders were consumed with one urgent task: to hold this vast, diverse, fractious land together. To take hundreds of princely states, dozens of languages, ancient communities that had

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never been asked to think of themselves as one nation — and make them one.

It was monumental work. And it succeeded, after a fashion. A constitution was written. A democracy was born. A flag was raised.

But in the urgency of assimilation, a different set of questions was never properly asked. Not 'how do we hold this country together?' — but 'what kind of country do we want to become?' Not 'who are we as Indians?' — but 'who could we be?' Not the India of survival, but the India of aspiration.

Instead, we adopted socialism. We built a state that promised to take care of its people — and in doing so, quietly discouraged its people from taking care of themselves. We developed the habits of a nation that waits. Waits for the government. Waits for the scheme. Waits for someone in Delhi to notice the problem and send a solution in a brown envelope.

For seventy-five years, India chugged along. Not without achievement. But without a defining answer to the most important question a nation can ask of itself: What are we trying to become?

And then, from the most unlikely of directions, an answer arrived.

He was not from the ruling elite of Delhi. He had no dynastic claim, no inherited network, no Lutyens' bungalow

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to return to after a press conference. He was, as his critics said with intended contempt and his supporters said with fierce pride, a chaiwala. A man who had grown up making tea, who had risen through the ranks, who had governed Gujarat for three consecutive terms and transformed it into one of India's most dynamic state economies.

When Narendra Modi arrived on the national stage, he arrived with something no Indian leader had carried in decades: a vision. Not just of better governance, or lower corruption, or faster growth — though he promised all of those. But a vision of a different India altogether. A New India. An India that could stand alongside the world's great nations not as a developing country humbly requesting recognition, but as an economic and civilisational powerhouse demanding it.

The timing was not accidental. The ground had shifted beneath everyone's feet. The internet had arrived. A young population — half of India under twenty-five — had grown up with smartphones and social media and a very different sense of what was possible. They were not willing to adjust and wait the way their parents had. They wanted more. And Modi, uniquely among Indian politicians of his generation, understood that hunger and spoke directly to it.



The Vision And The Gap

The New India vision is real. The infrastructure push — roads, railways, airports, digital connectivity — has been genuinely transformative. The focus on healthcare, on rural development, on a modern fighting force, on education reform: these are not cosmetic. They matter enormously. India in 2024 is a fundamentally different country from India in 2004 — and much of that difference is visible, measurable, and consequential.

But I — who have watched this transformation from both sides, as the son of a man who built enterprises from nothing in rural Maharashtra, and as someone who has lived and studied and worked beyond India's borders — am asking a harder question.

You can build roads. You can lay fibre optic cables. You can construct airports and launch satellites. But who is going to change the mind?

Seventy-five years of being told to adjust. Of 'chalta hai' — it'll do, it's fine, don't make trouble. Of watching corruption treated not as an outrage but as a weather condition: unfortunate, unavoidable, something you work around rather than dismantle. Of a culture that mistakes endurance for wisdom and calls cynicism realism.

New infrastructure delivered to an old mindset does not produce a New India. It produces a shinier version of the old one.

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So here is the question this book is built around: If the New India is to be genuinely new — not just in its roads and its rankings but in its people, its culture, its sense of what is possible — then who is responsible for that transformation?

The answer, which Subhash Deshmukh arrived at long before the phrase 'New India' was coined, is both simple and demanding.

Every single one of us.



Why This Book Exists

We live in an age of tremendous noise.

Social media hands us a megaphone and mistakes it for wisdom. We follow people with a million followers who have never built anything. We receive expert guidance on WhatsApp from people who have never had skin in the game. We are told, endlessly, what India needs — by people who have never tried to give India anything themselves.

This book is none of that.

This is the view from inside. From Solapur. From Wadala — a village so small that most maps don't bother to mark it. From a family that built enterprises from almost nothing, lost some, rebuilt others, and kept going anyway. From a life lived at the intersection of rural Maharashtra and the emerging new India — close enough to the ground to smell

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the soil, and far enough away to see the extraordinary opportunity that most people standing in the middle of it cannot see at all.

That opportunity is this: India is on the verge of its greatest entrepreneurial awakening. And most of us are not ready for it.



THE LEGACY THAT BUILT THIS MANIFESTO

My father, Subhash Deshmukh, was what the startup world today would call a serial entrepreneur. He would not have understood that phrase. He would have simply said: I kept trying things.

A kirana store. A tyre shop. A dairy with two cows. A check dam built for eight hundred rupees. And then — with his elder brother and with the audacity of two men who knew nothing about the sugar industry except that it existed — the construction of the largest privately owned sugar factory in Solapur. Recognised in the Limca Book of World Records.

He was practicing Corporate Social Responsibility before it became a corporate buzzword. He was an Angel Investor — funding the dreams of people who had no other access to capital — before I had even heard the term. He stepped into politics not because he sought power but because there was a gap between what the people needed and what was being offered, and the gap offended him.

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But the thing he said that has stayed with me most — the thing that is at the very heart of this book — was this: Government alone cannot bring about transformation. Transformation is the responsibility of every citizen. And if a citizen has the power to bring about change, they have the obligation to use it.

I am his son. This book is his inheritance, made into action.



What This Manifesto Demands Of You

Let us be direct with each other. From this first page.

This is not a book you read and then put down with a pleasant feeling about India's future. This is not inspiration dressed up as analysis. This is not a call for the government to do more, for politicians to be better, for the system to fix itself.

This is a call to action. An unambiguous one. And it is addressed to you — whoever you are, wherever you are, at whatever point on the spectrum between struggling and thriving you currently find yourself.

This is not a clarion call only to the big industrialist to loosen his CSR purse strings. It is a call to the last man and woman in the most rural village. To the IT worker with a high disposable income. To every citizen who can be the cause of even a small change.

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Think about what small actually means.

A roof sponsored for a school that currently teaches children in the open air. A computer placed in a village where children have never touched a keyboard. A tap installed in a community that still walks two kilometres for clean water. A sewing machine handed to a woman who has the skill and the hunger to start a tailoring business but not the two thousand rupees to buy her first machine.

None of these are grand gestures. None require a press release or a CSR report or a photo opportunity. All of them change a life. All of them change a village. Enough of them, multiplied across the width and depth of this country, change a nation.

India does not need more observers. It does not need more people who understand the problem with great sophistication and considerable regret. What India needs — what it has always needed — are builders. People who look at a problem and see not a reason to despair, but a reason to start.

My father started with dead chickens and a damaged eye. He ended up building factories, funding entrepreneurs, shaping policy, and leaving behind an institution that continues to incubate dreams and create livelihoods in the very region where he once had none.

If that is possible from Wadala, thirty kilometres outside a town most of India has never heard of — what is possible from wherever you are standing right now?

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That question is not rhetorical. This book is your invitation to answer it.



HOW TO READ THESE PAGES

The chapters that follow will take you through the full geography of what it means to build enterprise in modern India. Through the story of a family, a town, a state, and a nation at the hinge point of its history. Through the honest accounting of what entrepreneurship demands and what it returns. Through the frameworks, the resources, the programs, and the pathways that exist right now — that most people who need them don't know about.

But more than information, this book carries a conviction.

The conviction that the next wave of India's transformation will not be led by the already-privileged in already-powerful cities. It will rise — as my father rose — from the unmapped villages. The second-tier towns. The forgotten junctions. The places that don't appear in investment prospectuses.

It will rise from exactly where you are.

Modi has given India a vision. My father gave his family a philosophy. This book attempts to give you both — and then asks the only question that matters: what will you build with them?



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That is my dream

*That is my goal
I know not Impossible
For I have dismissed that notion
I know What is Possible
My Dream is Possible
I live to make it Possible
Right here in Maharashtra.*

**Rohan Deshmukh:
Solapur, Maharashtra**

BORN IN SOLAPUR, BUILT FOR BHARAT

Why Your Zip Code Doesn't Define Your Destiny

There is a particular kind of silence that settles over a railway station at dawn.

Not the absence of sound. Something deeper. A held breath before the world remembers how to move again.

I grew up in that silence. In Solapur. Watching the first trains arrive before the sun had fully decided to rise.

Solapur is not famous. It will not appear in tourist brochures. It will not feature in glossy magazine articles about India's rising cities. It is simply there — a town that textile mills built, that beedis kept alive, that the railway connected to the rest of a country too vast to fully comprehend.

If you have never heard of Solapur, you are forgiven. Most of India hasn't either.

But that is precisely why it matters.

Because Solapur is real India.

Not the India of grand narratives and government slogans. Not the India of startup unicorns and luxury high-rises. But the India where millions actually live. Working. Struggling. Hoping. Building something from nothing because nothing is all they were given to start with.

The Geography of Conscience

I used to stand at the railway station as a child, watching people arrive and depart.

Gujaratis traveling south with their sharp business sense and sharper bargaining skills. Tamilians heading north with their engineering degrees and quiet determination. Bengalis moving west with their poetry still intact despite everything the world had tried to take from them.

Each train carried not just passengers. Each train carried entire worlds. Languages that had never met before. Traditions that had no reason to mix. Dreams that had been deferred so many times they had become something else entirely.

What struck me then — and haunts me still — is this: they were all moving.

Some looked exhausted. As though movement itself had become a burden too heavy to carry. Some looked hopeful. Their eyes still bright with the particular belief that the next city, the next opportunity, would finally be the one that changed everything. Some looked lost. As though they had been moving so long they had forgotten why they started.

But they were moving.

And in a country where stagnation can feel like fate, movement — even directionless movement — is a form of prayer.

Solapur taught me something fundamental before I had words for it.

Movement is not just physical displacement from one place to another. Movement is the refusal to accept that where you are is where you must remain. Movement is the conviction that your circumstances are not your destiny. Movement is hope made visible. Made kinetic. Made real through the simple act of taking one more step when everything in you wants to stop.

The town itself existed because of movement. The textile mills that once hummed with the collective energy of thousands of workers. Their hands moving in synchronized rhythm. Creating fabric from thread. Creating livelihoods from labor. Creating dignity from the simple act of showing up day after day.

The beedi industry kept even more hands busy. Rolling tobacco leaves into thin cylinders sold across India. Work

that destroyed lungs slowly but fed families immediately. The kind of devil's bargain that poverty forces millions to accept — without ever calling it a choice.

The railway line connected our small corner of Maharashtra to the larger story of India. Bringing goods and people and ideas that transformed us whether we were ready or not.

Languages didn't just coexist in Solapur. They married. Had children. Created something new.

Marathi mixed with Hindi until you couldn't tell where one ended and the other began. Hindi embraced Urdu until the boundaries between them became meaningless. Urdu found Kannada and they discovered they had more in common than either expected.

We didn't call it diversity. We didn't have that vocabulary yet. We called it life. And we lived it without self-consciousness. Without the performative tolerance that comes from being told tolerance is a virtue — rather than simply the default setting of humans who see other humans as human.

A Muslim family would celebrate Ganesh Chaturthi. Not as a gesture toward communal harmony. But because their Hindu neighbours had always included them and it would have been rude not to participate. A Hindu family would send sweets during Eid. Not as a political statement about secularism. But because their Muslim friends had children and those children liked sweets and that was reason enough.

The temple bells and the azaan shared the same morning air. Nobody fought about it. The very idea of fighting about it

would have seemed absurd. Like fighting about whether rain should fall or birds should sing.

This was Solapur's first profound lesson, though I wouldn't understand its profundity until much later.

Unity is not something you build through policy initiatives or government programs or carefully crafted mission statements. Unity is what happens when people are too busy living together to waste time theorizing about whether they should. Unity is not taught in classrooms. Unity is not mandated by law. Unity is lived in streets. Practiced in homes. Passed down through generations who never thought to call it anything other than normal.

But my story — the story that would eventually lead to this manifesto, to this moment, to you reading these words — doesn't truly begin in Solapur town.

It begins thirty kilometers away.

In a village so small and insignificant that cartographers routinely forget to mark it on maps.

Wadala.

A place where roads were suggestions rather than guarantees. Where electricity came and went like an unreliable friend who promised to visit but rarely showed up. Where dreams were considered dangerous luxuries that poor people couldn't afford to indulge.

Yet it was from this forgotten corner — from this unmapped

village, from this soil that gave nothing easily — that my father emerged.

His name was Subhash Deshmukh.

And his emergence — his transformation from a boy with an injured eye and no prospects into a man who would build factories and fund dreams and change the economic trajectory of an entire region — asks a question that should disturb every comfortable person reading this:

**If greatness can rise from Wadala, why hasn't it risen
from you?**

When Pain Becomes Purpose

My father was seventeen when a cricket ball struck his eye.

The force was enough to shatter not just his vision but his entire imagined future.

Seventeen. An age when most boys today are choosing college streams based on placement statistics. Worrying about entrance exam rankings. Scrolling through social media to see what their peers are achieving. Living in a perpetual state of comparative anxiety that measures success in likes and shares and carefully curated images of lives that don't actually exist outside the frame.

Subhash at seventeen was deciding how to survive with one damaged eye, no education, and no clear path forward.

The injury was severe enough. But what made it catastrophic was the context.

No medical facilities in the village. No money for proper treatment even if it had been available. No insurance. No safety net. No benevolent organisation that swooped in to help bright young boys whose potential had been derailed by bad luck and a well-hit cricket ball.

That injury ended his formal education. But more than that — it ended the comfortable narrative that education leads to employment which leads to security which leads to a life where you don't worry about where the next meal comes from.

It stripped away every conventional path.

And it left him standing at seventeen with a simple, brutal truth: nobody was coming to save him.

Not the government. Not the education system. Not some distant relative with connections. Not fate or karma or cosmic justice.

The world didn't care about his story. The world didn't care about his injury. The world didn't care that he was only seventeen and shouldn't have to face this kind of existential reckoning yet.

The world only asked one question. It asks this question of every human who has ever lived.

What can you do?

His first answer: I can work in a poultry factory.

Stop here. Stop reading as a passive consumer of someone else's story. Actually imagine this.

Not as an abstract concept. Not as a dramatic plot point in an inspirational tale. As a lived reality that a human being endured day after day after day.

A poultry factory in rural Maharashtra in the 1970s. Dark because electricity was expensive and dead chickens don't need light. Cramped because space cost money and workers' comfort didn't generate revenue. The smell — God, the smell — of death and decay and chemicals that were supposed to mask the death and decay but only made everything worse.

Blood on every surface because chickens don't die cleanly and efficiency matters more than dignity. Feathers floating in the air like some perverse snow that clung to your skin and clothes and hair. Cracked eggshells underfoot. Sharp enough to cut through cheap shoes. Sticky enough to slow every step. Heat that made you sweat before you even started working. A humid hell where breathing itself became labor.

This was not a job in any meaningful sense. This was not an entry-level position on a career ladder that led somewhere better.

This was survival in its most stripped-down, undignified form.

This was what happens when the alternative to degrading work is no work. And no work means no food. And no food means slow starvation for you and everyone who depends on you.

But something happened in that factory.

Something my grandfather observed but couldn't articulate. Something that only became clear in hindsight when enough time had passed to see the pattern.

When Subhash left home for that job, he left as a boy. Scared. Uncertain. Still dependent on others to tell him what to do and how to be. When he returned months later, he returned as a man. Not because he had aged chronologically. Because something fundamental had shifted in how he understood himself and the world.

What transforms a boy into a man?

Not age. I have met forty-year-olds who remain perpetually adolescent, waiting for someone to give them permission to become who they're supposed to be. Not money. I have met wealthy men who are spiritually impoverished — their bank accounts full but their characters empty. Not education. I have met people with advanced degrees who have never truly faced life. Who have learned to navigate systems but not suffering. Who can quote philosophy but don't know how to endure pain with dignity.

A boy becomes a man when he learns — really learns, in his bones and blood and marrow — that nobody is coming to save him.

When the comfortable illusion of eventual rescue finally dies.

When he understands that if he doesn't save himself, he simply won't be saved.

This isn't cynicism. This isn't despair.

This is clarity. This is the beginning of agency. Of responsibility. Of the particular kind of strength that only comes from standing alone and discovering you can still stand.

The Education of Failure

My father left the poultry factory with something more valuable than the wages he'd earned.

He left with the knowledge that he could endure. That he could face degrading circumstances and not be degraded. That he could do terrible work and not become terrible. That survival was a skill he possessed. And possessing that skill meant other skills were possible too.

So he became a businessman.

Though that word makes it sound more intentional and strategic than it was. He didn't have capital. Not enough to rent a proper shop. Barely enough to buy initial inventory. He didn't have a business plan because business plans existed in a world he had never accessed and that had certainly never acknowledged his existence. He didn't have a

mentor. He didn't have a network. He didn't have the vocabulary for any of this because that vocabulary belonged to English-language business magazines and MBA programs and conferences he would never be invited to attend.

What he had was this: the courage to try when failure seemed not just possible but probable. The willingness to look stupid. The capacity to begin again after ending badly.

These sound like small things.

They are everything.

They are the difference between people who dream and people who build.

First came a kirana shop. A single room with shelves holding the essentials that villagers needed. Rice, dal, oil, sugar, salt, biscuits for children, soap for washing clothes, matches for lighting stoves. The shop did okay. Not spectacularly. Not memorably. Just okay — in the way that keeping your head above water is okay when the alternative is drowning.

He learned about inventory management without knowing that's what it was called. He learned about customer relationships because in a village, every transaction is also a social interaction and every social interaction can become a transaction. He learned about cash flow because running out of money at the wrong moment meant the shop closed and dreams died.

Then he thought: why not try something else?

So he opened a tyre shop. Selling tyres to farmers. Repairing punctures because in rural India, people repair everything until repair becomes impossible — and then they repair it one more time. Getting his hands perpetually dirty with grease and rubber because clean hands were a luxury that business ownership didn't afford. Learning about margins. Learning about competition. Learning that customers have choices and choosing you requires giving them a reason beyond mere proximity.

Then he bought two cows and started a dairy. Waking before dawn to milk them because cows operate on their own schedule and don't care about your sleep requirements. Delivering fresh milk to houses across the village. Learning that business is repetition — showing up day after day even when you don't feel like it. Even when it's cold or raining or you're sick. Even when every part of you wants to quit.

Do you see the pattern?

He wasn't hitting home runs. He wasn't building unicorns. He wasn't creating disruption or achieving scale or generating the kind of dramatic success that makes for good LinkedIn posts.

He was learning how to bat.

How to stand at the crease. How to watch the ball. How to defend when necessary and attack when possible. How to stay in the game long enough to eventually score.

Each small business was a classroom where the tuition was paid in failure and the lessons were taught through

consequence. Each modest success was encouragement to try again. Proof that effort could translate into outcome even if the translation wasn't always clean or direct. Each failure — and there were failures, ventures that collapsed, investments that disappeared, plans that proved to be fantasies — was data. Information about how the world actually worked versus how he'd imagined it worked.

Then one day someone offered him eight hundred rupees to help build a check dam.

Eight hundred rupees.

Today that's what you might spend on a decent dinner at a restaurant you'll forget by next week. Back then, for my father, it was a fortune. But more than the money — more than the immediate financial relief — it was the work itself that changed everything.

He learned construction. Not from textbooks or training programs. From doing. How to read land and understand water flow. How to manage labor — which means managing humans with their own needs and moods and motivations. How to negotiate with contractors who would cheat you if they could. How to see a project from conception through completion. How to hold the vision steady even when immediate circumstances made the vision seem impossible.

That eight hundred rupee check dam didn't just pay him money.

It paid him knowledge.

And knowledge — unlike money which can be spent or stolen or lost to inflation — knowledge compounds. Knowledge builds on itself. Knowledge transforms how you see every subsequent opportunity. Knowledge is capital that nobody can take from you and that increases in value the more you use it.

The Philosophy of Impossible Things

Years accumulated. My father kept learning. Kept trying. Kept building.

Some ventures succeeded. Some failed. Some existed in that ambiguous space between success and failure where you're not quite drowning but you're definitely not swimming with confidence. But he kept moving. And movement — remember — is hope made kinetic.

Then came the idea that should have remained just an idea.

The kind of audacious, ridiculous, almost certainly doomed idea that sensible people dismiss without serious consideration.

My father and my uncle decided to build a sugar factory.

The problem was elegantly simple: neither of them knew anything about sugar.

Not sugar production. Not sugar processing. Not the machinery required or the chemistry involved or the supply chain logistics or the quality control measures or the regulatory requirements. They had never been inside a

sugar factory. They had no technical knowledge, no industry connections, no understanding of what they were attempting.

They were attempting to build Solapur's largest privately-owned sugar factory with nothing but belief and borrowed money.

In rational terms, this was insanity.

Banks looked at their proposal and saw only risk — catastrophic, obvious risk that no competent financial institution would touch. Anyone with actual knowledge of the sugar industry would have explained, probably kindly, why this could not possibly work. The odds of success were infinitesimal.

But here's what my father and uncle knew that others didn't.

If you don't know how to do something, you find someone who does.

Not 'find' as in hire the most qualified expert with the most impressive credentials, because they couldn't afford that person. 'Find' as in identify someone who is willing to try. Someone whose ambition exceeds their current knowledge. Someone who understands that all expertise was once ignorance that refused to remain ignorant.

So they hired an engineer.

The engineer had one small complication: he had never built a sugar factory either.

Let me repeat that. Because the sheer audacity of it deserves to be stated clearly.

Two entrepreneurs who knew nothing about sugar hired an engineer who had never built a sugar factory — to build a sugar factory.

On paper, in any rational analysis, this was three people about to lose everything.

But this was not paper.

This was belief. Pure, irrational, magnificent belief in the possibility that learning could happen fast enough. That mistakes could be corrected quickly enough. That determination could overcome the gap between ambition and capability.

This was the philosophy of impossible things: that impossible is often just a word that comfortable people use to avoid uncomfortable effort.

They built that factory.

Day by day. Brick by brick. Problem by problem. Mistake by mistake. Learning by learning.

There were moments — many moments — when the machinery wouldn't work and nobody could figure out why. Days when workers were ready to quit because the project seemed cursed, doomed, impossible. Nights when my father and uncle sat together in exhausted silence, wondering if they had made a catastrophic error in judgment. If they had

risked everything for nothing. If they would be remembered as fools who overreached rather than pioneers who dared.

But they didn't stop.

They learned. They adapted. They improvised. They asked questions until they found people with answers. They made mistakes and then figured out how not to make those same mistakes again. They faced problems that seemed insurmountable — until the morning they weren't. Until some combination of persistence and luck and accumulated learning produced a breakthrough.

And slowly, impossibly, the factory rose.

Started producing sugar. Employed hundreds of people from surrounding villages. Generated crores in revenue. Became part of the Limca Book of Records — that peculiar Indian institution that documents achievements too specific for international recognition but too impressive to ignore.

People called it a miracle.

It wasn't a miracle.

Miracles are things that happen without human agency — divine interventions that require no effort from those who receive them. This was the inevitable result of courage meeting persistence. This was what happens when people refuse to accept that their ignorance is permanent. When they treat every gap in knowledge as a problem to be solved rather than a reason to quit.

The Question That Should Haunt You

The most important part of this story is not that they built a factory.

It's not about the Limca Book of Records or the revenue generated or the people employed.

The most important part is that they dared to build what they'd never built before. They dared to step into the unknown without a map, without a guarantee, without even knowing if success was possible. They dared to look foolish. To risk failure. To become examples of hubris if things went wrong.

How many of us are stuck right now because we're waiting to 'know enough'?

How many dreams have died in the gap between wanting to do something and feeling qualified to do it? How many businesses were never started, books never written, organisations never founded, movements never launched — because someone somewhere decided they weren't ready yet? Weren't expert enough yet. Weren't credentialed enough yet. Weren't perfect enough yet.

My father looked foolish. He made mistakes — terrible mistakes, expensive mistakes, mistakes that cost money and time and credibility. He failed at things. He had to apologise for overconfidence and admit ignorance and ask for help from people who had every right to say no.

But he kept moving.

And movement, in the end, is what separates those who dream from those who do.

This raises a profound moral question about our society.

What does it mean that banks will lend millions to someone with the right credentials and connections, but won't lend thousands to someone with character and determination? What does this say about what we value? About how we define risk? About who we believe deserves opportunity?

The formal financial system looked at my father and saw only deficits — no collateral, no credit history, no degree from a prestigious institution. They couldn't see what actually mattered: the capacity to endure, the willingness to learn, the refusal to quit.

Is our system designed to find and fund potential? Or to protect existing privilege? Are we creating opportunities for the talented and determined — or merely reproducing the advantages of those who already have them?

These are not rhetorical questions. These are questions that should disturb comfortable people. Questions that should make those of us with access and resources and platforms examine what we're doing with them — and whether we're part of the problem we claim to want to solve.

When Success Reveals Character

Success didn't change my father.

That sentence is easy to write but profound in its implications. Because success changes most people. Wealth typically doesn't make people more generous — it makes them more protective of what they have. Power usually doesn't increase empathy — it decreases it, because the powerful can insulate themselves from the suffering of others. Achievement often breeds arrogance rather than humility — because we love to believe we deserve what we've earned and others deserve what they lack.

But my father was different.

Success clarified him.

As the business grew and profits increased, his vision simultaneously expanded and sharpened. He started noticing things that wealth should have blinded him to but didn't. A farmer who couldn't afford to dig a borewell, watching his crops die every summer while his children watched their future die with them. A bright student who had to drop out of school because school fees — however modest — were still more than his family could afford. A young man with a real, viable, well-thought-out business idea but no capital to execute it and no access to the formal financial system that claimed to exist precisely to fund such ideas.

Banks wouldn't help these people. The farmer had no collateral because he'd already mortgaged his land for previous failed harvests. The student had no credit history because he'd never had credit — which is how systems trap people in poverty. No credit means no credit history means

no credit. A logical loop that feels like fate. The young entrepreneur had no guarantees, no track record, no family connections. The formal financial system saw them as risks — as liabilities, as probability calculations that didn't justify the investment.

But my father saw them as human beings.

He became the quiet angel investor of rural Maharashtra — decades before 'angel investor' became a term that Silicon Valley invented to describe wealthy people who fund startups for equity stakes and board seats and the possibility of ten-times returns. He didn't ask for equity. He didn't demand board seats. He didn't require detailed financial projections or exit strategies or any of the apparatus that professional investing requires.

He asked for one thing only: honesty.

'Try your best,' he would say. 'If it works, pay me back when you can. If it doesn't work, tell me what you learned so we're both wiser.'

This was not naivete. This was a sophisticated understanding of human nature and business reality. Not all ventures succeed. Not all people honour their commitments. The world is full of well-intentioned failures and occasional dishonest actors. My father knew this. He wasn't operating under some delusion that everyone is good and all investments pay off.

But he believed something deeper: that you can't build a community by refusing to invest in it. That you can't

complain about lack of entrepreneurship while simultaneously denying entrepreneurs the capital to attempt entrepreneurship. That if people only helped others when success was guaranteed, nothing would ever be built — because success is never guaranteed and guarantees are themselves usually illusions that comfortable people construct to avoid uncomfortable risk.

So he funded borewells for farmers who might never be able to repay him. Paid school fees for students who might never remember his name. Invested in business ideas that might fail spectacularly. Built check dams when villages had no water. Funded education when children had no schools. Supported farmers when droughts destroyed crops and hope simultaneously.

This wasn't Corporate Social Responsibility — that sanitised term that companies use to describe the fraction of profits they're willing to donate in exchange for tax benefits and positive publicity.

This was simply responsibility. Practiced quietly. Without press releases. Without photo opportunities. Without any expectation of recognition beyond the knowledge that he had done what he could with what he had.

The Terrible Choice of Politics

Then came politics.

I can feel you recoiling already.

Politics — that word that now means corruption and hypocrisy and the death of ideals. Politics — that arena where good people supposedly become compromised and principles supposedly die. Politics — that profession that parents tell their children to avoid if they want to maintain their integrity.

But here's what we've forgotten.

Politics is not inherently corrupt. Politics is simply the arena where we make collective decisions about resource allocation and power distribution and what kind of society we're trying to build. The word itself comes from 'polis' — the Greek term for city-state, for community, for the collective space we share. Politics became corrupt because good people abandoned it. Not because it required corruption.

My father didn't enter politics for power or prestige or the particular kind of petty status that comes from having a title and the ability to cut ribbons at inauguration ceremonies.

He entered politics because the people asked him to.

And he couldn't find it in his heart to refuse them.

The farmers trusted him because he had stood with them during droughts — when standing with them meant losing money. The workers respected him because he had created dignified employment, not exploitation disguised as opportunity. The youth believed in him because he had funded their education and businesses when believing in them was considered financially irrational.

When they collectively asked him to represent them — to be their voice in rooms where decisions were made that affected their lives, to translate their needs into policy and their suffering into action — he stepped forward. Not because he wanted the position. But because refusing felt like a betrayal of everything he'd built. The relationships. The trust. The mutual commitment to each other's wellbeing.

A man who belongs to the people cannot belong only to his family.

I learned this slowly. Sometimes painfully. As I grew up.

There were nights when my father wasn't home for dinner because a farmer needed help negotiating with moneylenders. Festivals when he couldn't celebrate with us because a village needed water more urgently than we needed his presence. Birthdays and anniversaries when his chair remained empty because someone, somewhere, needed him in a way that we — comfortable, secure, loved — did not.

As a child, I resented this.

I was angry that everyone else seemed to have more claim on his time than his own family did. I couldn't understand why strangers' needs should come before ours.

But that resentment came from a place of privilege. The privilege of not understanding what it means to have no one who will help you. No one who believes in you. No one who will risk anything for your wellbeing. I was angry because I'd

never been that desperate. And inexperience bred selfishness masquerading as righteous indignation.

Today I understand.

He wasn't choosing them over us. He was showing us what service really means. Not the convenient kind that costs nothing and demands nothing. But the uncomfortable kind that requires sacrifice and generates no applause. He was teaching us that responsibility isn't something you can schedule around your comfort. That need doesn't wait for convenient moments. That if you claim to care about people, you have to mean it when it's inconvenient.

The Inheritance That Matters

The values my father lived became my inheritance.

Not money, though there was some. Not property, though there was some of that too. Not contacts or connections or the particular kind of social capital that privileged families pass down to ensure their children remain privileged.

Values. Principles. A framework for making decisions when no decision feels easy or obvious.

Humility in success: when the factory generated record profits, he didn't buy a mansion to display wealth or a luxury car to signal status. He built more check dams. Funded more schools. Helped more farmers. He understood something that most successful people forget — that success is not proof of superiority but simply the result of effort meeting

opportunity. And opportunity itself is often a matter of luck. The luck of being born in the right place at the right time with the right capacities that happen to be valued by the market at that particular moment.

Resilience in struggle: when droughts hit hard and the economy contracted and revenues disappeared, he didn't abandon the community to protect profits. He stood with them. Sometimes this meant putting the business at risk. Sometimes it meant personal financial loss. But he understood that you can't claim to care about people only when caring is convenient. Only when it costs nothing. Only when market conditions permit generosity.

Service as the highest form of leadership: he didn't lead from a corner office with air conditioning and a secretary screening his calls and PowerPoint presentations that turned human beings into data points. He led from the fields. From the factory floor. From the village squares where actual life happened. He led by showing up. By being present. By demonstrating through action rather than announcing through words.

These values — humility, resilience, service — became the invisible architecture of our family.

We were not just a joint family in the traditional sense of multiple generations living under one roof and sharing expenses. We were a family jointed by values that ran deeper than blood. That persisted even when proximity didn't. That defined who we were more than any external marker of identity or status ever could.

Success didn't make us arrogant because we'd seen how much luck played a role in success. Power didn't make us cruel because we'd experienced powerlessness and remembered what it felt like. Wealth didn't make us selfish because we understood that wealth creates obligation, not just opportunity — the obligation to circulate it, to deploy it, to use it as a tool for building rather than merely accumulating.

The Question You Cannot Escape

Now let me turn to you.

Because this is not a history lesson. This is not a biography. This is not an exercise in nostalgia.

This is a mirror. This is a question. This is a demand for self-examination that you cannot deflect or defer.

Where did YOU come from?

Not geographically. I don't care what city name appears on your identity documents. I mean: what soil formed you? What struggle shaped you into who you are today? What person believed in you when you didn't believe in yourself? What failure taught you that you could survive failure? What pain revealed your capacity for endurance?

Because here's a truth that most people don't want to confront.

You cannot build New India if you forget where you came from. You cannot lead others if you haven't reckoned with

your own origin story. You cannot demand change if you haven't examined what made you comfortable with the status quo.

Your origin story is not about pride. Not about being able to say 'look at how far I've come' or 'see how much I've overcome.' Pride is cheap and comparison is even cheaper. Your origin story is about perspective. About understanding the foundation you're building on. About recognising what shaped your values and assumptions and blind spots. About knowing where your empathy comes from and where it stops.

So I'm going to ask you to do something uncomfortable. Right now. Not later. Not when you have more time. Not when you feel more ready.

Now.

Exercise 1.1: Where Did You Come From?

Write it. Not in your head where thoughts remain vague and unexamined. On paper. Where they become concrete and undeniable.

Your town or village. Your family's economic situation — not in euphemisms like 'middle class' but in actual terms of what resources you had and didn't have. What opportunities were available and unavailable. What doors were open and closed. Your first real struggle — not the manufactured difficulties of competitive exams, but actual struggle that tested whether you would break. Your first lesson about how

the world really works. About how power operates. About who matters and who doesn't.

Be honest. Nobody else needs to read this. This is between you and the person you're becoming. Write about the things you usually hide. Write about the advantages you pretend you didn't have. Write about the disadvantages you've overcome and the ones you're still carrying. Write until you understand yourself better than you did before you started.

Exercise 1.2: What Shaped You?

Was it a teacher who saw potential in you that you couldn't see yourself? What did they see? Why did they bother when they could have just processed you through the system like every other student?

Was it a failure that knocked you down and taught you that getting knocked down doesn't mean staying down? What exactly did you learn from that failure beyond the obvious lesson?

Was it a moment of clarity when everything suddenly made sense? What became clear — and why did it take that moment for clarity to arrive?

Was it a punch in the gut — literal or metaphorical — that woke you from sleepwalking through life? Who or what delivered that punch? Why did it land when so many other warnings didn't? Write it down with as much detail as you can reconstruct. The details matter because the details are where truth lives.

Exercise 1.3: Which Values Will You Carry Forward?

From your parents, who gave you more than they had and probably sacrificed more than you know. What specific values did they embody? Not the values they talked about. The ones they lived. The principles they demonstrated through action — especially when those actions cost them something.

From your village or neighbourhood or community, where you learned about belonging and obligation and what it means to be part of something larger than yourself. What did that place teach you about how humans should treat each other?

From your pain — the experiences that hurt but didn't destroy you, that left scars but also wisdom. What did pain teach you that comfort never could?

Which values are non-negotiable? Which principles will you never compromise, even if compromise would be profitable or comfortable or expedient? Write them down. Make them explicit. Because implicit values are easy to betray when circumstances pressure you. Explicit values create accountability. And accountability creates integrity.

The Covenant You Must Make

These exercises are not optional.

They are not 'nice to do' or 'helpful if you have time' or supplementary activities for particularly motivated readers.

They are necessary in the way that foundations are necessary for buildings. You can skip them — free will exists — but if you skip them, everything that comes after will be built on nothing and will collapse when pressure arrives.

Because New India will not be built by people who forget their roots and pretend to be something they're not. New India will not be built by those who are ashamed of where they came from. Or who reconstruct their origin stories to make themselves sound more impressive — or more disadvantaged — depending on what the audience wants to hear.

New India will be built by people who remember their roots with clear eyes and grateful hearts. Who understand both the advantages they had and the obstacles they overcame. Who neither inflate their struggles nor minimise their privileges.

Your origin story is your power — the unique combination of experiences and influences that nobody else has, that makes your perspective valuable, that means you can see things others can't.

Your values are your compass — the principles that will guide you when the path becomes unclear, when everyone around you is compromising, when doing the right thing costs more than you wanted to pay.

Your roots are your rocket fuel — the foundation that will launch you higher than you imagined possible, because

people who know where they came from can never be accused of forgetting where they belong.

Subhash Deshmukh was a high-school dropout from an unmapped village.

He had one damaged eye. Zero resources. Every reason to give up. And not one single excuse to hide behind.

He built factories. He fed communities. He changed lives. He did this not despite having nothing — but almost because of it. Because having nothing taught him that waiting for something was a luxury he couldn't afford.

He never needed to be motivated. He never needed a manifesto. He never needed someone to write a book telling him what was possible.

He just built.

Now it's your turn: What exactly is stopping you?

Questions for Reflection

- Why does the author describe Solapur as "real India"?
- How did Subhash Deshmukh's struggles help shape his entrepreneurial mindset?
- The chapter says, "Your zip code doesn't define your destiny." What does this mean to you?
- What lesson can young entrepreneurs learn from

the sugar factory story, even though the founders had no prior experience?

- Describe one challenge from your own life that has made you stronger or changed your thinking.
- Identify one problem in your community that could become a business opportunity. How would you try to solve it?
- The chapter asks, "What exactly is stopping you?" What is one fear, excuse, or obstacle currently holding you back from pursuing your goals?

THE LOKMANGAL WAY

How a Cooperative Became a Cathedral of Trust

Let me tell you about a tortoise.

Not in the way you expect. This is not a fable with a tidy moral about slow and steady winning races. This is about choosing a symbol that the entire world dismisses as weak. As unambitious. As fundamentally inadequate for a world that has convinced itself that speed is the only thing that matters.

In an age obsessed with unicorns and disruption and hockey-stick growth curves, we chose a tortoise as our logo.

People thought we were joking. Some assumed we didn't understand modern business. A few were openly contemptuous — how could we compete with aggressive, fast-moving companies if we'd already declared ourselves slow?

But the tortoise knows something that most modern businesses have forgotten in their rush to scale and exit and generate returns for impatient investors.

The race isn't always to the swift.

The race is to those who keep moving when everything in them wants to stop. The race is to those who understand that arrival matters more than speed. That building something that lasts requires a different kind of ambition than building something that dazzles briefly before collapsing.

We chose the tortoise on purpose.

We chose it knowing exactly what it said about us. And we chose it anyway.

What We Built and Why It Matters

Lokmangal is a cooperative. Not a corporation.

That distinction might sound technical. Bureaucratic. Like the kind of detail only lawyers and accountants care about.

It is everything.

It is the difference between two fundamentally opposed philosophies about what business is FOR.

A corporation exists to maximize profit for shareholders — people who may never use the product, never interact with employees, never set foot in the communities where the business operates. Shareholders are distant, abstract, concerned primarily with quarterly returns and stock price

appreciation. Their relationship to the business is transactional. They invested capital. They expect returns. The business exists to generate those returns. If it fails to do so, they sell their shares and move on. No loyalty. No obligation. No relationship beyond the temporary alignment of financial interest.

A cooperative exists to maximize value for members — real people with real needs who depend on the organisation not for return on investment but for services that improve their daily lives. Members are not distant or abstract. They're your neighbours. Your relatives. People you see at the market and the temple and community gatherings. Their relationship to the cooperative is not transactional.

It is covenantal.

We're in this together. We rise or fall together. What benefits one of us benefits all of us. What hurts one of us hurts all of us.

Today, Lokmangal has over 150 branches spread across Maharashtra. Thousands of members who trust

us with their savings, their loans, their financial futures. Hundreds of employees who've built careers with us. Who stayed when more glamorous opportunities appeared elsewhere. Who chose meaning over money — because money alone doesn't sustain human beings over decades.

Crores in transactions flowing through our systems every year. Representing not abstract numbers but actual lives. Farmers purchasing seeds. Families paying school fees.

Entrepreneurs accessing credit to start businesses. Elderly people saving for security in a world that doesn't value the elderly.

But here is what makes us fundamentally different from every other financial institution you might think of.

We didn't build Lokmangal to get rich.

We didn't build it to impress investors or attract acquisition offers or see our names in business magazines. We built it to make others self-reliant. To create a system where ordinary people could access financial services with dignity rather than desperation. Where trust was the foundation — not an afterthought or a marketing slogan.

Our motto is 'Success Through Total Dedication.'

Most companies choose mottos that invoke aggression or speed or dominance. Faster. Stronger. First. Winning. We chose dedication — that old-fashioned virtue that modern business culture has discarded as insufficiently ambitious.

Because we understand something the modern world has forgotten.

Dedication is what remains when enthusiasm fades. When obstacles appear. When the initial excitement of beginning something new wears off and you're left with the boring, difficult, unglamorous work of actually building something that lasts.

The Heresy of Hiring for Character

Here's where most businesses commit their original sin.

The foundational error that corrupts everything that follows.

They hire for credentials.

For degrees from prestigious institutions. For 'experience,' which usually means someone has already done the exact job elsewhere and will probably leave for the next highest bidder. For keywords on resumes that can be scanned by algorithms — reducing human complexity to searchable data points.

We do the opposite.

And this opposition is not accidental or naive. It is a deliberate philosophical stance about what actually matters when you're building organisations and communities.

We hire for alignment before aptitude. We hire for attitude before altitude — before how high someone has already climbed on conventional ladders of success.

When someone walks into our office looking for employment, we don't immediately interrogate them about their marks or which college they attended or whether they can speak fluent English with the proper accent.

We ask different questions. Questions that reveal character rather than credentials.

Do you believe in service, or are you just looking for a salary to fund a lifestyle? Are you here to build something meaningful, or just to collect a paycheck until something better comes along? Do you see our members as numbers on a computer screen or as neighbours and fellow human beings whose wellbeing matters? Will you stay when things get hard — when targets aren't met, when the work becomes repetitive and unglamorous, when nobody is watching or applauding?

If the answers align — if there's genuine conviction behind the words, if the person understands they're applying to join something rather than merely accepting employment — we hire them.

Even if their resume doesn't impress by conventional standards. Even if their English isn't fluent. Even if they don't have the 'right' degree or the 'right' experience or the 'right' network.

Then we invest in them. Not just financially — though we pay fair wages — but humanly. We train them comprehensively, teaching not just the technical skills they need but the philosophy behind what we do and why it matters. We mentor them. We hand-hold them through initial mistakes and confusion, creating psychological safety where learning can happen without fear of punishment or humiliation.

Because here's what we understand that most companies don't.

Skills can be taught through training and practice and repetition.

Values cannot be taught. They must already exist in a person's heart — planted there by family or community or experience, growing roots that training can strengthen but never create from nothing.

Most companies do it backward. They hire people with impressive skills but questionable values. People who know how to execute tasks but don't care why those tasks matter or who they're serving. Then they act surprised when there's high attrition. When people leave for slightly higher salaries. When loyalty is nonexistent and culture feels hollow and transactional. When nobody seems emotionally invested in the organisation's success beyond their personal career advancement.

At Lokmangal, we do it right from the beginning — even when doing it right looks inefficient to outside observers. We hire people whose inner rhythm matches our mission. Whose values align with our principles. Whose character suggests they'll honour commitments even when it's inconvenient.

Then we give them the skills, the tools, the training, and the unwavering support they need to succeed. Not just in their jobs but in their lives. Because we understand that people who are struggling personally cannot show up fully professionally.

The Sacred Work of Seeing Potential

You know who we hire?

The people that the 'professional' world has rejected and discarded.

The people whose resumes get automatically filtered out by applicant tracking systems. The people who walk into job interviews already defeated because they know their credentials don't match what's typically required. The people who've been told — implicitly or explicitly — that they're not good enough, not educated enough, not polished enough, not professional enough.

The graduates who don't have 'market skills' as defined by corporate buzzwords and LinkedIn job postings. The diploma holders who don't speak English fluently and therefore get dismissed as unsuitable for 'professional environments' — even though professionalism has nothing to do with language and everything to do with how you treat people and honour commitments. The mothers who've never worked formal jobs and are told they're too old or too inexperienced or too far removed from the workforce to be valuable. The young men from small villages who've never seen a city, whose rough hands and simple clothes make recruiters judge them before they speak a single word.

These are the people the world calls 'unemployable.'

We reject that label with everything we have.

We don't reject them. We see them — really see them — as human beings with potential rather than as deficient resume entries. We believe in them when nobody else does. When they don't even believe in themselves. We place them in positions where they can flourish instead of forcing them into standardised roles that don't fit their actual capabilities.

And then something happens that business schools can't quite explain and corporate consultants can't replicate through process design.

Not magic in the supernatural sense.

Magic in the human sense. The sense of potential meeting genuine opportunity and creating outcomes that seemed impossible at the beginning.

Let me tell you about three people.

Three ordinary people who became something extraordinary — not because they were exceptional to begin with, but because someone chose to see them.

Maruti

He joined us as an office assistant.

The kind of basic, entry-level position that most people see as temporary. A stepping stone to something better, not a destination. He was quiet — to the point of being nearly invisible. Hardworking in a way that didn't draw attention. Curious in a way that most supervisors wouldn't notice unless they were paying careful attention.

We noticed.

We saw that his curiosity wasn't passive consumption of information. It was active engagement with underlying principles. He didn't just want to know what to do. He wanted to understand why it worked that way — and whether it could work better.

We gave him opportunities to learn beyond his job description. We sent him for training in finance even though it wasn't strictly necessary for an office assistant. We trusted him with bigger responsibilities incrementally. We watched how he handled them. We gave him space to succeed and to fail — because both are teachers if you're paying attention.

Today, Maruti is our Finance Manager.

Overseeing budgets and financial strategies. Managing a team. Making decisions that impact the entire organisation's fiscal health.

Not because he had an MBA from a prestigious business school. Not because he came from a wealthy family with connections. But because we saw his curiosity — and fed it.

Rani

Her story carries a different kind of power.

She joined us as a cashier. A young woman from a conservative family where women working outside the home was still controversial. Still required negotiation and reassurance and promises about safety and respectability.

She was nervous during her interview in a way that went beyond normal interview nerves. There was real fear. Fear about whether she could handle the responsibility. Fear about what people would say. Fear about disappointing people who'd taken a risk allowing her to work.

We believed in her when she didn't believe in herself.

We assured her family that she would be safe and treated with respect — understanding that her employment wasn't just about her but about whether other families in that community would allow their daughters and wives to work. We trained her patiently. Teaching not just the technical aspects of handling money and maintaining accounts, but also confidence and professional presence — intangible qualities that nobody teaches explicitly but that you absorb through modelling and encouragement.

We supported her through mistakes — because everyone makes mistakes, and punishing mistakes teaches people to hide them rather than learn from them. We mentored her, connecting her with experienced women who had walked similar paths and could offer wisdom earned through their own struggles.

Today, Rani is a Senior Branch Head.

Managing a team of fifteen people. Making strategic decisions about operations and customer service. Mentoring other young women who remind her of herself years ago.

Think about that. One decision to see a frightened young woman. One decision to believe before the results proved we

should. And a life — and many lives after hers — transformed completely.

Sachin Jadhav

Perhaps the most remarkable story.

Remarkable not because the others aren't remarkable — but because this one illustrates something fundamental about what leadership development actually means.

He joined us as a trainee officer. Fresh out of pre-degree with a piece of paper that proved he could pass exams but said nothing about whether he could actually do anything useful. No real-world experience. Lots of energy — the kind of enthusiastic energy that can be channeled productively or can dissipate into chaos depending on how it's managed.

Many organisations would have constrained him. Put him through rigid training protocols, if at all. Made him follow established procedures without deviation. Treated him as a cog that needed to be shaped to fit existing machinery.

We took a different approach.

We saw his energy as potential fuel. Not as something dangerous that needed to be contained and controlled. We channeled it constructively — giving him challenging assignments that stretched his capabilities without breaking him entirely. We gave him significant responsibilities earlier than conventional wisdom would recommend. We let him fail at some initiatives because failure is the most reliable

teacher if you create an environment where failure doesn't mean punishment.

We helped him stand back up when he fell.

We celebrated his successes without letting him become arrogant — because early success can be more dangerous than early failure if it breeds the kind of confidence that stops listening and learning. We corrected his mistakes without destroying his confidence — understanding that the goal is growth, not perfection.

Today, this young man who joined us as a trainee officer with minimal experience and maximum enthusiasm is our CEO.

A trainee officer became the Chief Executive Officer.

Not through family connections. Not through political maneuvering. Not through lucky breaks or any of the usual explanations for rapid advancement. Through genuine growth. Demonstrated capability. Earned trust.

Because we believed in him before the results proved we should. Because we invested in him even when investing seemed risky. Because we placed him where he could grow into his potential rather than forcing him into a predetermined role.

Three people. Three lives that the world had undervalued or overlooked entirely. Three transformations that happened not because of some grand institutional program or carefully

designed talent management system — but because someone chose to see them.

How many Marutis are working in your organisation right now, invisible?

How many Rani's are too afraid to show you what they're capable of?

How many Sachins are being squeezed into roles that will never let them breathe?

The Language of Trust

Here's something that most 'modern' and 'progressive' businesses get catastrophically wrong in their quest to appear sophisticated and globally connected.

They worship English.

As if linguistic ability correlates with professional competence. As if the language you dream in is less valid than the language an MBA program is conducted in. If you can't speak English fluently with the right accent and the right idioms and the right cultural references, you're dismissed. Labelled as unprofessional. Unsuitable for corporate environments. Someone who doesn't belong in the modern economy.

We rejected that absurdity from the beginning.

At Lokmangal, our primary working language is Marathi — the language of Maharashtra, the language our members speak at home and in markets and at community gatherings,

the language that carries cultural weight and historical meaning beyond mere communication.

This choice was not about nostalgia. Not about regional pride. Not about resistance to globalisation.

This choice was about understanding something fundamental about trust and human connection.

When a farmer walks into our branch after a long day in the fields — worried about a loan payment or seeking advice on a financial decision that could determine whether his family eats well this year — he doesn't want to hear English. He doesn't want to navigate a conversation in a language he half-understands, where he has to guess at meanings and nod along to things he doesn't fully comprehend.

He wants to hear his language.

The words his grandmother used. The phrases that carry emotional resonance beyond literal translation. The tone that conveys respect and understanding and genuine human connection.

Trust is built in mother tongues.

This isn't romantic sentiment. This is practical reality. Trust requires comprehension. Comprehension requires linguistic comfort. When you speak to someone in a language they're still learning, there's always a gap between what you mean and what they understand. Always a possibility for miscommunication. Always a distance that can't be fully closed.

But when you speak to someone in their mother tongue — comprehension is immediate. Nuance survives. Emotion is conveyed. The full humanity of both parties is present in the conversation.

Hindi is absolutely welcome at Lokmangal. English is not a barrier for those comfortable with it. But Marathi is our foundation because we don't serve abstract 'customers' or faceless 'clients' or demographic segments defined by income brackets and spending patterns.

We serve communities.

Real people with real names. Real families. Real dreams. Real fears.

And communities speak their own language. Respecting that language is respecting them.

When Presence Becomes Leadership

When I became Chairman of Lokmangal, I inherited not just organisational authority but a profound responsibility to people who had trusted my family for decades.

I could have done what many leaders do. Settled into a comfortable office. Relied on reports and metrics and carefully curated presentations. Made decisions from a comfortable distance based on data that reduces human complexity to numbers and charts. Nobody would have criticised me for it. That's how leadership typically functions

in modern organisations — from the top down, from distance, from abstraction.

But I did something different.

I went everywhere. Literally.

Not metaphorically. Not through carefully staged visits where everything is prepared in advance and you only see what people want you to see. I physically traveled to over 150 branches in six months. Showing up unannounced. Sitting with every team member I could find. Sharing my personal phone number with everyone — from branch managers to cleaning staff. Understanding that hierarchy shouldn't prevent communication. That the most important information often comes from people at the bottom who actually see what's happening — not from people at the top who report what they think their superiors want to hear.

I listened more than I spoke.

Which is harder than it sounds. Because leaders are trained to speak. To answer. To solve. To demonstrate competence through confident assertions. Listening feels passive, feels like weakness, feels like it's not 'doing' anything. But listening is the most powerful act of leadership I know. Because you cannot lead what you don't understand. And you cannot understand what you refuse to hear.

I asked questions about their experiences. Their challenges. Their ideas for improvement. Their frustrations with systems and processes that didn't work as well as they should. I learned about their families — because you can't

truly know someone without knowing what they go home to, what they worry about beyond work, what motivates them at a level deeper than salary and career advancement.

People ask me: 'Wasn't that exhausting? Wasn't it inefficient use of your time as Chairman? Couldn't you have learned the same things through reports?'

And I answer with complete honesty: No.

It was the most essential thing I could have done.

Leadership is not surveillance conducted through monitoring systems and metrics dashboards. Leadership is not management conducted through policies and procedures and standardised protocols. Leadership is presence — showing up physically, being there in the flesh, demonstrating through your actual body that you care about people as human beings and not just as resources that generate outcomes.

You cannot lead an organisation effectively from behind a desk, no matter how expensive that desk is or how many monitors surround it showing real-time data. You cannot understand your people through Excel spreadsheets and PowerPoint presentations, no matter how detailed and well-designed those documents are. You cannot build genuine trust through emails and video calls and quarterly town halls where communication flows in one direction and questions are carefully screened to avoid anything uncomfortable.

I learned this from military history. Before a battle, a good commander doesn't stay in the command tent studying maps and making strategic plans in isolation. A good commander tours the territory. Meets every soldier individually if possible. Understands their fears and hopes and readiness. Shows through physical presence that their lives matter to the person making decisions that could end those lives.

Soldiers fight differently for leaders they've actually met. Leaders who know their names. Leaders who've demonstrated that they're not just data points in a strategic calculation.

That's what I did during those six months of intensive travel.

And what happened as a result changed everything I understood about leadership.

People opened up. Not in the sanitised way that happens in formal meetings where everyone is performing for superiors. Authentically. Sharing real struggles. Admitting real confusion. Expressing real frustration with systems that weren't working. Proposing real innovations that had been sitting dormant because they didn't think anyone would listen.

They told me about family situations that affected their work performance. Sick parents who required expensive care. Children who needed educational support. Personal health issues they'd been hiding because they feared being seen as weak or unreliable. They shared brilliant ideas for

improving operations that had never been voiced in official channels because hierarchy and fear of judgment had silenced them.

I learned more in those six months of travel and listening than I could have learned in six years sitting in an office reviewing reports and attending management meetings.

Because the truth is: reports tell you what people think you want to hear.

The truth lives in unguarded conversations. In offhand comments. In the stories people tell when they trust you enough to be honest rather than political.

The Moral Arithmetic of Organisations

Here's a hard truth about cooperatives that goes against everything modern business culture teaches.

We operate on tight margins.

We're not funded by venture capitalists who expect ten-times returns in five years and don't care if the business destroys itself in pursuit of that growth. We don't have deep pockets that allow us to lose money for years while we 'acquire customers' and 'capture market share' — all the euphemisms that tech companies use to justify unsustainable business models. We can't afford to waste money on fancy offices that impress visitors but don't serve members. Or inflated salaries that attract mercenaries but not believers.

So we run lean. We stretch every rupee — understanding that the money we spend on ourselves is money that can't be used to serve members. We rely on systems and process and discipline, not on luxury and excess and the kind of waste that wealthy organisations normalise as 'necessary investment.' We build with believers, not mercenaries. With people who stay because they believe in what we're doing — not because we're the highest bidder for their skills.

But here's the profound truth that modern business culture has forgotten.

Lean doesn't mean weak.

Running on tight margins doesn't mean being ineffective. Frugality is not the same as inadequacy. Constraints often force innovation in ways that abundance never does. When you can't throw money at problems, you have to think more carefully. Work more creatively. Build more intelligently.

We don't need great managers — those people skilled at maintaining existing systems and maximising efficiency within established parameters.

We need excellent leaders — those rare individuals who can transform situations. Who inspire people to attempt things they didn't think they were capable of. Who see potential where others see only risk. Who understand that human development is more important than short-term optimisation.

The difference is everything.

Management can be taught in classrooms through case studies and frameworks and proven methodologies. Leadership must be discovered in the field — through challenge and failure and the particular kind of growth that only comes from being tested. Management is about control and prediction and minimising variance. Leadership is about inspiration and transformation and accepting that the best outcomes often emerge from processes you can't fully control.

So we look for leadership potential early. We pay attention to how people respond to challenges rather than how well they execute predetermined tasks. We spot it in unexpected places — not just in the confident and articulate people who naturally draw attention, but also in the quiet ones who demonstrate character through consistent action rather than impressive words.

We nurture it through deliberate practice — giving people opportunities to lead before they feel ready. Because nobody ever feels truly ready. And waiting for readiness means never beginning.

The Aviation Principle

There's a principle we borrowed from aviation that transformed how we handle mistakes and challenges.

An aircraft never flies in a perfectly straight line from departure to destination.

It constantly drifts off course. Due to wind currents. Turbulence. Weather changes. Mechanical variations. The weight of the aircraft. Gravity. Every aircraft drifts. Every flight involves constant deviation from the planned route.

But pilots don't panic when instruments show they've drifted off course. Pilots don't waste time figuring out which wind current to blame or which weather system caused the problem.

Pilots course-correct.

They acknowledge the deviation. Adjust the heading. Compensate for conditions. Keep the aircraft moving toward its destination.

This seems obvious when we're talking about aviation. Of course you course-correct. Of course you don't panic. Of course you don't spend time assigning blame to wind currents.

But organisations routinely violate this obvious principle.

When something goes wrong, most companies immediately ask: 'Who's to blame? Who screwed up? Who should be punished? Who can we make an example of to ensure this never happens again?'

This question creates a culture where people spend more energy protecting themselves than solving problems. Where mistakes get concealed until they become catastrophes. Where innovation dies because innovation requires risk — and risk sometimes leads to failure.

At Lokmangal, we ask a completely different question.

'What must we change? What can we learn? What will we do differently? How can we systemise this learning so the entire organisation benefits?'

This question creates a culture where mistakes become data. Where problems get solved rather than hidden. Where people feel psychologically safe to experiment and innovate and try things that might not work.

Blame looks backward at what went wrong and who caused it — expending energy on something that's already happened and can't be changed. Change looks forward at what can be improved and how to move ahead — directing energy toward the future where action can actually make a difference.

Blame creates fear that paralyses people and makes them risk-averse. Change creates growth that empowers people and makes them innovative.

Blame protects egos and hierarchies at the cost of organisational health. Change protects the mission and values at the cost of individual comfort and the illusion of infallibility.

So whenever something goes wrong — and things go wrong constantly in any organisation that's actually doing difficult work rather than just maintaining safe routines — we gather the relevant team and facilitate an honest conversation.

Not a blame session disguised as a postmortem. Not a carefully managed discussion where everyone is performing for superiors.

An actual honest conversation where psychological safety allows truth to emerge.

What happened exactly? No spin, no defensive positioning, no carefully constructed narratives that make people look good or protect reputations. Just facts.

What did we learn? What assumptions turned out to be wrong? What knowledge were we missing?

What will we do differently next time?

How can we systemise this learning so others who face similar situations can benefit?

No finger-pointing. No scapegoating. No punishments designed to make someone an example.

Just honest reflection. Genuine learning. Practical course correction.

Like a pilot who has drifted — acknowledges it, adjusts, and keeps flying.

Pehchaan — The Question of Identity

There's a word in Hindi that doesn't translate cleanly into English but captures something essential about identity and purpose.

Pehchaan.

The closest English translation is 'identity.' But that's inadequate. Identity in English feels static — like something you have rather than something you continuously construct.

Pehchaan is more dynamic. More active. More existential.

Pehchaan is knowing who you are at your core. Not who society says you should be. Not who your circumstances have forced you to become. Not who you're pretending to be to fit in or get ahead. But who you truly are when you strip away all the external labels and expectations and performances.

Pehchaan is knowing where you stand in relation to your values. What you will fight for and what you will never compromise on. What principles define you and what boundaries you won't cross regardless of consequences or incentives.

Pehchaan is knowing where you must go based on your unique purpose. The contribution only you can make because of your specific combination of experiences and talents and perspectives that nobody else possesses.

It's your intrinsic GPS. Your internal navigation system that guides you when the external world offers confusing and conflicting directions. Every leader — every person who wants to make meaningful change — must find their

pehchaan before they can effectively guide others or build something lasting. Because without pehchaan, you're navigating by other people's maps. Pursuing other people's destinations. Living other people's definitions of success.

For Lokmangal, our organisational pehchaan has never wavered despite pressures and temptations to compromise.

We exist to serve communities, not to extract maximum profit from them. We exist to empower individuals, not to exploit their vulnerabilities for our institutional gain. We exist to build trust over decades, not to chase quarterly profits that look impressive in reports but represent value extraction rather than value creation.

When your pehchaan is clear, decisions become surprisingly straightforward — even when they're difficult.

Should we cut corners on service quality to increase profit margins? No. That's not our pehchaan. Should we fire dedicated employees during tough economic times to protect profits? No. That's not our pehchaan. Should we abandon rural branches that are less profitable to focus only on urban areas with wealthier members? No. That's not our pehchaan.

When you know who you are, you know what to do.

Even when what you must do is harder than what you want to do. Even when the right decision costs more than the expedient decision. Even when honouring your values requires sacrifice.

And here is the critical insight that most people miss.

Pehchaan begins with you as an individual before it can extend to your organisation or impact your community. Before you can lead an organisation with clarity and conviction, you must lead yourself with discipline and honesty. Before you can course-correct a team that has drifted from its mission, you must course-correct yourself when you notice your own drift from your principles. Before you can build trust with others through consistent action over time, you must build trust with yourself — by honouring the commitments you make to yourself when nobody else is watching.

Every morning, I remind myself: 'You have to get this right.'

And 'this' — whatever challenge or opportunity or moral choice the day brings — always begins with me. With my choices. With my integrity. With my willingness to honour our values even when it's inconvenient or costly or unpopular.

Because leadership is not a position or a title or a role you perform for others.

Leadership is who you are when nobody's watching.

What you do when nobody would know if you compromised.

How you behave when you could get away with less.

The Practice of Building Together

Now it's your turn.

Not metaphorically. Not eventually. Not when conditions are perfect.

Now. Today. This moment.

You don't need 150 branches to begin. You don't need crores of capital to start. You don't need a fancy logo or a sophisticated strategy or permission from anyone.

You just need to begin where you are with what you have.

Exercise 2.1: List Three People With Raw Alignment But Underused Skills

Stop. Think carefully about the people you know. Not the impressive ones with credentials and polished presentations. The ones with something more essential — alignment between their values and potential contributions. Between who they are and what they could become if someone believed in them.

Who do you know who has the heart for something meaningful but not the opportunity to pursue it? Who has natural energy and desire but not the direction to channel it effectively? Who has hunger to learn and contribute but not the platform or support system to develop their capabilities?

Don't overthink this. Don't wait for perfect candidates. Write three specific names of actual human beings you know personally. People whose potential you can see even if they

can't see it themselves yet. Even if the world has told them they're not good enough.

Exercise 2.2: Where Can You Place Them?

For each person you listed, think carefully about their actual strengths, interests, and circumstances. Don't force them into predetermined roles or conventional pathways. What opportunity would actually fit who they are — rather than who you think they should become? What role or project or challenge would match their unique combination of abilities and aspirations? What would stretch them beyond their current comfort zone but not break them with impossible demands?

What would awaken something dormant inside them — a sense of purpose, a recognition of capability, a belief in their own potential that they've been taught to suppress?

Match each person to a specific, concrete possibility. Not vague ideas about 'helping them' or 'giving them a chance.' Actual actionable opportunities. A role in your business. A project you're starting. A skill you can help them develop. A connection you can facilitate. A resource you can provide access to.

Exercise 2.3: Create Your 30-Day Support System

For each person and opportunity you've matched, design a simple but concrete support system. What specific training will you provide? What ongoing support will you offer — weekly check-ins, daily encouragement, available problem-solving when obstacles appear? What clear targets will you

set together — measurable goals that create accountability without crushing people with unrealistic expectations? What accountability structures will you create?

Build a realistic 30-day plan that you can actually execute. Not an elaborate fantasy that sounds impressive but will never happen because it's too complex or requires resources you don't have. A simple, concrete, actionable plan that can begin tomorrow.

The Covenant of Action

And then — this is where most people fail, where good intentions evaporate, where compassion becomes merely comfortable emotion rather than uncomfortable action — execute.

Don't wait for perfect conditions. Don't wait for more resources or better timing or clearer signals. Don't wait for permission from authorities or approval from peers or guarantees of success. Don't wait until you feel fully ready — because nobody ever feels fully ready, and waiting for readiness means never beginning.

Start small if starting big feels overwhelming. Start with one person if three seems like too many. Start with one simple action if a complete plan seems daunting.

But start.

Now.

This week at the latest.

Because that's how Lokmangal started decades ago. Not with a grand vision or massive capital or detailed strategic plans. But with one person helping another person. One relationship building trust through consistent action. One small success inspiring the next attempt.

That's how every meaningful organisation starts. Every lasting movement begins. Every real change takes root in the world.

One person at a time. One belief demonstrated through action at a time. One transformation that proves transformation is possible and inspires others to attempt their own.

The tortoise doesn't win by being fast or flashy or impressive in moments of peak performance.

The tortoise wins by being consistent. Steady. Unwilling to quit when the path gets difficult or the destination seems impossibly far away.

That's what building requires. Not bursts of enthusiasm that fade when obstacles appear. Not impressive launches that collapse under the weight of sustained effort. Not dramatic gestures that generate applause but accomplish nothing lasting.

Building requires the tortoise's wisdom.

Showing up day after day. Moving forward inch by inch. Refusing to quit even when quitting would be easier and nobody would blame you for giving up.

The Only Question That Matters

So here's what I need you to understand. Need you to feel in your bones. Need you to carry forward as you close this chapter and move into whatever comes next.

This is not about Lokmangal.

This is not about my family's business or our particular approach to cooperatives or the specific details of how we operate in Maharashtra.

This is about a philosophy of human development and organisational building that works anywhere. With anyone. In any context where people genuinely care about creating value rather than merely extracting it. This is about seeing potential where others see deficits. About investing in character before credentials. About building trust through consistency rather than demanding it through contract. About measuring success not in quarterly profits but in transformed lives.

The Lokmangal Way is not a corporate strategy you can copy from a business school case study and implement through process documentation and change management protocols.

It's a human philosophy.

Rooted in respect for human dignity. Commitment to service over extraction. And unwavering belief in potential that most people can't see — because they've been trained to look only at credentials and current capabilities rather than at character and possible futures.

We built a cathedral of trust over decades with nothing but belief and grit and refusal to compromise our values — even when compromise would have been more profitable. Starting from a small town that most people have never heard of. Serving communities that banks consider too risky to touch.

Imagine what YOU could build

Not someday. Not when conditions are perfect. Not when you have more resources or better circumstances or clearer signals that success is guaranteed.

What can you build starting now — today, this week — with whatever you currently have? Whether that's money or skills or connections or simply the willingness to see potential in one person who everyone else has dismissed as unemployable?

Because the world doesn't need more people waiting for permission or perfect conditions.

The world needs more tortoises.

Moving steadily forward. Building slowly but surely. Refusing to quit when the path gets hard. Understanding that arrival matters more than speed. That legacy is built through dedication rather than disruption.

That one person you believe in today could be tomorrow's Finance Manager.

Tomorrow's Branch Head.

Tomorrow's CEO.

You just have to choose to see them.

MISSION CHECKPOINT

Before you move to the next chapter, complete these honestly. Not as intellectual exercises. As actual commitments with names and dates and actions.

- ☐ I have identified 3 potential team members with specific names
- ☐ I have created a realistic placement plan for each person
- ☐ I have designed a concrete 30-day support system I can implement

If you've checked all three boxes with complete honesty — you're not just reading anymore.

You're building.

You've transformed from a passive consumer of information into an active creator of change.

And building — done slowly and steadily and surely like the tortoise, refusing to quit when obstacles appear or when progress seems invisible, honouring your commitments even when nobody's watching or applauding — that's exactly how revolutions begin.

That's exactly how lasting change takes root in the world.

That's exactly how New India gets built.

Not through grand declarations or viral campaigns or government programs or corporate initiatives that generate headlines but accomplish nothing lasting.

Through millions of small acts of belief.

Through countless quiet investments in human potential.

Through the accumulated weight of people who chose to build rather than merely consume. Who chose to serve rather than merely extract. Who chose to honour the tortoise's wisdom rather than chase the hare's flash.

Remember this as you move forward. As you face the inevitable obstacles and doubts and moments when quitting seems easier than continuing:

Degrees might open doors. But alignment with values is what keeps them open.

Talent is valuable. But trust is invaluable — and must be earned through consistent action over time.

Speed is exciting. But dedication is enduring.

The tortoise always arrives: The question is whether you have the courage to be one.

Questions for Reflection

- Why does the organisation compare itself to a tortoise instead of a lion or tiger?

THE NEW INDIA MANIFESTO

- What does the chapter suggest about building institutions that last for generations?
- How does the Lokmangal model balance business growth with community trust?
- Why is character considered more valuable than talent while hiring people?
- Describe a time when patience gave you a better result than speed.
- If you were starting a company, what kind of work culture would you want to create?
- What does this chapter teach about building something bigger than personal success?

THE SUBTLE POWER OF SOCIAL IMPACT

When Profit Meets Purpose, Magic Happens

There is a particular kind of wealth that never appears on balance sheets.

It never gets counted in tax returns. Never shows up in the calculations that economists use to measure national progress. Never earns a mention in analyst reports or investment summaries or the quarterly declarations that determine whether a business is considered successful.

It's the wealth that accumulates when a young couple can start their married life without the crushing weight of debt pressing down on their future before they've even had a chance to imagine what that future might hold.

It's the wealth that grows when a farmer's daughter can attend school because her family isn't bankrupting itself to

pay for an elaborate wedding ceremony that tradition demands but economic reality cannot support.

It's the wealth that multiplies when dignity remains intact — because people didn't have to borrow from predatory lenders at interest rates that would make a loan shark blush, just to fulfill social obligations that were designed in a different era for different economic circumstances.

My father understood this wealth long before anyone in our family could articulate it clearly enough to build systems around it.

And standing beside him, shaping him, seeing what he sometimes could not — was my mother.

She was his spiritual compass. But that phrase makes her sound passive when she was anything but. She didn't preach values from a position of comfort. She didn't deliver moral lectures from a safe distance where consequences couldn't touch her. She lived values in ways that made them visible and tangible and impossible to ignore — embedding them so deeply into our family's DNA that departing from them would have felt like betraying not just principles but people.

She saw things that prosperity often blinds people to seeing.

When our businesses succeeded and money started flowing more freely than it had in the difficult early years, many people in our position would have upgraded their lifestyle proportionally — assuming that wealth earned the right to comfort and display. My mother did the opposite. She looked outward with even more intensity. She paid attention

to suffering that success could have easily insulated her from. She refused to let comfort become a barrier between our family and the community we came from — and still belonged to.

The Mathematics of Heartbreak

What she observed was heartbreak of a very specific kind.

The kind that doesn't make headlines or inspire charity campaigns. But destroys futures quietly and systematically.

Failed monsoons that turned wedding plans into impossible dreams — because the money that should have gone toward celebrations was needed just to survive until the next harvest that might or might not come. Daughters reaching marriageable age while fathers calculated and recalculated numbers that never added up. Watching helplessly as social expectation collided with economic reality. Young men ready to start families but unable to meet the financial demands that weddings had become — watching the years pass while they saved and borrowed and still came up short.

The mathematics of rural weddings in India is a form of structural violence that we've normalised so completely that questioning it seems almost radical.

A family earns perhaps fifty thousand rupees in a good year. After all expenses. After all debts are serviced. A wedding costs anywhere from five lakhs to fifteen lakhs — depending on the number of guests and the social standing the family is trying to maintain or demonstrate. These

numbers don't reconcile through saving or planning or prudent financial management. They reconcile only through debt. Debt that takes ten to fifteen years to repay — assuming nothing else goes wrong during those years. Assuming no medical emergencies. No crop failures. No other catastrophes that rural families face with depressing regularity.

So dignified people spiral into indignity.

Farmers who worked their entire lives without borrowing from anyone suddenly find themselves supplicants before moneylenders who charge interest rates that compound faster than crops can grow. Parents who raised their children with values of self-reliance and independence compromise those values by accepting loans on terms they know they'll struggle to meet — choosing between impossible options because there are no good options.

Young couples begin their marriages already buried under obligations that will shape every financial decision they make for the next decade or more. Their futures mortgaged before they've had a chance to build anything of their own.

My father looked at this system and asked a question that seems obvious only in retrospect.

What if we removed the debt?

Not the wedding. Not the celebration. Not the joy of two families coming together or the ritual significance of marriage within our cultural framework. Not the traditions

that carry meaning across generations or the ceremonies that mark the beginning of new lives.

Just the debt.

Just the crushing financial burden that transforms what should be a joyous occasion into an economic catastrophe that ripples through generations.

The Lokmangal Foundation: Where Action Answered the Question

Nineteen years ago, that question became action.

The Lokmangal Foundation was created. And under it, the mass marriage initiative — built on a premise so simple it felt radical.

What if couples could get married with full dignity and complete cultural observance — but without any debt?

We didn't do this halfheartedly. We didn't do it symbolically. We built a complete ecosystem that addressed every aspect of what makes a wedding culturally meaningful and socially acceptable in our communities.

We provided traditional attire for brides and grooms — because appearance matters in ceremonies that mark major life transitions. We provided ornaments — because jewelry carries symbolic weight in our traditions beyond mere decoration. We arranged elaborate meals — because feeding the community is how joy gets shared and relationships get honoured in our culture. We brought in counselors who

could speak to young couples about marriage and partnership and the practical realities of building a life together — because weddings mark beginnings and beginnings deserve thoughtful preparation.

Over the past nineteen years, we have facilitated marriages for more than three thousand five hundred couples.

Just before COVID hit the world, we fed over one lakh people during a single mass marriage ceremony — turning what is typically a family celebration into a community festival where everyone belongs and everyone is fed, regardless of their relationship to the couples getting married.

We don't publicise this work through press releases or social media campaigns or any of the apparatus that modern organisations use to convert good deeds into brand value. We don't invite politicians for photo opportunities or journalists for feel-good stories.

We simply do the work. Quietly. Year after year. Because the work matters more than the recognition. And because the families we serve deserve dignity rather than publicity.

The impact of this initiative cannot be measured only in numbers — though the numbers themselves are staggering.

Three thousand five hundred couples. That means seven thousand individuals who started their married lives without debt. Seven thousand individuals means families that weren't bankrupted. Futures that weren't mortgaged. Children who will grow up in households where their

parents aren't crushed under the weight of wedding loans taken before those children were even conceived.

The ripple effects extend in ways that no economist could fully calculate — because freedom from debt creates possibilities that debt forecloses before they can even be imagined.

But beyond the mathematics, there's something more fundamental at work.

We are demonstrating that systems can be redesigned. That cultural practices can be honoured without economic destruction. That tradition and financial responsibility are not mutually exclusive categories. Every mass marriage ceremony is proof that we don't have to accept suffering as inevitable just because it's traditional. That we can preserve what's meaningful about our cultural practices while removing what's harmful about their economic implementation.

Raja Mama — The Story of Pehchaan in Action

My father's approach to angel investing operated on similar principles — but in a different context.

He wasn't looking for equity stakes or board seats or exit strategies or any of the mechanisms that formal investing requires.

He was looking for character and potential in places where the formal financial system refused to look — because their

risk models couldn't accommodate the kind of investment that's based on human judgment rather than algorithmic calculation.

There is a story that illustrates this perfectly.

His name was Raja Mama. He worked as a railway employee — earning a modest salary that would never make him wealthy by conventional standards, but kept his family secure and comfortable. Most people looked at Raja Mama and saw exactly what he appeared to be. A decent man. A government job. A predictable life.

My father saw more.

He saw honesty. Deep, structural honesty — the kind that isn't performed for observers but simply exists as a way of being in the world. He saw hunger. Not desperation, but genuine appetite — for growth, for purpose, for something larger than a railway salary could contain. He saw determination of a kind that matters more than credentials when you're building something from nothing.

My father made Raja Mama a proposition. To take charge of his contracting business in Pune. No elaborate contract. No equity agreement. No detailed performance metrics or probationary conditions. Simply: I believe in you. The business is yours to grow. Let's see what you do with it.

Raja Mama went to Pune.

And something my father did next says everything about the kind of leader he was. As Raja Mama built the business — as

he put in the hours, made the relationships, solved the problems, grew the revenue — my father quietly stepped back. Not out of disinterest. Out of respect. He recognised that he was no longer the most valuable person in that equation. Raja Mama was building something. And a good mentor knows when to stop standing in the light that should fall on someone else.

Today, decades later, Raja Mama runs a business worth crores.

He employs hundreds of people from all walks of life — creating dignified employment where none existed before. He pays taxes that fund public services, contributing to the collective resources that make civilisation possible. He mentors younger entrepreneurs who remind him of himself when he was starting out — passing forward the gift that my father gave him.

The return on my father's investment cannot be calculated in financial terms. Because the most significant returns were human rather than monetary.

A community has employment. A generation of younger entrepreneurs has a mentor who understands what it means to be seen when the world has looked away.

This is *pehchaan* — the ability to recognise potential before it becomes visible to others. My father could see what Raja Mama might become because he remembered what he himself had been. Because he understood that circumstances are temporary but character is enduring.

Because he refused to let the formal financial system's definition of risk become the final word on who deserves opportunity.

The Real Crisis — It Isn't Unemployment

The real crisis facing India is not unemployment in the simple sense of too few jobs for too many people.

The real crisis is unemployability.

The gap between what our education system produces and what actual productive work requires. We produce graduates who can recite theories but cannot apply them. Who can pass exams but cannot solve problems. Who have degrees but lack skills that employers need and communities require.

We teach students how to answer questions on tests but not how to identify real problems that need solving. We focus on theoretical knowledge that might be useful someday but neglect practical skills that could be deployed immediately. We create a system where credentialing matters more than capability. Where certificates carry more weight than competence. Where passing exams is considered more important than being able to actually do things that need doing.

The agricultural sector illustrates this dysfunction perfectly.

We produce food but waste obscene amounts of it. Because we lack the distribution systems and storage infrastructure

and supply chain coordination that would get food from farmers to consumers efficiently. This isn't a knowledge problem. We know how to build cold storage facilities and distribution networks. The problem is leadership. Organisation. The kind of systematic thinking that can coordinate multiple actors toward collective benefit rather than individual optimisation.

When crops rot in one district while people go hungry in another district a few hundred kilometers away — that is not a production problem. It is not a natural disaster. It is not an inevitable consequence of geographic distance.

That is a failure of systems.

A failure of coordination.

A failure of the entrepreneurial thinking that sees inefficiency as opportunity rather than as inevitable reality.

And this is the failure that educated, capable, passionate young Indians are perfectly positioned to solve — if someone would stop waiting for them to have the right credentials and start asking whether they have the right character.

The Three Stages of a Meaningful Life

I've come to understand that meaningful lives follow a three-stage progression that most people never complete. Not because they lack the ability. Because they get stuck in the

first stage and never move to the deeper levels where real impact becomes possible.

Stage One is solving one problem through entrepreneurship. Building something that generates income and creates value. Establishing yourself as someone who can identify opportunities and execute solutions. Most people stop here. Content with the financial security and social status that successful entrepreneurship provides. And there is nothing wrong with this. It is necessary. But it is not sufficient.

Stage Two is growing your enterprise to the point where it can support others. Creating employment and opportunity beyond just your own family. Building systems that generate value for multiple stakeholders rather than extracting value for a single owner. Some people reach this stage — building businesses that employ hundreds or thousands of people, creating meaningful economic activity in their communities. This is more. But it is still not enough.

Stage Three is where transformation really happens.

Stage Three is taking ownership of a local issue and dedicating serious resources to fixing it. Moving beyond profit and employment to address the underlying conditions that keep communities stuck. Stage Three is where you stop asking what more you can extract from your environment and start asking what you can contribute to make that environment healthier and more capable of supporting human flourishing.

My father moved through all three stages naturally. Almost inevitably. As though each stage logically required the next. He built businesses that generated profit. He grew those businesses until they employed hundreds of people and created economic opportunity across multiple communities. And then he took ownership of issues that nobody was paying him to solve — investing time and money and attention into problems that decreased his profit margins but increased the collective capacity of the communities he served.

The mass marriages. The educational support. The angel investing in entrepreneurs that banks rejected. The infrastructure investments in villages that government had abandoned. None of this made financial sense if you evaluated it purely on return on investment.

All of it made profound sense if you understood that businesses exist within social ecosystems — and healthy ecosystems require investment that goes beyond profit maximisation.

The Contradiction We Must Confront

There is a contradiction at the heart of modern India that we need to confront honestly. Because it will determine whether our aspirations for development and progress are achievable — or merely rhetorical.

Inside our homes, we've embraced modernity with enthusiasm. Smartphones and internet connections. Air

conditioning and water purifiers. Modern appliances and contemporary furnishings. We've upgraded our private spaces to match global standards of comfort and convenience.

But outside our homes — in our public spaces and shared infrastructure and collective systems — we tolerate conditions that no modern nation should accept.

Roads full of potholes that destroy vehicles and sometimes lives. Public toilets that are unusable or nonexistent — forcing people into indignity. Garbage collection systems that work sporadically at best, turning public spaces into dumps. Water supplies that are unreliable and often contaminated. Electrical grids that fail regularly — because we've accepted power cuts as normal rather than as failures that should trigger urgent remediation.

We live in private excellence and public squalor.

And we've somehow made peace with this contradiction — treating it as the natural order of things rather than as the choice it actually is.

This public-private split will kill the dream of New India if we don't address it directly and honestly.

We cannot build a modern nation while accepting medieval standards for public infrastructure and collective systems. We cannot claim to be a rising superpower while our cities are choking on pollution and our villages lack basic services. We cannot talk about competing globally while our public

spaces communicate incompetence and negligence and collective failure.

The solution is not waiting for government to fix everything. Not waiting for some external force to solve problems that we ourselves tolerate daily.

The solution is treating public space as an extension of personal responsibility. Understanding that the environment outside our doors affects the quality of life inside our doors. Recognising that collective problems require collective action — and that someone has to start, even if others haven't joined yet.

That someone is you.

It was always you.

Your Turn: Create Impact

Now it's your turn to move from understanding to action. From passive consumption of ideas to active creation of change.

These exercises are not suggestions for particularly motivated readers.

They are requirements for anyone serious about building rather than merely consuming. About contributing rather than merely criticising.

Exercise 3.1: Identify One Social Pain Point in Your Immediate Environment

Look around your neighbourhood. Your village. Your community. With honest eyes that see reality rather than the sanitised version you've grown comfortable ignoring.

What breaks your heart when you pay attention instead of looking away? What makes you angry — not because it's inevitable, but because it's unnecessary? The result of neglect or indifference or systems that don't work? What could be fixed if someone cared enough to try?

Write it down specifically. Not 'poverty' or 'education' as abstract concepts. Something concrete. School dropout rates in your area. Lack of safe drinking water. Unemployed youth with skills but no opportunities. Elderly people with no support systems. Waste management that doesn't exist. Healthcare access that leaves people suffering from preventable conditions. Make it real. Give it a name and a location and a face if you can.

Exercise 3.2: Draft a Six-Month Project With Three Measurable Outcomes

Take the problem you identified and design an intervention that you could actually execute. Not a fantasy that requires resources you don't have or permissions you'll never get. What could you realistically do in six months with the resources you can access through your network and community?

Define three specific, measurable outcomes that would indicate progress. A number of people served. A percentage improvement in some metric. A system created that didn't exist before. Make it concrete enough that six months from now you can evaluate honestly — without self-deception — whether you succeeded or failed.

Exercise 3.3: Recruit Two Allies and Begin Within One Week

Identify two people who might join you in this effort. People with complementary skills or perspectives or resources that would make the project more viable. Talk to them honestly about what you want to do and why it matters.

Don't oversell it. Don't make it sound easier than it will be. Be honest about the challenges and the uncertainty and the possibility of failure. Ask them to commit for the six-month duration — understanding that commitment means showing up even when enthusiasm fades.

And then — within one week — start something. Anything. Not planning. Not more research. Actual action that moves the project from idea to reality.

MISSION CHECKPOINT

Before moving to the next chapter, complete these honestly. Not as intellectual exercises. As actual commitments with names and dates and actions.

☐ I have identified my specific social problem with concrete details

- ☐ I have created my six-month action plan with three measurable outcomes
- ☐ I have recruited two allies who have committed to the six-month duration
- ☐ I have taken one concrete action within one week of completing these exercises

If you cannot check all four boxes honestly — you're not ready to move forward.

Because understanding without action is just sophisticated procrastination.

Go back. Actually complete what you've been asked to do.

Questions for Reflection

- Why does the author believe businesses should solve human problems, not just sell products?
- What is the difference between temporary help and long-term social impact?
- How can helping others also strengthen a business or organisation?
- Why are local community problems often ignored by larger systems?
- What is one issue in your area that people have accepted as "normal" but should actually change?
- If you had access to funding, what social initiative would you start first?
- How can entrepreneurship create dignity instead of dependency?

THE NEW INDIA MANIFESTO

The revolution begins with you doing what you said you would do when nobody is watching. When nobody is applauding. When nobody is holding you accountable except your own conscience — and the people you want to serve.



PART I

FROM EXPERIENCE TO
POSSIBILITY

From What We Have Done to What Must Be Done Next

So far, you have heard about what we at the Lokmangal Group have done.

You have heard about hospitals built where none existed. Institutions created where systems had failed. Livelihoods restored where despair had taken root. You have heard about work carried out quietly, consistently, often far from attention or applause — work grounded in one belief: that development is not charity, but responsibility.

But if I am honest with you — and honesty is the only currency that matters now — what we have done is not enough.

It was never meant to be.

What I share next does not come from boardrooms or conferences or theory. It comes from decades on the ground. From watching lives up close. From listening more than speaking. From seeing where systems work — and, more often, where they collapse the moment reality touches them.

These are not conclusions reached comfortably.

They are conclusions reached painfully.

In the pages so far, I have laid before you what was achieved over two to two-and-a-half decades of working on the ground. What was done. How it was done. And, most importantly, what was learned along the way. This is not presented as a perfect model, nor as the only way forward. It is simply a system I have witnessed firsthand — one that worked, one that made sense in its context, one that evolved organically in response to real needs.

I am not claiming this is the answer.

I am suggesting that it is an answer — one that can grow, adapt, and become better.

How It Began — And Why That Matters

When my father began what would later be known as the Lokmangal Way, there was no grand blueprint. No articulated long-term vision of what it would eventually become. There was only a deep sensitivity to the needs of the hour — and the courage to act upon it.

He went where the need was. He did what felt necessary. He allowed the work itself to shape the direction.

In hindsight, a system emerged. But it was never imposed. It was discovered.

Today, however, we stand at a different moment in history.

We now have before us a larger, clearer, more ambitious vision — what we call New India. This is not a dream in the abstract. Not a distant aspiration. It is a serious proposition. A vision of what a nation can become. And what a country in a leadership position must become.

For the first seventy-five years after Independence, one could argue that India was recovering. Recovering from colonial damage. From institutional hollowing. From a loss of confidence that centuries of subjugation had inflicted on a civilisation that had once led the world. We took the paths we took — socialist, cautious, inward-looking — because perhaps that was all we could afford then.

But today, we no longer have that luxury.

We have clarity.

We have capacity.

We have responsibility.

This book, therefore, is not about nostalgia.

It is about possibility.

The Scale of What Becomes Possible

If one individual — supported by committed teams and good people — could help build something meaningful over twenty years, learning through mistakes, adapting through challenges, creating lasting change in communities that the world had forgotten — then imagine what could be achieved if one lakh people chose to do the same.

Consciously. Systematically. Together.

Imagine what could happen if we began not merely with intent but with vision. Not merely with effort but with alignment. Not merely with good hearts but with clear minds and specific plans and the willingness to be held accountable for results.

Mistakes will be made. That is inevitable. But if those mistakes become shared lessons rather than repeated failures — then we stand on solid ground.

One conviction is unshakeable in my mind.

India cannot continue as two countries within one.

One urban. One rural. One with access to world-class healthcare, excellent education, reliable infrastructure. One without.

If urban India can access world-class healthcare, rural India must not settle for less. If urban children receive excellent education, rural children deserve the same dignity of

opportunity. How we do this can — and must — be debated. What methods we choose can be refined, improved, discarded and replaced as we learn. But whether we should do it is beyond question.

The answer is yes: It has always been yes.

The Invitation

This second part of the book is therefore an invitation.

It is an opening.

It is a manifesto — not in the political sense, but in the human sense.

It brings together three streams of thought that must flow as one river if New India is to become real rather than rhetorical.

The Lokmangal Way — that shaped my upbringing, shaped my thinking, shaped my understanding of what it means to build something that lasts rather than something that merely grows.

The grand national vision — for a New India that takes its rightful place among the leading nations of the world, not through imitation but through the expression of its own deepest values.

The lived understanding — that real change is built by people, over time, on the ground. Not announced from

podiums. Not legislated into existence. Not funded into being by distant institutions. Built. By hands. By character. By the kind of patient, persistent, unglamorous dedication that the tortoise embodies and the hare will never understand.

What History Teaches — And What It Demands

History teaches us something sobering.

Leaders may ignite movements. But they are not always present to witness their culmination.

The New India we speak of may take ten years. Twenty years. Perhaps longer. Some of today's stalwarts may not be here to see it completed. Some of the people who planted the seeds will never sit under the trees. And that is the nature of building something that actually matters — it outlives the builder, or it isn't worth building.

And that is precisely why this moment matters.

If all goes well — with grace, with perseverance, with the collective determination of millions of ordinary people who refuse to accept that ordinary is all they can be — it is people like you and me who will inherit that future.

We cannot afford another seventy-five years of regret.

We cannot say, someday, that if only someone else had been there — things would have turned out differently. That liberty is no longer ours.

The moment is now.

The responsibility is ours.

The work must begin here.

Not in some other city: Not in some other lifetime.

Not by some other person who cares more than you do.

Here.

Now.

You.



Subhash Deshmukh never waited for the right moment.

He never waited for permission. He never waited for resources to be sufficient or conditions to be ideal or someone more qualified to step forward first.

He saw the need. He calculated what he had. He began.

That is the entirety of the philosophy.

That is the whole of the manifesto.

Everything else — every chapter, every exercise, every principle and framework and challenge in this book — is an elaboration of that single truth.

THE NEW INDIA MANIFESTO

See the need.

Calculate what you have.

Begin.

REVOLUTION IS RESPONSIBILITY

Why Youth Must Stop Waiting and Start Warring

Let me tell you the hard truth that nobody wants to hear but everyone needs to understand.

India is not poor because we lack resources. Not because we lack talent. Not because we lack potential or intelligence or the capacity for greatness. These are comfortable excuses that comfortable people repeat to avoid uncomfortable responsibility.

India is poor because our systems are weak. Because our institutions became dysfunctional — elaborate structures that look impressive on paper and collapse under the weight of actual implementation. Systems that didn't change when the world changed around them. Institutions built for a different era, serving a different India, solving problems that

have since been replaced by entirely different problems that nobody updated the systems to address.

We have had seventy-five years of freedom from British rule. Seventy-five years to build the nation we claimed we wanted to become. Seventy-five years to prove that self-governance could deliver what colonial administration never would.

And what do we have to show for it?

Freedom from foreign rule — certainly. And that matters more than cynics acknowledge. But freedom from hunger? Freedom from unemployment? Freedom from the grinding, dignity-destroying poverty that keeps millions trapped in lives they never chose and cannot escape?

On those measures — we have failed. Spectacularly. Repeatedly. Generation after generation producing the same dysfunctions, offering the same excuses, expecting different results.

The true disease is not unemployment in the simple sense of too few jobs for too many applicants. We covered this in Chapter 3. But it bears repeating here — louder.

The true disease is unemployability.

The systematic mismatch between what our education system produces and what productive work requires. We graduate commerce students who cannot maintain basic balance sheets. We produce engineering graduates who cannot fix motors or apply theoretical knowledge to practical problems. We hand out degrees like participation

trophies — certificates that prove someone sat through classes and passed exams, saying nothing about whether they can actually do anything useful.

This is not an accident. This is not an unfortunate side effect of rapid expansion in education access. This is a design choice. The inevitable result of a system that optimised for credentialing rather than capability. For processing students through standardised curricula rather than developing skills that communities need. We built an education system that serves the system's need for perpetuation — rather than society's need for capable people who can identify problems and implement solutions.

The consequences cascade through our social structure in ways that most comfortable people never see — because they've insulated themselves from the hardest impacts.

Villages lose their youth to migration. Fields go unattended. Agricultural traditions break. The connection between generations that used to transmit knowledge and values and practical wisdom — severed. Cities suffocate under the weight of migration they cannot absorb. Slums form where dignity goes to die. Congestion makes every daily task harder than it should be. Despair settles over people who came seeking opportunity and found only different forms of struggle. And nations weaken when they produce job beggars rather than job creators. When the best and brightest can imagine no higher ambition than securing employment in someone else's organisation — rather than building something of their own.

But here is what gives me hope despite all this dysfunction.

Youth is energy waiting to be channeled. Potential waiting for direction. Power that can build or destroy — depending entirely on how it's organised and toward what ends it's pointed.

The question is not whether youth has the capacity to change India.

The question is whether youth will accept the responsibility that comes with that capacity.

Whether young people will stop waiting for someone else to fix problems — and start warring against those problems with the kind of systematic intensity that actually creates transformation.

So I'm going to give you a six-point war plan.

Not suggestions. Not recommendations. Not nice ideas to consider when you have time.

A plan for action. For organised effort. For the kind of sustained commitment that changes conditions rather than just complaining about them.

You can reject this plan and propose something better.

But you cannot claim to care about New India while refusing to do anything concrete to build it.



POINT ONE: Start-Rural India — The New Freedom Movement

India's original freedom movement was about political independence.

This one is about something harder to win. And more important to keep.

Economic independence. Social independence. Psychological independence.

Freedom from helplessness. From dependency. From the paralysing habit of waiting for someone else to act.

India's next freedom movement will not be led only by governments, institutions, or billion-dollar programs.

It will be led by young Indians who decide to take responsibility for one problem, in one place, within a fixed window of time.

"I will solve one local problem in ninety days."

That is the pledge. That is the entire movement.

Not a massive, nation-scale challenge that requires policy reform or endless approvals. One real problem affecting real people you can see, speak to, and serve directly.

Start Where You Stand

The problems are not abstract. They are visible. They are immediate. They are waiting for you — not for a

government scheme or a policy window or a well-funded NGO to notice them.

- Water shortages in your village or ward
- Rising school dropout rates
- Farmers losing crops due to lack of market access
- Skilled workers unemployed despite demand elsewhere
- Waste piling up with no collection system
- Blood donation needed but no coordination

These are not problems waiting for permission to be addressed.

They are waiting for ownership.

They are waiting for you.

Ninety Days: The Discipline of Action

The ninety-day framework is not arbitrary. It is strategic.

Long enough to test an idea, organise people, gather data, and show measurable progress. Short enough to eliminate excuses — 'I don't have time,' 'conditions aren't right,' 'I'll start next month.' Safe enough that failure does not ruin you if the idea doesn't work.

In ninety days, perfection is not the goal.

Proof is.

Proof that the problem is real. That a solution can be attempted. That people are willing to participate. That change is possible with limited resources. That you — specifically you, with what you currently have — are capable of making something happen.

From Complaints to Builders

Start-Rural India flips the cultural script that has kept a generation passive.

From waiting — to doing. From complaining — to building. From entitlement — to responsibility. From commentators — to creators. From social media outrage — to social infrastructure.

Even a small intervention — if real, if honest, if executed with full commitment — creates something that no amount of commenting ever can.

Confidence. Credibility. Momentum.

Learning Through Doing, Not Planning Forever

Most ideas die in overthinking. Most revolutions die in planning meetings. Ninety days forces something that planning meetings never can.

Rapid experimentation. Learning from mistakes. Course correction in real time. Evidence-based decision making born from actual contact with actual reality.

You don't need full funding to begin. You don't need perfect plans. You don't need expert validation or institutional

approval or the blessing of anyone who currently holds power.

You need commitment. Coordination. Courage.

Individual Action, Collective Momentum

One person solving one problem may feel insignificant.

Ten thousand people solving ten thousand problems creates a national capability shift.

When documented, shared, and replicated, these ninety-day experiments become blueprints for others. Inputs for Rural Incubation Centres. Pipelines for CSR and institutional support. The foundation of a new grassroots economy that nobody built from the top down — because it couldn't be. It had to be built from the ground up, village by village, problem by problem, person by person.

I will identify one problem in my community.

I will act on it for ninety days.

I will learn, adapt, and document the journey.

And whether I succeed or fail, I will not remain passive.



POINT TWO: Rural Incubation Clusters

Every district in India should host at least one Rural Incubation Cluster.

Not a training centre. Not a skill development institute. Not another certificate factory.

A capability engine. A physical, accessible hub designed not for abstract learning — but for real skills tied directly to the local economy.

These clusters must move decisively away from the traditional model of classroom-based instruction that delivers theoretical knowledge students forget within weeks. Instead: hands-on, outcome-driven training that builds skills the market will actually pay for.

Skills That Matter Locally — And Pay Immediately

- Welding, fabrication, and basic manufacturing
- Coding, software testing, low-code development, and IT services
- Food processing, grading, packaging, and compliance
- Digital marketing, content operations, and e-commerce enablement
- Agricultural technology, precision farming, soil analytics, and post-harvest solutions

The goal is not certification for its own sake.

The goal is immediate productive capacity — skills that can be deployed for employment, freelancing, enterprise creation, or corporate outsourcing from day one.

Practitioners, Not Just Trainers

These clusters must be staffed by people who have actually done the work they are teaching. Entrepreneurs,

technicians, engineers, farmers, professionals with proven real-world outcomes — not academics who have studied outcomes at a comfortable distance.

Credibility should be demonstrated through projects completed, products shipped, systems deployed, enterprises built. Not through degrees and certifications that prove nothing about whether a person can teach someone else to actually do something.

Market Linkages: From Skill to Income

Training without market access creates frustration, not livelihoods.

Every cluster must act as a market connector — linking learners and incubatees to corporate outsourcing contracts, local and regional buyers, e-commerce platforms, government and institutional procurement.

Skills must translate into income streams. Not remain theoretical capabilities that never get deployed productively. Not become another entry on a resume that leads to another round of unsuccessful job applications.

Income. Real income. Starting from day one.

Why This Matters More Than Any Government Program

Traditional skill development programs focus on inputs. Training hours delivered. Certificates issued. Money spent. Boxes ticked. Reports filed. Photos taken. Programs closed.

Rural Incubation Clusters focus on outputs and outcomes. Work completed. Value created. Income earned. Lives changed.

This is the difference between teaching about work — and teaching people to do work that the economy actually rewards.

The Invisible Engine: Why the Social Impact Sector Must Be Rebuilt

There is another force without which none of this scale is deliverable.

It is present everywhere. Formally acknowledged almost nowhere.

The social impact sector.

Every transformation of consequence in history has required people who work not just for profit but for purpose. People who build bridges between policy and people. Between intention and execution. Between vision and lived reality.

And yet in India, we have made a grave mistake.

We have treated social impact work as voluntary, informal, and secondary. As something driven by goodwill rather than skill. We have labelled those who work in this space as 'social workers' — a term so loosely defined and poorly structured that it neither attracts top talent nor commands institutional respect.

As a result, one of the most critical sectors required for national transformation remains understaffed, underpaid, under-recognised, and underpowered.

This is not a failure of values. It is a failure of design.

The scale we are talking about — ten lakh enterprises, rural transformation, agricultural renewal, ecosystem building — cannot be delivered casually. It requires program designers, field operators, community mobilisers, impact managers, finance and compliance professionals, people who can translate ideas into execution repeatedly across geographies.

This is not charity work.

This is nation-building work.

And nation-building requires the best minds — not only the most well-intentioned ones.

Talent follows structure. Structure follows recognition. Recognition follows incentives. Right now, the incentives are wrong. Young, capable people who want to contribute meaningfully also want financial stability, career progression, social respect, and a clear professional identity. The social impact sector offers too few of these today.

So talent opts out. Not because it doesn't care. Because it cannot afford to stay.

We need to move from the vague idea of a 'social worker' to a recognised class of social impact professionals — people with defined roles, defined skills, defined career pathways, and the ability to say with pride:

This is my profession. This is my contribution. This is my career.

If India is serious about transformation at scale, then social impact work must be recognised as a formal economic sector. Supported through meaningful tax benefits. Incentivised for individuals, organisations, and champions. Integrated into national development priorities.

Tax incentives are not giveaways. They are signals. They tell society what a nation values. If wealth creation is incentivised — and it should be — then value creation for society must be incentivised as well.

Without social impact professionals, good ideas stall. Funds remain unused. Programs fragment. Momentum is lost. With them — execution accelerates. Trust deepens. Impact multiplies. Employment is guaranteed not just for beneficiaries but for the builders of the system itself.

One district. One cluster.

Skills that pay. Work that lasts.

Capability before certificates.

Respect, honour, and reward — for those who serve the nation.



POINT THREE: Adopt-a-Village Economy

Corporate Social Responsibility should mean actual capacity building rather than charity that creates dependency.

Instead of companies writing checks to NGOs that run projects in communities those companies will never visit — companies should adopt specific villages and commit to building economic capacity over a five to ten year period.

This is not sponsorship. It is partnership.

What Real Adoption Actually Means

Real adoption begins with deep understanding. Not with branding ceremonies or ribbon cuttings or press releases about how committed the company is to rural India.

What does the village already produce? Where is value being lost? What skills exist but remain underutilised? What infrastructure bottlenecks prevent productivity? Which markets are inaccessible today — and why?

Only when these questions are answered honestly can capital, training, and technology be deployed meaningfully rather than wasted on interventions that look good in annual reports but change nothing on the ground.

This Is Not Charity. It Is Enlightened Self-Interest.

Companies need healthy supplier ecosystems. Consumer markets. Social stability that only comes when communities have economic opportunity and dignity. Villages need access to capital, markets, and technical knowledge that companies possess.

The relationship should be mutually beneficial over time — not extractive where companies take resources and provide minimal value in return. Not patronising where companies

decide what villages need without asking what villages want.

When companies act as anchor buyers — integrating village producers into supply chains, providing quality and compliance standards, opening access to platforms and distributors and export channels — something fundamental changes.

Villages stop being price takers. They become value participants.

A Five-to-Ten-Year Commitment: Why Time Matters

Economic ecosystems do not mature in annual CSR cycles. They cannot be built in a year and cannot be evaluated in a quarter.

A five-to-ten-year horizon allows trust to be built. Skills to compound. Enterprises to survive early failures. Second-generation leadership to emerge. Communities to develop the confidence that comes only from sustained engagement with partners who don't disappear the moment their PR value has been extracted.

Short-term projects produce reports.

Long-term commitments produce resilient local economies.

When Rural Incubation Centres create capability, Start-Rural India creates agency, and Adopt-a-Village Economy creates sustained partnership — India moves from welfare-driven rural development to economy-driven rural transformation.

Not aid. Not dependence.

Capability. Dignity. Shared growth.

We adopt not to give, but to build.

Not for a year, but for a decade.

Not as patrons, but as partners.

Because strong villages make a strong India.



POINT FOUR: Mentorship-as-a-Service

India does not suffer from a lack of talent.

It suffers from a lack of access — to guidance, to networks, to confidence, to people who have already walked the path and are willing to turn around and show others the way.

Mentorship-as-a-Service reframes mentorship from an informal, occasional act of generosity into a structured, repeatable social responsibility.

Every Indian who has achieved a measure of professional, entrepreneurial, or social success should make a simple annual commitment.

"I will mentor two people for six months each."

Not through one-off advice. Not through motivational talks or casual networking. Through sustained engagement. Accountability. Real investment in another person's progress.

What Mentorship Actually Means — And What It Doesn't

Mentorship is not a single coffee meeting. Not generic career advice. Not LinkedIn encouragement. Not passive inspiration that makes the mentor feel good without requiring anything from them.

Real mentorship means regular interaction over at least six months. Helping mentees navigate real obstacles — not hypothetical ones. Sharing practical knowledge that is usually learned the hard way. Opening doors that are normally closed to outsiders.

Mentorship requires time. Presence. Honesty.

Transferring What Privilege Usually Protects

One of the least discussed forms of inequality in India is network inequality.

Successful individuals accumulate insider knowledge. Unwritten rules. Trusted contacts. Pattern recognition built from years of navigating systems that the untrained eye cannot even see. These advantages rarely get passed down across economic or social boundaries. They stay within circles. They reproduce privilege quietly and efficiently.

Mentorship-as-a-Service deliberately breaks this pattern. By encouraging mentors to share decision frameworks, professional norms, introductions to real opportunities, feedback that is constructive but unfiltered — the feedback that usually only people with powerful connections ever receive.

This is how invisible barriers begin to dissolve. Not through policy. Not through protest. Through one honest conversation between one person who has been somewhere and one person who is trying to get there.

The Mathematics of Transformation

If one person mentors two people each year — in five years that's ten people directly impacted. In ten years, those mentees become mentors themselves. This creates exponential networks of capability, not just linear impact.

Over a decade, such a system can span economic classes, cut across caste and geography and gender, democratise access to opportunity, and reduce dependence on formal institutions that have failed too many people for too long.

This is social mobility powered by human relationships — not programs. Not schemes. Not well-intentioned initiatives that run for three years and then quietly close when the funding cycle ends.

Mentorship is social infrastructure.

Just as roads move goods and power grids enable industry — mentorship transfers wisdom, accelerates learning, reduces avoidable failure, and builds the leadership depth that a New India will require at every level, in every district, in every sector.

I will mentor two people every year.

I will commit time, honesty, and access.

I will measure success not by advice given, but by growth enabled.

And I will remember that someone once opened a door for me.

India does not need more heroes.

It needs more ladders.

Mentorship-as-a-Service builds ladders — quietly, steadily, and at scale.



POINT FIVE: Buy from Bharat Movement

India's villages and small towns do not lack skill, effort, or quality.

They lack access — to distribution, to visibility, and to the marketing muscle that large brands take for granted.

The Buy from Bharat Movement calls for a conscious shift in consumer behaviour.

Choose village producers, local artisans, and small-scale manufacturers when quality and value are comparable — rather than defaulting automatically to large brands because large brands are the only names you've been told to trust.

This is not about charity. This is not about lowering standards. This is about recognising hidden excellence and correcting a market imbalance that has nothing to do with merit and everything to do with marketing budgets.

Quality Already Exists. Visibility Does Not.

Across rural India, producers are already making high-quality jaggery, oils, grains, and processed foods. Textiles woven and dyed with skill passed down through generations. Furniture, metalwork, pottery, leather goods, and crafts built to last — not designed to be replaced in a season.

These products rarely reach mainstream consumers. Not because they are inferior. But because they lack distribution networks. They lack marketing budgets. They lack brand recognition created by advertising spend.

Markets reward visibility, not always value.

Buy from Bharat seeks to rebalance that equation.

Every Purchase Is a Vote

Money is not neutral.

Every rupee spent reinforces a certain economic structure. Every purchase is a vote for the kind of India you want to live in — whether you're conscious of it or not.

When you buy directly from farmers — you strengthen local agriculture. When you buy from cooperatives — you support dignified employment. When you buy from small manufacturers — you preserve skills and decentralise industry.

Consumption is policy — executed daily, silently, at scale. By millions of people who don't think of themselves as policy

makers but are, in fact, the most powerful policy makers in existence. Because they vote every single day with their wallets.

Demand Creates Capability

One of the most overlooked truths of economics: supply follows sustained demand.

When rural producers see reliable demand — quality improves, capacity expands, young people stay back instead of migrating, innovation becomes worthwhile because someone will actually pay for better.

Demand signals are more powerful than subsidies. More powerful than schemes. More powerful than any government program that funds production without asking whether anyone will buy what gets produced.

This is not a sacrifice. This is not nationalism-as-consumption or guilt dressed up as economics.

This is an upgrade in awareness.

I will look for local and village-made alternatives.

I will judge by quality and value, not brand size.

I will remember that my money shapes the economy I live in.



POINT SIX: Business Literacy for All

Business literacy must be treated as a basic life skill.

Taught as universally as reading and writing. Required as fundamentally as arithmetic. Considered as essential as any subject that currently occupies space in a school curriculum.

Bookkeeping. Costing. Pricing. Credit management. Customer relations. Quality control. These are not niche competencies reserved for entrepreneurs or MBAs. They are fundamental capabilities required by anyone who seeks economic independence in any form.

Whether someone runs a roadside stall, a family farm, a tailoring unit, a cooperative, or a factory — the same basic questions apply.

Am I making a profit — or just working hard?

Where is my money coming from and where is it going?

Is my pricing sustainable?

Is my credit helping me grow or quietly destroying me?

Are my customers returning — and why?

Without the ability to answer these questions, effort becomes wasted motion. Hard work without financial literacy is a hamster wheel — exhausting, relentless, going nowhere.

The Absurd Gap in Our Education System

We teach algebra and trigonometry to every student — even though most people will never use advanced mathematics in daily life.

Yet we do not teach how to maintain basic financial records. How to calculate profitability. How to manage cash flow. How to deal with customers and suppliers. How to judge whether growth is healthy or dangerous.

This is not an accident. Our education system was designed to produce employees for other people's organisations — not builders of their own. The result is a population that works hard, often brilliantly — but blindly. Brilliant effort, pointed in a direction that someone else chose, serving goals that someone else set, building wealth that someone else keeps.

Business Literacy Is Economic Self-Defence

Business literacy does not mean everyone must start a company. It means everyone should understand how value is created, measured, protected, and grown.

A farmer who understands costing negotiates better prices. An artisan who understands margins survives volatility. A shopkeeper who understands cash flow avoids debt traps. A worker who understands business becomes more effective — and harder to exploit.

The absence of business literacy imposes a silent tax. Profitable work that collapses due to poor cash management.

Enterprises that grow too fast and die from debt. Good products that fail due to bad pricing. Honest effort destroyed by avoidable mistakes that a basic education could have prevented.

These failures are often misdiagnosed as lack of resources or bad luck.

In reality, many are failures of basic understanding.

Mediocrity: The Real Enemy

The deepest obstacle to India's transformation is not poverty. Not lack of resources. Not even government dysfunction — real as those are.

The real enemy is mediocrity.

Mediocrity is accepting 'chalta hai' when excellence is possible. Tolerating inefficiency because it's familiar. Shrugging at problems that could be solved. Choosing comfort over improvement because improvement requires effort and effort requires courage and courage is uncomfortable.

Mediocrity is cowardice dressed as practicality.

It is the refusal to try harder — disguised as realism.

Every time we accept substandard work, unclear accounts, broken systems, or avoidable waste — the nation weakens. Not dramatically. Not in ways that make headlines. Steadily. Quietly. Invisibly. Until one day we look up and wonder why we've been working this hard and getting this little in return.

Courage as a Daily Practice

The antidote to mediocrity is courage. Not reckless bravado. Disciplined resolve.

Courage means looking honestly at how far we've fallen short of our potential. Refusing to normalise dysfunction. Choosing improvement even when it's inconvenient. Taking responsibility for what we tolerate daily.

Business literacy cultivates this courage because it makes problems visible. Makes performance measurable. Makes excuses harder to justify. When you know your numbers, you cannot pretend you don't. Clarity demands action. And action — repeated, daily, disciplined — is how revolutions are actually built.

I will understand the economics of my work.

I will measure before I complain.

I will not accept mediocrity where excellence is possible.

And I will choose courage over comfort.



The Six Pillars — A Framework for New India

These six points are not independent initiatives. They are an interconnected framework — each pillar reinforcing the others, each one incomplete without the rest.

Together, they form a Capability-Agency-Market Framework for New India. Not designed from the top down by planners who have never visited the places they're planning for.

Designed from the ground up by people who have spent decades understanding what actually works.

PILLAR 1 — Business Literacy for All

Creates: Economic intelligence. The base layer on which every other pillar rests. Without it, effort dissipates. With it, effort compounds.

PILLAR 2 — Rural Incubation Clusters

Creates: Productive capability. Converts potential into income, ideas into enterprises, skills into livelihoods.

PILLAR 3 — Start-Rural India

Creates: Agency and ownership. Builds confidence, not dependency. Replaces waiting with doing.

PILLAR 4 — Mentorship-as-a-Service

Creates: Transferred confidence and networks. Moves invisible privilege across class and geography.

PILLAR 5 — Adopt-a-Village Economy

Creates: Stability, capital, and market access. Converts CSR from charity into investment.

PILLAR 6 — Buy from Bharat Movement

Creates: Sustainable demand. Turns consumption into economic agency.

90-Day Entry Points: Anyone Can Start Without Permission

→ Individual → Start a 90-day problem project in your community

→ Professional → Mentor two people for six months each

→ Corporate → Fund one Rural Incubation Cluster vertical or adopt one village

→ Consumer → Shift 10-20% of purchases to Bharat producers

→ District → Launch one incubation cluster with practitioner staff

Notice what this framework does not ask.

It does not ask what the government should do.

It asks what YOU will take responsibility for.

That's why it works. That's why every other approach hasn't.



Your Turn: Start Your War

These exercises are your entry point into revolution.

The beginning of your transformation from passive observer to active builder.

Complete them honestly — or admit that you're not serious about change and stop pretending that you care.

Exercise 4.1: Identify ONE Problem in Your Community That You Can Address

Stop thinking about national-scale issues or problems that require government intervention to solve. Focus on something immediate and local and within your capacity to affect. What specific problem can you see with your own eyes, affecting people you could talk to within an hour of deciding to do so?

Write it down with enough specificity that someone else could understand exactly what you're talking about. Not 'poverty.' Not 'education.' Something real, something named, something with a location and a face and a number you could measure.

Exercise 4.2: Define ONE Solution to Test Within Ninety Days

Take your problem and design one intervention that you could implement and evaluate within ninety days. Simple enough that you can actually execute it without requiring permissions or resources you don't have. Concrete enough that ninety days from now you can measure — without self-deception — whether it worked or failed.

Write down your hypothesis about what will happen if you implement this solution. Write down what evidence would prove you right or wrong. Make yourself accountable to something other than your own optimism.

Exercise 4.3: Find ONE Partner Who Commits to the Ninety-Day Duration

You cannot do this alone. You shouldn't try. Find one person who will commit to working with you for the full ninety days — understanding that commitment means showing up even when enthusiasm fades and obstacles appear.

Choose someone with skills or perspectives that complement yours rather than duplicate them. Have an honest conversation about what you're attempting, why it matters, and what you're asking from them. Don't oversell. Don't promise what you can't deliver. Start the relationship with honesty.

Exercise 4.4: Begin TODAY

Take one concrete action today that moves your solution from idea to reality. Not planning. Not more thinking. Not additional research that functions as sophisticated procrastination.

Action that produces a visible result — however small — that you can point to as evidence that you've started. Send the email. Make the phone call. Schedule the meeting. Buy the necessary supplies. Recruit the first participant. Create the first system. Whatever your specific intervention requires to move from intention to implementation.

Today. Not tomorrow. Not next week. Not when conditions improve.

Today.

Mission Checkpoint

Before moving to the next chapter, complete these honestly. Not as intellectual exercises. As actual commitments with names, dates, and actions.

- ☐ Problem identified with specific details — what, where, and who is affected
- ☐ Solution declared with clear hypothesis and success metrics
- ☐ Partner found who has committed to the ninety-day duration
- ☐ Day one started with concrete action taken today, not planned for tomorrow

If you can check all four boxes honestly — you're no longer just reading a book.

You're building a revolution.

If you cannot check all four boxes — go back and do the work. Because understanding without action is just another form of mediocrity dressed up as intellectual engagement. Another way of feeling like you're contributing while contributing nothing. Another way of watching India wait.

The revolution is not coming someday when conditions improve.

The revolution is not waiting for someone more qualified to start it.

The revolution is not dependent on government finally deciding to do its job.

The revolution is here.

Now.

Waiting for you to accept responsibility for the piece of it that only you can build — because of your unique combination of location and skills and relationships and perspectives that nobody else on earth possesses.

Subhash Deshmukh didn't wait for a revolution: He built one. One brick at a time. In a village nobody had heard of.

**With nothing but his hands, his character, and his refusal
to accept
that the life he was born into was the only life available
to him.**

You have more than he had.

You have this book. You have this framework. You have the knowledge of what's possible when a human being simply refuses to wait.

What's your excuse?

Questions for Reflection

- According to the chapter, why is personal responsibility important for national progress?
- What does the author mean by "average thinking creates average nations"?
- How can small daily decisions shape a person's future success?
- Why is blaming society or the system not enough to create change?
- What is one responsibility you avoid but know you should improve?
- Which daily routine would make the biggest positive impact on your life if followed consistently?
- If you became a leader tomorrow, what responsibility would matter most to you?

A HUNGER-FREE, EDUCATED INDIA

The Three Hungers That Must Be Fed

Hunger is not always loud.

It doesn't always announce itself through growling stomachs or desperate pleas for food or the skeletal frames that appear in charity advertisements designed to extract guilt-driven donations from comfortable people who would rather donate than think.

Sometimes hunger lives in the eyes of a child who sits quietly in class — too proud or too ashamed to admit that the lunch box in her bag is empty because there was no food to pack this morning.

Sometimes it's a mother faking a smile, telling her children she's already eaten — even though she hasn't had a bite. She does it so they don't go to bed hungry. Because that's what mothers do when there's not enough to go around. They eat

last. They eat nothing. They call it choice when it is anything but.

Sometimes it's a father whose face is worn through — bouncing between jobs, skipping meals, grabbing a few hours of sleep here and there. He pushes himself to the edge, making sure everyone else eats, even as his own health falls apart from the constant grind. He doesn't complain. He was taught that men don't. So he just keeps going — until he can't.

This kind of hunger hides well. Most people never spot it. Because pride keeps it out of sight. People choose to struggle quietly, hoping no one will see their need. The world isn't always kind to those who admit they're not okay. And so this hunger works slowly. It chips away at health, at hope, at the capacity to imagine something better. After a while, people forget what it's like to eat without guilt or worry. To sleep without counting the hours until the next meal. To dream about anything beyond just making it through another day.

But hunger is not one thing.

Hunger is three distinct deprivations — that often appear together but require different responses, different interventions, different kinds of commitment from those of us who have enough and want others to have enough too.



The First Hunger: The Body

The first hunger is the hunger of the body.

The most obvious. The most immediate. The most undeniable form of deprivation.

This is the hunger that keeps millions of Indians trapped in a cage they cannot escape no matter how hard they work or how desperately they try.

When your body is hungry, everything else becomes secondary. You cannot think clearly when your stomach is empty and your mind is consumed by the need for food. You cannot work productively when malnutrition has weakened your muscles and stolen your energy. You cannot plan for the future when the present is an unending emergency that demands all your attention and all your resources and still leaves you short.

The hunger of the body creates a trap that catches people and doesn't release them.

Hungry people cannot work as hard or as effectively as well-fed people, which means they earn less, which means they can afford less food, which means they remain hungry. Hungry children cannot learn as well as well-fed children, which means they fall behind in school, which means they get less education, which means they qualify for worse jobs, which means their own children will likely be hungry too.

The cycle perpetuates itself across generations. Across

decades. Across lifetimes. Unless someone intervenes decisively enough to break it.

This is not a natural disaster. This is not inevitable. This is a failure of systems and a failure of will — a collective decision, made by omission if not commission, that some people's hunger is acceptable collateral damage for a progress that somehow never reaches them.

The Second Hunger: The Mind

The second hunger is the hunger of the mind.

This often exists even when the hunger of the body has been addressed. And which is, in its own way, just as crippling.

This is the child whose stomach is full but whose school is broken. Whose teachers don't show up — or show up and don't care. Whose curriculum is decades out of date and teaches nothing useful for the economy that the child will eventually need to navigate. Whose classroom has forty students and one exhausted teacher, and no resources and no hope of improvement because the system was designed to process children, not educate them.

This is the young person who completed their education but learned only theory without practical application. Who memorised facts without developing the ability to think critically, solve real problems, or create value that markets will reward. Who received a certificate that proves they sat through years of schooling, but cannot tell you what those years actually prepared them for.

The hunger of the mind is perhaps more insidious than the hunger of the body.

Because it's less visible. Because it's easier to ignore. Because a hungry body announces itself through physical symptoms that cannot be hidden for long — but a hungry mind suffers quietly, its potential withering unseen, its dreams dying before they're even fully formed.

When we fill stomachs but leave minds empty, we create a different kind of poverty. One that is almost as destructive as the physical kind. One that feels like progress — because the person is no longer starving — but is in fact only a different form of imprisonment. A more comfortable cage. A prison with better food.

An India that feeds its people but fails to educate them has not solved poverty. It has merely postponed it by one generation and made it slightly harder to see.

The Third Hunger: Dignity

The third hunger is the hunger of dignity.

And this one breaks people before poverty does.

This is the farmer who must beg for loans from moneylenders who treat him with contempt. The daily wage laborer who waits outside construction sites, hoping to be chosen, like cattle at an auction, selected or dismissed by a foreman who doesn't know his name and doesn't want to. The mother who has to accept charity

wrapped in judgment and condescension from people who think their wealth makes them superior. Those who take the help with gratitude because they have no choice — and feel something die inside themselves every time they do.

This hunger doesn't come from lack of food or education. It comes from a lack of respect. From being treated as less than fully human. From living in a system that constantly reinforces the message that your poverty makes you worthless — that you are a problem to be managed rather than a person to be honoured.

Dignity cannot be separated from material conditions because it's nearly impossible to maintain dignity when you're desperate.

When you don't know where your next meal is coming from, you'll accept help on degrading terms — because the alternative is worse. When you cannot feed your family through your own labor, you'll tolerate being treated badly by those who offer assistance — because pride is a luxury that hungry people cannot afford.

The hunger for dignity kills something essential in the human spirit. Something that matters as much as food and education. Because without dignity, people stop believing they deserve better. They accept their suffering as inevitable rather than as an injustice that should be — that must be — fought. They stop imagining. They stop reaching. They stop.

And a nation full of people who have stopped is not a nation

building toward greatness. It is a nation managing its own decline.



Twenty Years of Warfare in Solapur

For the past twenty years in Solapur, we have been waging war against all three hungers.

Through a model that refuses to separate material assistance from human dignity.

Through a philosophy that insists: if you cannot help someone while respecting them, then you are not helping them. You are using them to feel good about yourself.

Every single day, we feed five hundred and fifty people.

Not because they've filled out applications demonstrating their worthiness for our charity. Not because they've proven they're poor enough to deserve help. Not because they've agreed to listen to a lecture or attend a religious service or demonstrate appropriate gratitude in whatever form we've decided to require before releasing the food.

We feed them because they're hungry and we have food.

That should be reason enough.

It is reason enough.

We don't call them beneficiaries — a term that creates hierarchy and reinforces the power imbalance between

those who give and those who receive. We call them guests. Because that is what they are. Guests in our community. Entitled to the same respect and hospitality we would offer anyone else we invited to share a meal.

The food we serve is not leftovers. Not the cheapest ingredients available to minimise costs. Not food that technically qualifies as nutrition, but communicates through every bite that the people eating it don't matter enough for anything better.

The food is good. Nutritious. Prepared with care. Because dignity requires treating people as though their well-being matters as much as anyone else's. Because the message of a meal is not just in the calories. It's in the care with which it was made.

Food in this context is not just nutrition for the body.

Food is reassurance that someone cares. That you haven't been forgotten. That your suffering has been witnessed by people who consider it their responsibility to respond. Food becomes a statement — you belong to a community that will not let you starve. Your life has value regardless of your economic circumstances. You deserve to eat with dignity rather than as a transaction that diminishes you while supposedly helping you.

The Debt That Steals Futures

The mass marriage initiative addresses the hunger for dignity in a different way.

By attacking the organised suffocation that rural Indian families call culture, when it is really just a system of extraction that benefits no one except moneylenders.

Wedding debt traps families in cycles of obligation that take ten to fifteen years to escape. Assuming they escape at all. During those years, every rupee earned must first service the debt before it can be used for anything else. Children's education gets deferred because wedding loans must be repaid. Medical needs get ignored because wedding loans take priority. Business opportunities get missed because there is no capital available for anything except debt repayment. Dreams get shelved — not because they were impossible but because the family's future was mortgaged before the marriage that was supposed to celebrate it.

We remove the debt.

And in removing the debt, we remove the despair.

We don't eliminate weddings. We don't suggest that cultural traditions should be abandoned or that the rituals that mark major life transitions have no value. We eliminate the financial destruction that has become attached to those traditions — proving that celebration doesn't require bankruptcy and that cultural practices can be honoured without economic suicide.

In twenty years, we've facilitated over three thousand five hundred debt-free marriages.

That is seven thousand individuals who started their lives together with freedom instead of obligation. With the

possibility instead of a predetermined financial struggle. With the gift that no one should have to earn — the gift of a beginning that is not already an ending.

Just before COVID, we fed over one lakh people during a single mass marriage ceremony. Turning what is typically an exclusive family event into an inclusive community celebration where everyone belongs, and everyone eats — regardless of their relationship to the couple getting married.

This is culture reclaimed from the extractive systems that have corrupted it. Tradition is practiced in ways that strengthen communities rather than impoverish them. Celebration that builds up rather than tears down. Joy that doesn't carry a bill that arrives three months later and haunts you for fifteen years.

The School That Refuses to Fail Them

Education completes the trinity of interventions that address all three hungers simultaneously.

At Shri Ram Prathisthan, fifty percent of students study completely free.

Because we understand that talent and potential are distributed evenly across all economic classes — but opportunity is not that the child born into poverty is not less intelligent or less capable or less deserving than the child born into comfort. Only less lucky. And luck should not be a prerequisite for education.

We don't just waive fees and then provide the same inadequate education that failing public schools offer. We don't reduce 'free' to mean 'cheap.' We provide a value-based curriculum that develops character alongside capability — teaching students not just what to think but how to think. Not just how to pass examinations but why integrity matters, what responsibility looks like in practice, and what it means to be a person of genuine substance in a world that increasingly rewards performance over reality.

We've built skill labs where students pick up real-world abilities — the kind employers actually want, not just the textbook knowledge that looks good on paper but doesn't help much when it's time to get a job. You discover that everything you studied prepared you for an economy that stopped existing years ago. Students work with their hands. They solve real problems. They leave school knowing they can actually do things — not just recite things.

We hire women teachers first.

Not as a symbolic gesture toward gender representation. Because girls learn better and feel safer when they see women leading the way. Because a girl who has never seen a woman in a position of authority has been given a ceiling before she was given a chance. We remove the ceiling.

In rural areas, we run an entrepreneurship school. Here, students learn to spot problems and turn them into opportunities. They don't wait for someone else to fix things — they learn how to fix things themselves. They learn that the gap between a problem and a solution is not filled by the

government or by some distant institution but by the person who is standing close enough to the problem to understand it and willing enough to try.

We provide free transportation for girls to school.

For many families, distance and safety concerns keep daughters at home. Keep them out of classrooms. Keep them out of futures that were always theirs to claim. We remove that barrier. Because we are not okay with the idea that where you live — or how much money your family has — should decide whether you get an education or stay stuck without choices.

Everything we do in education starts with one conviction.

Education sets you free.

It is the surest path out of poverty and into a life where you make decisions rather than having decisions made for you. Where you build the world rather than inherit whatever's left after others have taken what they want. Where you stop settling for the world as it is — and start building the world as it should be.

The Formula That Changes Everything

The formula is simple, even if the execution is complex.

Food + Knowledge + Dignity = Transformation

Feed the body — so people have the energy and health to work, learn, and build. Feed the mind — so people have the skills and understanding to create value, solve problems, and navigate an economy that's constantly changing beneath their feet. Feed the spirit through dignity and respect — so people believe they deserve better, have the confidence to reach for better, and refuse to accept suffering as their permanent condition.

Each element is necessary. None is sufficient alone.

A fed body without an educated mind produces a stronger version of the same trapped person. An educated mind without dignity produces someone who knows exactly how badly they've been failed — and has no power to change it. Dignity without food or education is an abstraction that cannot feed a child or secure a future.

All three. Together. Always.

This is warfare.

Though not the kind that uses bullets or bombs or the violent apparatus that most people associate with the word. This is a different kind of war — fought in kitchens and classrooms and community halls, in the quiet decisions to show up every day and serve and teach and protect and build.

Every meal we serve is a bullet fired at hunger — an act of resistance against systems that would rather people starve

than admit those systems are broken. Every classroom we build is a fortress against ignorance — a protected space where learning can happen and potential can develop, away from the chaos and dysfunction that surrounds it. Every wedding we facilitate without debt is a shield against the organised extraction that masquerades as culture — protection for families who would otherwise be crushed by obligations they never chose but cannot refuse.

We are at war.

And we are winning.

One meal at a time. One student at a time. One family at a time.



The Thirty-Day Plan: Your War Begins Here

The thirty-day plan I'm giving you is not aspirational. It is not theoretical. It does not require wealth you don't have or skills you haven't developed or permissions from authorities who might never grant them.

It requires only three things.

Commitment to start. Persistence to continue. Willingness to learn from mistakes and adjust based on what actually works — rather than what you hoped would work.

That's it. That's the entire barrier between you and action.

Everything else is an excuse.

Days 1–3: Feed One Person Daily

Not through a donation to an organisation that will feed people on your behalf. Not through a financial transaction where you write a check and walk away feeling good about yourself. Feed someone directly. Buy a meal. Cook food. Share what you have. Experience what it feels like to be the person who ensures someone else doesn't go hungry today. Look at them. Know their name if you can. Understand that this is not charity — this is human beings doing what human beings should do for each other.

Days 4–7: Visit One School in Your Area

Not to judge. Not to criticize. Not to arrive with all the answers before you've understood the questions. Go to understand what's actually happening in our education system. What resources exist, and what's missing? What students need and aren't getting. What teachers are dealing with that nobody talks about. What the gap is between what's promised and what's delivered. Sit in a classroom if they'll let you. Talk to a teacher. Talk to a student. Let reality teach you something that statistics never can.

Days 8–14: Start One Micro-Initiative

Based on what you learned during your school visit, start something. Maybe it's tutoring one student weekly. Maybe it's raising money to buy books or supplies the school lacks. Maybe it's organising parents to advocate for better conditions.

Maybe it's as simple as painting a wall, fixing a broken desk, or donating a fan to a classroom that's been sweltering through every summer. Something small. Something concrete. Something that moves from observation to action, from witnessing to doing. Because witnessing without acting is just a more comfortable form of looking away.

Days 15–30: *Document, Measure, Teach*

Write down what you did. Measure whether your intervention made any difference — honestly, without inflating the impact to make yourself feel better. Figure out how to scale it beyond yourself. And then teach someone else how to replicate it because the goal is not to create a project that depends on you. The goal is to create a model that outlives your involvement. Heroes do not build a revolution. It is built by people who teach others how to do what they've learned to do — until the doing becomes a habit and the habit becomes a culture and the culture becomes a country.



Why This Matters More Than You Think

You might be reading this and thinking: feeding one person a day is a small thing. Visiting one school is a small thing. Starting a micro-initiative is a small thing.

You are right. These are small things.

But consider what Subhash Deshmukh did with small things.

He started with a kirana shop. Small. He started with a tyre repair shop. Small. He started with two cows. Small. He accepted eight hundred rupees to help build a check dam. Small. Each of these things — viewed in isolation, viewed on the day they began — was nothing. A grain of sand. A single stitch. A whisper in a country full of noise.

But he kept going.

And small things, done consistently over time by a person who refuses to stop, become large things. Become factories. Become cooperatives. Become communities that are fed, educated, and protected. Become the proof that a different India is not a dream — it is a construction project. One brick at a time. By one person at a time. In one village at a time.

India has a billion small things waiting to happen.

The question is not whether they are possible.

The question is whether you will be one of the people who make them happen.

The three hungers are real. They exist in your city. In your neighbourhood. Within walking distance of wherever you are sitting right now, reading these words. There is a child nearby whose lunch box is empty. There is a family nearby whose future is being quietly mortgaged by debt they cannot escape. There is a young person nearby whose potential is

withering in a broken school system that was never designed to develop them.

You don't have to fix all of it.

You don't have to fix most of it.

You have to fix the piece that is in front of you.

That is all that is required. That is also everything that is required.

Your Turn

Now it is time for you to stop being a passive reader and become an active participant in this revolution we are building together.

Exercise 5.1: Feed One Person Daily for the Next Thirty Days

Commit to ensuring that one person who would otherwise go hungry gets fed every single day for the next month. This cannot be outsourced to an organisation or reduced to a financial transaction where you write a check and forget about it.

You need to be personally involved in the act of feeding someone. This might mean cooking extra food and giving it to someone who needs it. It might mean buying a meal for the person who begs near your office or home. It might mean identifying a family in your neighbourhood that's struggling and regularly providing groceries or home-cooked meals. The point is direct personal engagement with

the reality of hunger — and the practice of addressing it through your own action, with your own hands, with your own presence.

Do not delegate this. Do not outsource this. Do this yourself because the point is not just the food. The point is the connection. The point is the transformation that happens in you when you regularly face hunger directly — when it is no longer an abstraction or a statistic but a specific person you know and whose well-being you have taken personal responsibility for.

Exercise 5.2: Mentor One Child Monthly for the Next Year

Find one child who needs educational support and commit to mentoring that child at least once per month for the next twelve months. This is not tutoring where you help with homework and then disappear until the next session. This is mentorship where you take a genuine interest in the child's development — their struggles and dreams, their family situation and the obstacles they face.

Meet with them regularly. Ask about their progress. Help them think through problems. Connect them to resources they need. Be someone they can trust and depend on consistently — who shows up even when it's inconvenient, who remembers what you discussed last time, who treats them as a person with a future rather than as a project you're managing for your own satisfaction.

For many of these children, you might be the first adult outside their family who has ever taken their potential

seriously. That matters more than you know. It may be the thing they remember twenty years from now when they're the ones mentoring someone else's child.

Exercise 5.3: Protect One Family from Debt This Year

Identify one family in your network or community that's facing potential financial disaster — because of an upcoming wedding, medical emergency, or some other crisis that will force them into debt they cannot afford. Figure out how to help them avoid that debt.

This might mean direct financial assistance if you can afford it. It might mean organising collective support from others who share your values and your understanding of what debt does to families. It might mean connecting them to resources and programs they don't know exist — cooperative loan schemes, community foundations, government support that people rarely access because they don't know it's available.

The goal is to prevent the debt trap from closing on one more family. Demonstrating that communities can protect their members when they choose to act collectively. Proving that the hunger of dignity — the hunger that breaks people before poverty does — can be fought and won, not through grand schemes but through the decision of one person to stand between a family and the abyss.

Mission Checkpoint

Before you move to the next chapter, verify that you've actually begun these commitments. Not that you've thought about them. Not that you intend to begin. That you've begun.

- ☐ I am feeding one person daily and have done so for at least seven consecutive days
- ☐ I have identified a child to mentor and scheduled our first meeting
- ☐ I have identified a family to protect from debt and created a concrete plan to help them

If you cannot honestly check all three boxes — you're still consuming rather than building.

Go back and do what you said you would do.

Because revolution is not reading about change. Revolution is actually creating it — through actions that cost something, that require sustained commitment over time, rather than one-time gestures that make you feel good but accomplish nothing lasting.

The Three Hungers don't disappear because you understood them intellectually. They don't diminish because you felt moved reading about them. They require a response. Direct, personal, sustained, inconvenient response.

Subhash Deshmukh fed people. He educated people. He protected people from the debt that was designed to keep

them small, dependent, and grateful. He did this not because he had infinite resources or institutional backing or a government mandate.

He did it because he could.

And because he could, he believed he should.

And because he believed he should, he did.

You can: Therefore, you should.

Therefore — begin.

Questions for Reflection

- Why does the chapter connect hunger with human dignity?
- How can education change not only individuals but entire families?
- Why is dependency harmful even when help is provided with good intentions?
- What role should citizens play in improving education and nutrition in India?
- Describe one teacher, mentor, or family member who positively influenced your growth.
- What simple step could your school, college, or community take to help underprivileged children?
- What does true empowerment mean according to this chapter?

THE ENEMY WITHIN: MEDIOCRITY

How 'Chalta Hai' Is Killing a Nation

Mediocrity is the silent assassin.

It doesn't announce itself with drama or violence or the sudden catastrophic collapse that gets attention and triggers an emergency response. It doesn't arrive on a date you can mark on a calendar or declare a moment of crisis that demands action. It slips in like fog that gradually obscures vision — until you can't see more than a few feet ahead, until you've forgotten what clear sight looks like, until you've accepted limited visibility as normal and stopped bothering to look further than your immediate circumstances.

It kills nations slowly enough that people don't notice they're dying until it's too late to save themselves.

Nations fall when people become comfortable. When the hunger that drives improvement gets satisfied by conditions

that are good enough to be tolerable — but not good enough to be celebrated. Comfort dulls ambition the way too much food dulls appetite. When you're comfortable, the pain of staying where you are becomes less than the pain of pushing toward something better. When you're comfortable, risk feels dangerous rather than exciting — because you have something to lose and losing it seems worse than never gaining more.

Comfort blurs vision because it creates the illusion that your current position is sustainable indefinitely. That the world will remain static and allow you to remain static, too. That you can stop growing and learning and pushing — without consequences.

But here's what comfortable people consistently fail to understand until circumstances force the lesson upon them.

Mediocrity is not neutral.

Mediocrity is not the safe middle ground between failure and excellence, where you can rest permanently without sliding backward. Mediocrity in a competitive world is slow decline disguised as stability — because while you're standing still, everyone else is moving forward. What feels like maintaining position is actually losing ground relative to others who refuse to accept good enough as their permanent condition.

So let me be very clear about what mediocrity actually is. Because most people misunderstand it in ways that allow it to persist unchallenged — hiding in plain sight, wearing the

face of pragmatism and realism and reasonable acceptance of limitations.

Mediocrity is not failure.

Failure is honest. Failure is attempting something difficult and coming up short. Failure generates data about what doesn't work and creates the possibility of learning and trying again differently. Failure can be respected — because it represents effort and risk and willingness to attempt something where success wasn't guaranteed.

Mediocrity is something else entirely.

Mediocrity is the quiet acceptance of good enough when better is possible. Mediocrity is settling for outcomes you know are substandard — because improving them would require effort or discomfort or sacrifice you're unwilling to provide. Mediocrity is the half-hearted attempt. The work done was just barely enough to avoid being called lazy, but not enough to achieve anything worth celebrating. Mediocrity is fear of excellence disguised as realism. The refusal to reach for more — pretending to be a mature acceptance of limitations.

It wears many faces in India. Four faces in particular. Four monsters that breed mediocrity in our society — four patterns of behaviour and thought that seem harmless individually but collectively create a culture where excellence becomes rare, substandard performance becomes normalised, and the very idea of demanding better begins to feel unreasonable.



The Four Monsters

MONSTER 1: Chalta Hai

This phrase should be banned from the Indian vocabulary.

Not because language policing works. But because of how much damage it causes every single time someone speaks, it is made quietly and wrongly, in offices and workshops and government buildings and homes and schools and everywhere that the decision between adequate and excellent is made quietly and wrongly.

Every time you say chalta hai, you lower the national standard by one tiny notch. One small notch. Invisible, almost. Harmless, seemingly. But multiply that notch by a billion people making that same small concession every single day — and you understand why a nation of extraordinary people produces ordinary results.

Every time you accept work that's inadequate but tolerable, you train the person who did it that inadequate is acceptable. Every time you shrug off a problem that could be fixed, you make it harder for the next person to demand better — because you've reinforced the pattern. You've voted, silently and decisively, for the lower standard.

Chalta hai is not harmless flexibility. It is not a practical accommodation to imperfect reality. It is not the wisdom of someone who has learned to pick their battles.

Chalta hai is cowardice dressed as pragmatism.

It is the refusal to hold standards and demand quality, pretending to be a reasonable acceptance of constraints. It is the slow collective agreement that we are not capable of excellence, so we should stop expecting it from ourselves or anyone else.

And the most insidious thing about chalta hai is that it spreads. One person says it, and the next person says it, and soon the entire room says it — and the standard that was once considered inadequate becomes the new baseline. And then the next round of chalta hai lowers it again. And again. And again. Until we are so far below where we should be that we have genuinely forgotten what the original standard looked like.

MONSTER 2: Comfort Fever

The disease of instant gratification — and modern technology has made it epidemic.

Food delivered in ten minutes. Validation is received in one second after you post something on social media. Entertainment is available instantly without any effort required to find it or engage with it meaningfully. The dopamine hits come so fast and so frequently that our brains recalibrate to expect immediate reward for minimal effort.

This makes it nearly impossible to build discipline. Because discipline requires delaying gratification — enduring discomfort now for benefit later, investing effort without immediate return, working toward distant goals that won't

deliver satisfaction for months or years. The comfort fever that modern life induces makes us incapable of the delayed gratification that all worthwhile achievement requires.

Think about what it takes to build a business. You work for months before anyone pays you. You invest money before you make money. You endure uncertainty and setbacks and the particular loneliness of building something that doesn't yet exist. None of that delivers a dopamine hit. None of that gives you immediate feedback that you're doing well. All of it requires the ability to keep going without the reward that comfort fever has trained you to expect constantly.

Subhash Deshmukh didn't have comfort fever. He couldn't afford it. The poultry factory paid him no dopamine hits. The kirana shop offered no instant validation. The tyre shop provided no viral moments. He just worked — for years — before anything recognisable as success appeared. The ability to do that, to sustain effort across the long dark period before results arrive, is the most important capability a builder can have.

And it is the capability that comfort fever destroys.

MONSTER 3: Credential Worship

The collective delusion that degrees and certificates prove capability, when they often prove nothing except that someone successfully navigated an examination system.

We produce engineers who cannot wire a simple circuit or fix a motor — because their education was mostly theoretical rather than practical. We graduate MBAs who

have never closed a sale or managed a real team or made a decision where failure would have actual consequences — because business school is a simulation rather than reality. The paper has value in our credentialing system. The person holding the paper often doesn't have the skills the paper supposedly certifies.

This creates a dangerous inversion. Credentials matter more than capability. Appearing qualified becomes more important than actually being qualified. People invest years pursuing degrees that make them look professional, rather than developing skills that would make them actually useful.

The hired engineer cannot fix the motor. The MBA who cannot manage the team. The commerce graduate who cannot maintain the balance sheet. These are not hypothetical failures — they are the daily reality of an education system that produces credential holders rather than capability builders.

Meanwhile, Subhash Deshmukh, the high school dropout from Wadala, built a sugar factory. Hired an engineer who had never built a sugar factory. Built it anyway. Because he didn't have a credential to hide behind, he had only capability. And capability — real, tested, hard-won capability — turns out to be worth considerably more.

MONSTER 4: Applause Addiction

The hunger for fame and attention and social validation — made catastrophically worse by social media, which made it

possible to collect followers and likes and shares without actually accomplishing anything real.

People want fame without work. They want followers without responsibility for those followers. They chase visibility rather than capability — because visibility feels like success even when it represents nothing except successful self-promotion.

A reel is not a skill.

A viral post is not an achievement.

Ten thousand followers who don't know you and couldn't identify you on the street are not a community.

But we've started treating these things as though they matter — as though collecting attention online is equivalent to building something real in the world. This addiction to applause makes people perform for audiences rather than doing work that matters regardless of whether anyone is watching or applauding.

The work that builds nations is almost never applauded in real time. Nobody gave Subhash Deshmukh a standing ovation for showing up at a poultry factory before dawn. Nobody went viral for digging a borewell in a drought-hit village. Nobody got followers for mentoring a young entrepreneur who went on to employ hundreds of people. The work that actually matters is largely invisible — done in the quiet hours, for reasons that have nothing to do with being seen.

Applause addiction makes people incapable of doing that work. Because if nobody's watching, they stop doing it.

And that is how the most important work in the world never gets done.



The Cost of These Four Monsters

These four monsters combine to weaken nations in ways that are measurable — even if the mechanisms are subtle and the damage accumulates slowly enough to be deniable.

Mediocrity shrinks GDP — because productivity suffers when people are doing substandard work and accepting substandard results. Mediocrity increases migration — because talented people leave environments where excellence is punished or ignored for environments where it's rewarded and celebrated. Mediocrity encourages corruption — because when standards are already low, lowering them further through bribery or cheating seems like a minor additional compromise rather than a fundamental betrayal of integrity.

Mediocrity punishes excellence.

This is perhaps the most destructive effect of all. When mediocrity becomes the norm, excellent people stand out in ways that trigger resentment rather than admiration. The person who arrives early, who does more than required, who refuses to accept *chalta hai*, becomes threatening to those

whose mediocrity is now visible by comparison. Social pressure builds to conform to the mediocre norm rather than exceed it. And slowly, the excellent person stops being excellent. Not because they lost the capacity. Because the environment made excellence too costly to maintain.

This is how mediocre cultures reproduce themselves. Not by defeating excellence. By making excellence too uncomfortable to sustain.

We cannot build a New India like this. We cannot compete with the world like this. We cannot honour the sacrifice of every person who built what we inherited — by accepting less than our full capability in the name of comfort.

The four monsters must be named. Must be confronted. Must be killed.

Not in India's institutions first.

In you. In me. In each of us individually. Before we can demand better from the system, we must demand better from ourselves.



The Five Strategies: War Against Your Own Mediocrity

There is an antidote to mediocrity. And it is available to anyone willing to take it — regardless of their current circumstances, their capabilities, or the mediocre environment they're surrounded by.

The antidote is a systematic approach to personal excellence that becomes habit through repetition — until excellence stops being something you do occasionally and becomes who you are consistently.

Five strategies. Not suggestions. Not options to consider when you have time. Strategies — to be deployed with the deliberate intensity of someone who has finally understood what the enemy is and what it will cost them if they don't defeat it.

STRATEGY 1: *The Daily Discomfort Ritual*

Most people design their mornings around comfort. Alarm set as late as possible. Coffee before thought. Phone before intention. The day begins in reaction mode — responding to whatever the world throws at them — because they never established the discipline to begin it in creation mode.

The daily discomfort ritual flips this.

Wake early — before your comfort wants you to. Earlier than you think is reasonable. Earlier than everyone around you. Use those quiet hours for yourself, not for the world's demands. Take a cold shower that shocks your system awake and proves — physically, viscerally — that you can endure discomfort voluntarily. This matters more than it sounds. Because every morning you choose discomfort over comfort, you build the psychological muscle that excellence requires. You train yourself to move toward difficulty rather than away from it. You deposit in the account of self-discipline that will pay interest for the rest of the day.

Spend thirty minutes reading something challenging — something that expands your thinking rather than just confirming what you already believe. Spend another thirty minutes practicing a skill that's difficult enough to require real concentration and effort. A skill that you cannot yet do with ease. A skill that makes you aware of your own incompetence and requires you to sit with that awareness rather than fleeing from it.

This ritual, accomplished before most people are awake, builds the psychological architecture that everything else in this chapter depends on. It is not optional. It is the foundation. Without it, the other strategies have nothing to rest on.

STRATEGY 2: *One New Skill Every Ninety Days*

That is four skills per year. In five years, twenty skills you didn't have before. In ten years, a person of such broad competence that narrow credential worship cannot touch you, because you've built something that no certificate can capture and no algorithm can filter out.

Skills compound the way money compounds when you reinvest the returns. Each new skill makes learning the next skill easier — because you're developing the meta-skill of learning itself. You're building the habit of beginning at incompetence and pushing through to competence — a habit that, once built, becomes the most valuable thing you possess.

Make the skill specific enough that you can evaluate whether you've actually learned it. Not 'improve my communication' but 'deliver five presentations without notes.' Not 'get better at writing' but 'publish ten articles of at least one thousand words each.' Not 'learn coding' but 'build one functional application from scratch.'

Specific. Measurable. Achievable in ninety days with disciplined effort. And then — when ninety days are up, and the skill is acquired — immediately choose the next one. Do not rest. Do not celebrate too long. Begin again.

This is how Arvind from Beed became extraordinary. Not through a single dramatic transformation. Through ninety days, then ninety days again, then ninety days again. Until the person who woke at four thirty one morning and began was unrecognisable from the person looking back from the mirror.

STRATEGY 3: *The Accountability Pod*

Individual willpower is unreliable. Every person who has ever set a New Year's resolution and abandoned it by February knows this. Willpower is a resource that depletes. Motivation is a mood that passes. Inspiration is a feeling that fades.

Commitment to other people is different. Commitment to other people has social stakes. It engages your reputation and your sense of identity within a group you respect. It creates consequences for failure that matter — not physical consequences, but social ones. The particular discomfort of

being the person who didn't do what they said they would do, in front of people whose opinion matters to you.

Form an accountability pod with two or three people who are similarly committed to excellence and growth. Not people who will be easy on you. Not people who will say 'that's okay, you tried.' People who care enough about you and about their own integrity to be honest — who will hold you to what you said you would do.

Meet weekly. Set specific targets for the coming week. Report honestly on whether you hit last week's targets. Show receipts — actual evidence that you did what you committed to doing. Make the group small enough that you cannot hide, and everyone's participation matters.

The accountability pod works because it transforms private intention into public commitment. And public commitment — made to people you respect — is one of the most powerful forces in human psychology. It is stronger than motivation. Stronger than inspiration. Stronger than almost any external incentive.

Use it. Build it. Protect it.

STRATEGY 4: *Two Hours of Production for Every Hour of Consumption*

Track this ratio for one week, and you will be disturbed by what you find.

Production means creating something that didn't exist before you made the effort to create it — writing, building,

making, teaching, solving, designing, growing. Something that leaves a mark on the world, however small. Consumption means entertaining yourself with content that other people produced — scrolling, watching, listening, reading, without applying, absorbing without creating.

Both have their place. Consumption feeds the mind with raw material. But consumption without production is like eating without exercise — you accumulate without transforming, you receive without giving back, you grow heavier without growing stronger.

Production is evolution. It develops your capabilities and leaves something behind. It proves to you — concretely, undeniably — that you can create value, that you have something to contribute, that you are not merely a recipient of other people's effort but a generator of your own.

The two-to-one ratio is not a law. It is a direction. A commitment to spending at least twice as much time creating as you spend consuming. Most people who track this honestly for the first time discover their ratio is inverted — ten hours of consumption for every thirty minutes of production. The gap between where they are and where they should be is so large that it is briefly paralysing.

Good. Let it paralyse you for one day. Then begin.

STRATEGY 5: *The Failure Log*

Most people hide their failures. Bury them. Pretend they didn't happen. Move on quickly and hope nobody noticed, and never speak of them again.

This is precisely backwards.

Your failures are your most valuable data. They are evidence that you attempted something difficult enough to involve the possibility of failure. They contain the most precise information available about where you need to grow — information that success never provides, because success tells you what worked but not what would have worked better.

The failure log is a simple discipline. After every significant failure — every project that fell short, every commitment you didn't keep, every target you missed — write down three things you tried, what you learned from the attempt, regardless of the outcome. What will you do differently next time based on that learning?

Publishing failures — even just to yourself in a private log — removes the shame and fear that usually surrounds them. When failure becomes data rather than disaster, you can take risks you would otherwise avoid. You can attempt things at the edge of your capability rather than staying safely in the centre of what you already know you can do.

Over months and years, the failure log becomes something remarkable. It becomes a record of your growth. A chronology of everything you dared to attempt. Proof that you were the kind of person who tried difficult things — and proof that each failure made you smarter about how to try again.

Look back through it when you feel like quitting. Read the failures you survived. Remember that you are still here — still building, still learning, still refusing to stop. And then — do not stop.



Arvind from Beed: What Discipline Actually Looks Like

Let me tell you about Arvind.

Not because his story is dramatic. Not because it involves a single transformative moment, a lucky break, or a natural gift that set him apart from everyone around him. But precisely because it involves none of those things.

Arvind from Beed was not a topper. His academic record was thoroughly average — the kind of record that recruiters scan and set aside, that opens no doors and impresses no one. He was not fluent in English. Not comfortable with the polished professional presentation that corporate environments typically reward. He did not come from a connected family. Did not study at a prestigious institution. Did not have a network that could place him in rooms he hadn't yet earned the right to enter.

By every conventional measure, Arvind should not have succeeded in ways that stand out or deserve attention.

But Arvind had something that his more credentialed peers mostly lacked.

Discipline.

That old-fashioned virtue that modern culture has mostly abandoned in favour of looking for shortcuts and hacks and life optimisations that promise results without the boring, unglamorous, unsexy work that actually produces results.

Arvind woke at four thirty every morning.

Not because he enjoyed waking early. Not because it felt good or came naturally or was recommended by some productivity guru on YouTube. Because he understood — at a level that went beyond intellectual agreement into actual lived conviction — that discipline requires doing what's necessary regardless of whether it's enjoyable. That the gap between who you are and who you could become is bridged not by inspiration but by the alarm at four thirty that goes off every morning, whether you feel like getting up or not.

He used those quiet early hours for reading. For skill development. For planning his day with intention rather than just reacting to whatever emerges. While his peers were still asleep, Arvind was building. While his peers were scrolling through phones, Arvind was practicing. While his peers were waiting for motivation to arrive, Arvind had already understood that motivation is a visitor that comes after you've started — never before.

This single habit — sustained not for a week or a month but for years — created compounding advantages that his more credentialed peers couldn't match because they were still sleeping while he was building capabilities. Because they

were waiting for the right opportunity, while he was becoming the right person for any opportunity.

In three years, Arvind became a branch manager — despite lacking the educational background that typically qualifies people for management roles. In five years, he became a regional leader responsible for multiple branches and hundreds of people. Today, he mentors over two hundred people who see in him the proof that discipline defeats credentials. That consistency beats intensity. That showing up every day at four thirty in the morning and doing the work — relentlessly, without drama, without waiting to feel ready — creates results that sporadic brilliance never matches.

Arvind's story matters because it proves something that this entire book has been building toward.

Greatness is a decision.

Not a blessing. Not a genetic gift that some people possess and others lack. Not a lucky confluence of circumstances that enabled some and disabled others. Greatness is a choice — made daily, in the dark, before anyone is watching, in the small, quiet decisions to do the difficult thing rather than the comfortable one.

Greatness is available to anyone willing to pay the price that greatness demands.

And that price is always the same.

Disciplined effort sustained longer than comfort would prefer.

Arvind paid it.

Subhash Deshmukh paid it — in a poultry factory before dawn, in a tyre shop covered in grease, in a sugar factory that everybody said could not be built.

The question is whether you will pay it.



The Mirror You Cannot Look Away From

This chapter has been asking you to look at something most people spend their entire lives avoiding.

Themselves.

Not the version they present on social media. Not the version they describe in job interviews. Not the version they perform for people whose opinion they want to manage. The actual version — the one that knows exactly where it has been accepting good enough when better was possible. The one that knows how many alarms have been snoozed. How many commitments have been quietly abandoned? How many times *chalta hai* was the decision when excellence was available?

That version.

Looking at it clearly is not comfortable. It was not meant to be comfortable. Comfort is the enemy. This chapter has been building the case against comfort from every possible angle — and now it makes its final argument.

You cannot build a New India and remain mediocre yourself.

You cannot demand excellence from systems while accepting mediocrity from yourself. You cannot call for accountability in institutions while avoiding accountability in your own life. You cannot inspire others to push past their comfort zones while refusing to push past your own. The revolution that this book is calling for is not abstract. It is not someone else's responsibility. It begins in the specific place where you stop accepting less than your best from yourself.

That is the leap.

That is the hardest thing this book will ask of you.

Not to feed someone, start a ninety-day project, join a cooperative, or mentor two people.

To declare war on your own mediocrity. Every day. Without applause. Without a viral moment. Without a certificate of completion. Just you and the enemy within — and the daily decision about which one wins.

Your Turn: Declare War

Now it's time to declare war on your own mediocrity. Because you cannot build a New India while remaining mediocre yourself. And remaining mediocre is a choice —

not a circumstance, not a fate, not the result of what you were given or where you were born.

It is a choice you make every morning when the alarm goes off.

Exercise 6.1: Identify ONE Specific Mediocrity to Kill This Week

Look honestly at your life and find one area where you've been accepting good enough when better is possible. Not vaguely — specifically. Maybe you're chronically late to commitments because you haven't respected other people's time enough to make punctuality non-negotiable. Maybe you do substandard work because nobody's checking carefully, and you've confused absence of feedback with absence of consequence. Maybe you make excuses instead of taking responsibility. Maybe you consume far more than you produce.

Pick one specific mediocrity. Name it without euphemism. And commit to killing it this week — not improving it gradually or working on it when convenient, but killing it completely. Through whatever discomfort that requires. Through whatever embarrassment of admitting that it existed. Through whatever discipline it costs to replace it with something worthy of who you could be.

Exercise 6.2: Commit to ONE Act of Excellence Tomorrow

Choose something you'll do tomorrow that represents your absolute best effort — not adequate effort, not acceptable effort, not the effort that gets the job done, and no one complains. Your best. Something where you'll push past

comfort and convenience to deliver quality that exceeds expectations — your own expectations first, then everyone else's.

It doesn't need to be large or dramatic. Excellence in small things is where excellence begins. A perfectly prepared meeting. A commitment kept with exact precision. A piece of work is sent only when it is genuinely ready rather than merely passable. Choose it. Do it. Notice how it feels different from *chalta hai*. Remember that feeling. Build on it.

Exercise 6.3: Create Your Daily Discomfort Ritual Starting Immediately

Design a morning routine that includes deliberate discomfort and builds the psychological muscles that excellence requires. Wake earlier than comfortable. Take a cold shower. Read something genuinely challenging — not comfortable, not confirming, genuinely challenging. Practice a skill that exposes your current incompetence rather than one you've already mastered.

Whatever specific elements you choose, make them genuinely uncomfortable — not slightly inconvenient, not mildly challenging, genuinely uncomfortable. The point is training yourself to move toward discomfort voluntarily. So that when life imposes discomfort involuntarily — as it will, as it always does — you already have the capacity to endure it. You have practiced. You have built the muscle. You are ready.

Exercise 6.4: Choose Your Next Skill to Learn Over the Next Ninety Days

Select one skill that would make you genuinely more capable in ways that matter for your goals. Not a credential. Not something that looks good on a resume. Something that makes you actually better at doing something that needs doing.

Make it specific enough that you can evaluate honestly whether you've learned it. Not 'get better at public speaking' but 'deliver five presentations without notes to groups of ten or more people.' Not 'improve my writing' but 'write ten articles of at least one thousand words each and publish them.' Specific. Measurable. Achievable in ninety days with disciplined daily effort. Begin today. Not when you feel ready. Today.

Exercise 6.5: Form Your Accountability Pod

Find two other people who are similarly committed to growth and excellence, not comfort and convenience, and the path of least resistance. People who will hold you accountable when you fail to deliver what you promised. People who care enough about you to be honest rather than just supportive.

Schedule weekly meetings where you set targets, report results, and show proof that you did what you committed to doing. Make the group small enough that you cannot hide. Make the commitment serious enough that failing to show up matters. Make the honesty non-negotiable —

because an accountability pod that only celebrates and never challenges is just another form of applause addiction.

Mission Checkpoint

Before moving to the next chapter, verify that you've actually begun transforming yourself — rather than just understanding the concepts intellectually. Understanding is not transformation. Comprehension is not changed. You can understand every word of this chapter and remain exactly as mediocre as when you started — if you don't act.

- ☐ I have identified my specific mediocrity and taken concrete action to kill it this week
- ☐ I have created my daily discomfort ritual and completed it for at least three consecutive days
- ☐ I have chosen my next skill and begun learning it with specific daily practice scheduled
- ☐ I have formed my accountability pod with at least two people and scheduled our first meeting

If you cannot check all four boxes honestly, you're still mediocre. Regardless of how well you understood mediocrity intellectually. Regardless of how moved you were by Arvind's story or how clearly you recognised the Four Monsters in yourself and the people around you.

Knowing what you should change is not the same as changing it.

Go back and do the work.

Because the enemy within is not going to defeat itself through your awareness of its existence, the enemy within requires deliberate, sustained assault — through disciplined action repeated until discipline becomes character and character becomes destiny.

The war against mediocrity is won one morning at a time.

One difficult choice at a time.

One act of excellence at a time — when comfort would have been easier, but you chose difficulty because you understand that difficulty is the price of transformation.

And transformation is the only path to the India we claim we want to build.

Not the India of grand speeches and government schemes and five-year plans that produce reports.

The India of people who wake at four thirty. Who builds in the dark? Who chooses excellence when nobody is watching. Who refuse — absolutely and permanently refuse — to accept *chalta hai* as a way of life.

That India is possible: It has always been possible.

**It is waiting for you to stop accepting less than your best
and start becoming who you were always capable of
being.**

Questions for Reflection

- What internal weaknesses does the author describe as more dangerous than external competition?
- Why can comfort become a trap for young people?
- How do excuses prevent people from achieving their goals?
- What does the chapter teach about self-discipline and self-respect?
- Which habit wastes the most time in your daily life?
- What is one difficult habit you would like to build over the next six months?
- How can mastering yourself help you become a stronger entrepreneur or leader?

THE YOUTH MANIFESTO

War-Room Playbook

Your 90-Day Blueprint to Change Everything

This is not the last chapter. This is the first day.

Youth is not a number on your birth certificate.

It is not a demographic category that statisticians track for government reports or that marketers segment into consumer cohorts.

Youth is temperature.

The heat that transforms societies from solid to liquid. That melts calcified systems and makes new shapes possible. That turns what has always been into what could never have been imagined before the heat arrived.

India doesn't lack young people in the numerical sense. We have hundreds of millions of people under thirty — more young humans concentrated in one geography than most continents possess in total population. The most extraordinary demographic advantage any nation has ever possessed in modern history. A gift of scale and energy and raw potential that, if activated, could remake the world.

What we lack is not youth as age.

What we lack is youth as energy.

Not young people — but activated young people. Not dreamers — but dreamers who have learned to execute their dreams in the messy, resistant, uncooperative reality of actual circumstances. Not people who want to change India — but people who have started.

This chapter is for them.

It is for you.

It is the blueprint for the ninety days that could change everything — not for India in some distant abstract sense, but for you, specifically, in the place you are standing right now, with the resources you currently have, starting from this exact moment.



The Gap Between Dreaming and Doing

There is a profound difference between having dreams and executing them.

Dreams are easy. Dreams cost nothing and demand nothing and can exist indefinitely in your head without ever touching reality or being tested by the friction that reality always applies to good intentions. Dreams let you feel ambitious and purposeful without the discomfort of actually attempting anything where failure is possible. You can dream for decades. You can die dreaming.

Execution is hard. Execution costs time, energy, and reputation. Execution requires translating vague aspirations into specific actions — confronting obstacles that didn't appear in your mental simulations, adjusting when reality refuses to cooperate with your plans, persisting when initial enthusiasm fades, and the work becomes boring and difficult and invisible.

The gap between dreaming and executing is where most potential dies.

Not on battlefields. Not against external enemies. In the quiet daily decision to wait one more day before beginning.

Three enemies fill that gap. Three internal poisons that kill more revolutions than any external opposition ever could. Three forces that must be identified, named, and neutralised before you can build anything meaningful that survives contact with reality.

Enemy One: Distraction

Your focus changes every ten seconds. Not because you're weak — because you've been engineered to be this way. The world's smartest behavioural psychologists designed the apps on your phone specifically to capture and hold your attention through constant novelty and variable reward schedules. Billions of dollars of intelligence are deployed to ensure you never focus on anything long enough to go deep.

This makes sustained focus on difficult tasks nearly impossible. Because difficult tasks require holding attention on one thing long enough to understand it deeply — and to work through the inevitable obstacles that deep work always encounters, you cannot build anything meaningful when your attention span has been reduced to seconds. Building requires hours of sustained focus. Days of returning to the same problem repeatedly. Months of incremental progress that's invisible to outside observers and feels frustratingly slow to the person doing the work.

Distraction is the enemy of depth.

And depth is what separates impressive-sounding ideas from actual solutions that work in practice.

Enemy Two: Directionlessness

Young people often have enormous energy. The problem is rarely a lack of motivation, drive, or willingness to work hard. The problem is that energy without direction dissipates into motion that goes nowhere — busyness that

accomplishes nothing, activity that generates exhaustion but no results.

You can work yourself into the ground and still achieve nothing if your work isn't pointed toward a clear objective that you've defined carefully enough to evaluate whether you're making progress toward it. Directionlessness creates the illusion of productivity because you're always busy, always tired, and always feeling like you're working hard. But working hard on undefined objectives is like running on a treadmill — you're expending energy and experiencing all the discomfort that effort produces, but you're not actually going anywhere. The exhaustion feels virtuous because our culture celebrates busyness and equates activity with value.

But exhaustion without achievement is just a waste.

Noble waste — but waste nonetheless.

Enemy Three: Dependency

The psychological posture of waiting. Waiting for the government to fix broken systems — even though decades of evidence suggest the government lacks either the will or the capacity to fix what you're waiting for them to address. Waiting for your parents to create opportunities — even though your parents have their own struggles and limitations. Waiting for luck to arrive and transform your circumstances — even though luck favours those who are already in motion, not those sitting passively hoping circumstances will somehow improve on their own.

Dependency is perhaps the most insidious enemy because it feels like patience. It feels like prudence. It feels like being responsible for constraints. But what you're actually doing is abdicating responsibility for your own life and future — outsourcing your agency to forces beyond your control, choosing the psychological comfort of victimhood over the psychological discomfort of taking ownership of outcomes even when circumstances aren't favourable.

Dependency is waiting dressed up as wisdom.

And it has cost India more than any enemy it has ever faced.



The Three Pillars: What Replaces the Enemies

Against distraction, directionlessness, and dependency — three pillars. The foundation that makes effective action not just possible but inevitable for anyone willing to build on it.

Pillar One: Clarity of Mission

Most people operate with objectives so fuzzy they function as permission slips for inaction. 'Make a difference.' 'Help people.' 'Build something meaningful.' These aspirations might be genuine — but they are useless as guides for action because they're too vague to evaluate. You cannot determine whether you're succeeding at 'making a difference' because the phrase means everything and therefore nothing.

Clarity means being able to complete this sentence without hesitation:

"In ninety days, I will solve [specific problem] in [specific location] by [specific intervention], resulting in [measurable outcome]."

That level of specificity creates accountability that vague aspirations never do. When your mission is clear, you know every single day whether you did what needed doing — or whether you wasted time on things that felt productive but didn't actually move you toward your goal.

Clarity is not limiting. Clarity is liberating. It tells you exactly where to aim. And it tells you — with equal precision — what to ignore.

Pillar Two: Community of Allies

You cannot sustain difficult work alone over extended periods. Human willpower is a finite resource that depletes through use. Motivation is a mood that passes. Inspiration is a feeling that fades. None of these can be relied upon as the engine of a ninety-day sprint — let alone a decade of building.

Community is not emotional support or cheerleading. Community is an operational infrastructure that makes sustained effort possible. When you've publicly committed to people you respect, you show up even on days when you

want to quit — because letting them down feels worse than pushing through your own discomfort. When you're stuck on a problem, you have people to consult who might see solutions you've missed. When you achieve something worth celebrating, you have people who understand the significance.

Community transforms the solitary burden of building into something shared. And shared burdens — carried by the right people — become lighter than any single person could carry alone.

Pillar Three: Systems of Execution

Systems are what remain when enthusiasm fades. Systems are what allow you to keep making progress even on days when you're tired or discouraged or distracted. Systems remove the need to constantly make decisions about what to do next — because the system tells you what comes next. Systems create momentum that carries you forward even when internal motivation is low.

A system might be as simple as a daily time block where you work on your mission for one hour, regardless of how you feel about it that day. A system might be a weekly accountability meeting where you report what you did and commit to what you'll do next. A system might be a checklist that ensures you complete all necessary steps rather than just the parts you enjoy or remember.

Systems externalise discipline — so you're not depending entirely on willpower that fluctuates with mood and

circumstance. Systems are how Subhash Deshmukh showed up to the factory before dawn, how Arvind arrived at his desk at four thirty, how every person who has ever built something lasting managed to keep building on the days when everything in them wanted to stop.



The 90-Day Blueprint

This is not a plan. Plans get written and filed and forgotten.

This is a blueprint. Blueprints get built.

Every phase has a deadline. Every phase has a deliverable. Every phase moves you from the person who finished reading this book to the person who is visibly, measurably, undeniably building New India from the ground you are standing on.

PHASE ZERO — 48 Hours — No Extensions

Forty-eight hours. Not a week. Not 'soon.' Forty-eight hours — because waiting longer is evidence that you're not serious, and this blueprint has no patience for people who aren't serious.

Choose one local problem to solve. Not a massive national issue. Not something that requires government intervention or significant capital or permissions you don't have. Something immediate and concrete that you can actually

affect. Something you can see from where you are standing right now.

Water shortage in your neighbourhood. School dropout rates in your area. Farmers are wasting crops because they lack market access. Youth unemployment among people with skills but no opportunities. Waste management that doesn't exist. Blood donation is needed, but nobody is organising the supply. A broken street light has caused accidents for three years, while everyone waits for someone else to report it.

Pick one problem that breaks your heart when you pay attention to it.

Write this sentence. By hand. In a notebook. Right now.

"In ninety days, I will solve _____ in _____."

That sentence is your declaration of war.

Everything that follows is the battle.

PHASE ONE — *Two Weeks* — *Ground Intelligence*

Before you build a solution, understand the problem. Actually understand it — not the version you assumed from a distance, not the version that fits the solution you've already decided you want to build. The real version. The version that lives in the experience of the people who actually have the problem.

Meet six to ten people who are directly affected. Not to tell them your solution. To understand their experience. To learn what they've already tried. To identify what the real barrier is — because it's rarely what you initially assume. Money is rarely the actual barrier, even though it's the barrier people most often name. The real barriers are usually coordination failures, information gaps, trust deficits, or technical knowledge that's missing from the people who need it most.

Listen more than you speak. Ask questions you don't know the answers to. Let their reality disrupt your assumptions. Let the problem teach you what it actually requires — rather than what you decided it required before you understood it.

And while you're listening — watch for allies. For the person whose eyes light up when you describe what you're attempting. For the one who says, 'I've been thinking about this for years.' For the person who has already tried something similar and failed, because their failure is a map of the obstacles you're about to face, and they know things you need to know.

PHASE TWO — *Four Weeks — Build Your Minimum Viable Pragati*

Not a perfect solution. Not the solution you'll eventually build after years of refinement. The smallest possible intervention that could make a measurable difference — right now, with what you have.

The rules are strict. They are strict by design — to force creativity rather than allowing you to wait for ideal resources that will never arrive.

Budget under five thousand rupees. So, lack of significant capital cannot become an excuse for inaction. Build it in three weeks. So, perfectionism cannot delay the launch indefinitely. Make it easy to teach and replicate. So your solution can spread beyond you. Test it on the ground with real users in real conditions. So you learn what actually works — rather than what should work in theory.

Some examples of what a Minimum Viable Pragati looks like in practice. A WhatsApp tutoring group where college students teach school students for one hour weekly — costs nothing, starts tomorrow. A micro-irrigation training where you teach five farmers one technique and provide initial supplies — three hundred rupees, three weeks, measurable results. A waste segregation system for one building with colour-coded bins and a twenty-minute training session. A Sunday skill class where unemployed youth learn one marketable skill from someone who already has it.

Small. Real. Executable. Starting now.

The Minimum Viable Pragati is not where your work ends. It is where proof begins.

PHASE THREE — *Four Weeks — Serve Your First Ten*

Ten is the number.

Not one. Not two. Ten — because ten is where the pattern becomes visible. One or two could be luck. Ten is evidence that your solution works beyond just one or two fortunate cases. Ten people who experience improvement because of what you built — who can testify, specifically, how their lives have measurably changed.

Serve these ten people intensely. Be present. Observe what works and what doesn't. Collect honest feedback — especially the critical kind, especially the kind that tells you what you got wrong. Because getting it wrong now, while the scale is small, is infinitely better than getting it wrong later when the stakes are higher.

Stack small victories. Celebrate them — not publicly, not for the followers — internally, within your team, between the people who know what this cost and what it took. Momentum matters as much as magnitude in the early stages. Movement begins when ten people say yes, when ten people feel the difference. When ten people can look at what you built and say: This changed something for me.

That is not a small thing.

That is everything.

That is how every revolution in history actually started — with ten people who experienced something different and told five others.

PHASE FOUR — *Two Weeks* — *Multiply*

Now you have proof. Now you have a model that works, documented evidence that it works, and the credibility that comes from having done something rather than merely having planned to do something.

Use it.

Recruit three volunteers who will replicate your model in other locations. Train them thoroughly — not just in the mechanics of what you built but in the philosophy behind it. The why matters as much as the how. People who understand why something matters build it with more care than people who understand only what steps to follow.

Help them launch in two additional locations. Document your process so others can learn from your experience without repeating your mistakes. And then announce your success — not to seek applause, but to inspire replication. To show the next person who is sitting where you were sitting ninety days ago that what seemed impossible is demonstrably, verifiably, visibly possible.

Your ninety days can change ten thousand lives if you understand the multiplier effect.

You directly serve ten people. Each of them tells five others. Those fifty people influence hundreds. The model spreads through demonstration rather than persuasion. Systems scale in ways that individual effort never can.

This is how Subhash Deshmukh became more than one man. Not because he tried to do everything himself. Because he built systems and developed people and then stepped back — as he did with Raja Mama — and let those people carry the work forward. The mission outlived the moment. The impact multiplied beyond the person.

That is what you're building toward. Not a project. A movement.



Five Weapons — Carry These Always

These are not metaphors. These are literal, physical, practical tools that you carry with you throughout the ninety-day sprint. The warrior who enters battle without weapons does not last long.

WEAPON 1: *The War Diary*

A small notebook — physical, not digital — that becomes your record of everything. Observations. Ideas. Lessons learned. Commitments made and kept. Commitments made and broken, and the honest accounting of why. Writing by hand creates neural pathways that typing doesn't. It forces clarity that keeping thoughts in your head never achieves. It makes your journey real, permanent, and reviewable. In ten years, this notebook will be more valuable than anything else you own from this period of your life.

WEAPON 2: *The Ledger*

Track every rupee spent. Every single one. Not because money is the most important thing, but because financial discipline is the foundation of organisational credibility. When you can show exactly where every rupee went and what it produced, people trust you with more. When you cannot, they shouldn't. The ledger is not bureaucracy. It is integrity made visible.

WEAPON 3: *The Mentor*

One person who is five steps ahead of you. Someone who has already done something similar and survived the mistakes you are about to make. Their job is not to do your work for you — it is to warn you about the pitfalls they fell into, encourage you through the moments when you feel like quitting, and occasionally ask the question you've been avoiding that turns out to be the most important question of all. Find this person. Treasure them. Do not waste their time.

WEAPON 4: *The War Room Group*

A WhatsApp group of four to eight people maximum. Small enough that everyone's participation matters, and no one can hide in the noise. This is your operational coordination channel — where you report progress, ask for help, share what you've learned, and celebrate wins without waiting for the world to notice them. Larger groups become announcement channels. This group is a war room. Keep it small. Keep it honest. Keep it active.

WEAPON 5: *The Sacred Hour*

One hour every day — non-negotiable, unscheduled, inviolable — when you work on your mission regardless of how you feel or what else is demanding your attention. Not when it's convenient. Not when you feel inspired. Every day. This hour is protected from everything. Because if your mission cannot claim one hour from twenty-four, then you are not as committed to it as you believe you are, and the sooner you discover that honestly, the better.



The Revolutionary's Code

Five commitments that define how you operate. Not aspirations. Not goals. Code — the operating principles that govern your decisions and your behaviour, regardless of circumstances.

1. I will act before I complain. Complaining is easy and accomplishes nothing. Action is hard and changes reality. Any time I feel the urge to complain about a problem, I will ask first: Have I done everything in my power to address it? If the answer is no, I will act before I speak.
2. I will create more than I consume. Creation builds capability and leaves something behind. Consumption provides entertainment but doesn't develop you. I will track this ratio honestly and correct it relentlessly.

3. I will teach two others what I have learned. Teaching forces deep understanding. It multiplies impact beyond yourself. Every insight I gain, every lesson I earn through failure, every skill I develop — I will pass to at least two other people who need it.

4. I will not wait for permission. Permission is often denied and always delayed. The work that needs doing needs doing regardless of whether someone in authority has sanctioned it. I will act and ask forgiveness rather than wait for approval that may never come.

5. I will finish what I start. Starting is exciting. Finishing is what separates people who build things from people who begin things. I will not add another unfinished project to the graveyard of good intentions. I will finish.



The Four Roles — Build Your Team

You cannot do this alone. Not because you lack capability — but because no single person possesses all the capabilities that building something real requires. Every team needs four distinct types of people working together. The absence of any one of them is a weakness that will eventually break you.

THE DOER

Executes tasks. Takes action. Gets things done while others are still talking about getting things done. The Doer has a

bias for movement — imperfect movement, sometimes, but movement. Without the Doer, the team plans brilliantly and ships nothing.

THE THINKER

Plans carefully. Documents processes. Analyses what's working and what isn't — and asks the question no one else is asking. Without the Thinker, the team moves fast and makes the same mistakes repeatedly, never understanding why.

THE CONNECTOR

Brings people together. Builds networks. Finds the resource you didn't know existed and the person who has exactly what you need. Without the Connector, the team operates in isolation, reinventing wheels and missing opportunities that are visible from slightly further away.

THE CHALLENGER

Asks the tough questions. Prevents groupthink. Forces the team to examine its assumptions and improve its weak plans. The Challenger is uncomfortable to have in the room — and essential. Without the Challenger, the team builds confidently in the wrong direction.

Teams composed entirely of Doers accomplish things quickly — but often in the wrong direction. Teams of only Thinkers analyse endlessly but never ship. Teams of only Connectors have large networks but little substance. Teams of only Challengers criticise everything but build nothing.

You need all four. Find them. Name them. Build with them.



The Ten-Year Vision

Think beyond ninety days for a moment.

Think ten years.

If just one percent of Indian youth adopt this approach — if just one percent of the hundreds of millions of young people in this country complete one ninety-day sprint, then another, then another — the transformation will be visible from space.

Rural entrepreneurship explosion — thousands of new ventures created in areas that currently lack economic opportunity, built by people who were told they had nothing and discovered they had everything they needed. Local job creation that keeps talented people in their home communities — rather than forcing the endless painful migration to already overcrowded cities where they arrive as strangers and often remain strangers. Grassroots leadership development that produces not ten national leaders but a million mini-leaders — one in every district, one in every village, one in every community — who can coordinate action, inspire effort, and prove through their own existence that change is possible here, now, by people who look exactly like the people around them.

India does not need a few extraordinary leaders at the centre to somehow fix everything for everybody.

India needs a million ordinary people who refuse to be ordinary.

India needs transformation through the multiplication of local transformation, not a singular genius radiating outward from a single point. Still, a million points of light igniting simultaneously, each one illuminating the dark in its own particular corner, together making the night impossible.

Migration has reduced because people have opportunities where they already live. Social capital rises because trust is rebuilt when neighbours solve problems together rather than waiting for distant authorities. Leadership emerges from unexpected places — from Beed and Solapur and Wadala and ten thousand other towns that the world has not yet heard of but will.

Transformation doesn't come from Delhi.

It never did.

It comes from small towns and villages where young warriors refused to accept dysfunction as inevitable — and built solutions that proved change was possible, where they proved it so clearly, so undeniably, so visibly that the next person watching had no excuse left.



Your Turn

These exercises are your entry into the revolution.

Not the revolution in the abstract. Your revolution. The specific, local, ninety-day revolution that begins in the place where you are sitting right now — with the resources you currently have, with the problem you can currently see, with the people who are currently around you.

Complete them now. Or admit you're not serious about change — and stop pretending to yourself that you are.

Exercise 7.1: Write Your Mission in One Sentence

Complete this: 'In ninety days, I will solve [specific problem] in [specific location].'

Make it concrete enough that ninety days from now you can evaluate honestly — without self-deception — whether you succeeded or failed. Make it ambitious enough to matter but realistic enough to be achievable with sustained effort and whatever resources you can access. Not a dream. A declaration. Not an aspiration. A commitment with a deadline.

Write it by hand. In ink. In the war diary that you will carry for the next ninety days. And when you write it, mean it.

Exercise 7.2: Assemble Your Four-Member Team

Recruit one Doer, one Thinker, one Connector, and one Challenger. Don't try to do this alone, because you cannot

sustain ninety days of difficult work without support and accountability, and the people who will tell you what you need to hear rather than what you want to hear.

Choose people who complement your weaknesses rather than duplicate your strengths. Have honest conversations about what you're committing to — the difficulty of it, the uncertainty of it, the possibility of failure. Ask them not just for their time but for their honesty. That is the rarer and more valuable gift.

Exercise 7.3: Complete Phase Zero Within 48 Hours

Stop reading. Start acting.

Forty-eight hours from now, you should have identified your problem, written your mission statement, and taken the first steps toward ground intelligence. Not planning to start. Actually started. Not intending to begin. Already begun.

Forty-eight hours is enough time to move from intention to action for anyone serious. If you cannot find forty-eight hours, you have found your first mediocrity to kill.

Exercise 7.4: Start Your 90-Day Sprint Today

Today. Not Monday when the week starts fresh. Not next month when your schedule clears. Not after you've finished reading one more book or attended one more seminar or felt sufficiently inspired to begin.

Today.

Take one concrete action toward your mission before you sleep tonight. Open the notebook. Send the first message. Make the first phone call. Schedule the first meeting. Walk to the location of the problem and stand in front of it, and let it be real to you in a way it wasn't before you stood there.

Do something. Anything real. That moves you from the person who talks about change to the person who creates it.

Mission Checkpoint

Before moving forward, verify honestly — not what you intend to do, not what you plan to do, not what you will definitely do very soon — what you have already done.

- ☐ Mission statement written with specific problem, location, and timeframe
- ☐ Four-member team assembled with clear role assignments
- ☐ Phase Zero completed — problem identified, initial ground intelligence begun
- ☐ Ninety-day sprint started today with one concrete action already taken

If you cannot check all four boxes honestly, close the book. Do the work. Come back when you can check them.

Reading further accomplishes nothing if you're not willing to execute what you've already read. The revolution doesn't need more people who understand it intellectually. The

revolution needs people who are building it practically — one ninety-day sprint at a time, one problem solved at a time, one community transformed at a time.

Questions for Reflection

- Why does the author describe youth as a force rather than just an age group?
- According to the chapter, what separates ambitious people from successful people?
- How do distractions reduce the potential of today's youth?
- Why is consistency more important than motivation?
- What is one talent or strength you have not fully used yet?
- If you could dedicate one year completely to learning something, what would it be and why?
- What kind of future do you want to help create for the next generation?



The Last Words of This Book — And the First Words of Your Story

You have traveled a long way to reach this page.

You began in Solapur — standing at a railway station at dawn, watching trains arrive from everywhere, carrying people who were all moving. You met a boy from Wadala

with an injured eye, no prospects, and no permission from the world to succeed. You watched him build — slowly, messily, without applause, without a blueprint, without anyone telling him it was possible.

You saw him build a kirana shop, a tyre shop, a dairy, a check dam, and a sugar factory that nobody believed in until it was standing. You saw him feed communities and fund marriages and back entrepreneurs and serve as the quiet angel investor for a generation that had no one else willing to bet on them. You saw him enter politics not for power but because the people asked him to — and you saw him pay the price of belonging to the people by giving up the comfort of belonging only to himself.

You saw what he built.

You saw what it cost.

You saw that he never needed a book to tell him how.

And now the book turns to you.

Not with sympathy. Not with encouragement. With a demand.

You have been given something Subhash Deshmukh never had. You have education, however imperfect. You have technology; however, it is double-edged. You have a connected world that would have seemed like science fiction to a boy in Wadala in the 1970s. You have this book, which means you have a framework that took decades to build and a philosophy that was paid for in blood and sweat and early

mornings and the particular kind of sacrifice that comes from choosing service over comfort for an entire lifetime.

You have everything he didn't have.

And you have the same thing he had.

Twenty-four hours every day: The choice of how to spend them.

And the question that this entire book has been asking from its very first sentence.

WHAT WILL YOU BUILD?

Not someday.

Not when you're ready.

Not when conditions improve, or someone gives you permission, or the perfect opportunity arrives wearing a sign that says 'this is the moment you've been waiting for.'

Now.

Here.

With what you have.

Starting today.

India is not waiting for a hero.

THE NEW INDIA MANIFESTO

India is waiting for you — specifically, exactly, precisely you
— to stop waiting and start building.

The ninety days begin now.



*For Subhash Deshmukh.
Who never needed this book.
And built everything anyway.*

REVOLUTION WITHOUT VIOLENCE

The Gandhian Modernity for the 21st Century

India defeated the British Empire without firing a single bullet.

Let that fact settle in your mind with the weight it deserves. Because modern cynicism has made us forget how extraordinary that achievement was — and remains. The most powerful empire the world had ever seen, with superior weapons and professional armies and centuries of experience subjugating populations across continents, was forced to leave India. Not because we overpowered them militarily. Not because we matched their firepower or their organisation or their centuries of accumulated imperial experience.

Because we made their presence morally unsustainable.

We defeated the greatest military power in history with a conscience weaponised through discipline. With moral force that proved more powerful than military force. With a strategy disguised as spiritual practice — so effectively, so brilliantly, that even now many people misunderstand Gandhi's non-violence as weakness rather than recognising it for what it actually was.

The most sophisticated political warfare ever conducted on Indian soil.



What Non-Violence Actually Is

Let us be very clear about something that decades of misrepresentation have obscured.

Non-violence is not passivity.

Non-violence is not cowardice.

Non-violence is not the refusal to fight because you lack the courage for confrontation.

Non-violence is a disciplined weapon. Anger channeled into constructive action rather than destructive reaction. Power is expressed through moral authority rather than physical force.

Gandhi understood something that most revolutionaries miss — before they discover it too late, usually surrounded by the wreckage of the very thing they were trying to build.

Violence might win battles. It rarely wins wars. And even when it wins wars, it almost always loses the peace that follows — because violence creates resentment and cycles of revenge that perpetuate conflict across generations, turning victories into the seeds of the next war.

His genius was something more radical than most people realise.

Gandhi didn't just tell Indians to stop cooperating with British rule. He replaced the thing he was dismantling with something better. He created alternative systems that demonstrated Indians could govern themselves. Could produce what they needed without dependence on British goods. Could organise complex collective action without British administration.

Khadi became a programme — not just a symbol. Village industries became economic infrastructure — not just rhetoric about self-reliance. Literacy camps became capacity building — not just consciousness raising. He was not simply opposing a system. He was building its replacement simultaneously, so that when the old system fell, something worthy was already standing in its place.

This is the insight that most revolutionaries miss, and most protesters never reach.

Constructive action destroys corruption faster than protest ever can.

Because corruption thrives in the gap between what systems promise and what systems deliver, when you build better

systems that actually deliver what people need, corrupt systems lose their power and their relevance. When you create functioning alternatives, people abandon broken systems voluntarily — rather than needing to be persuaded through argument or coerced through force.

You don't have to tear the old thing down if you've built something better that people freely choose instead.

Why Non-Violence Works Better in Modern India

This is not just moral philosophy. This is a tactical reality.

Three reasons — observable, measurable, and undeniable.

Violence Divides. Non-Violence Unites.

Violence creates fear that divides communities and makes collective action harder — because fear drives people to protect themselves rather than trust others. Violence destroys the very social fabric that any meaningful change requires. It turns neighbours into enemies, allies into opponents, and the people who should be building together into people who are guarding against each other.

Non-violence unites citizens across divides that violence would deepen. Because moral claims speak to universal human values that transcend particular group interests. When you stand for something rather than against someone — when your action is clearly in service of a community rather than against an enemy — you expand who can join you rather than narrow it.

Violence Excuses. Non-Violence Exposes.

Violence gives authorities an excuse for repression. It allows the corrupt to play victim — to deflect attention from their own wrongdoing by pointing at the wrongdoing of those opposing them. The moment you become violent, you hand your opponent the one gift they need most: the ability to change the subject.

Non-violence embarrasses the corrupt by exposing the gap between their claims and their conduct — in ways that violence cannot, because violence obscures that gap. When you are peaceful, and they are brutal, the entire world can see clearly who is the problem. There is nowhere for them to hide.

Violence Limits. Non-Violence Scales.

Violence requires resources, training, and organisation that limit who can participate. It concentrates power in the hands of those capable of force, which usually means the same people who already have it.

Non-violence scales rapidly through replication because anyone can adopt non-violent methods. A grandmother. A student. A farmer. A shopkeeper. A child. The barrier to entry is not strength or weapons or money — it is only commitment and courage. And courage, unlike weapons, cannot be monopolised by the powerful.

Violence is a moment — producing, immediate, visible impact, but it rarely creates lasting change. Non-violence is a movement — building slowly but creating transformation

that endures because it wins converts rather than just defeating opponents. Because it builds capacity rather than just destroying obstacles. Because it creates new systems rather than just dismantling old ones.



The Four Pillars of Gandhian Modernity

Gandhi's framework was built for a specific historical moment. But its underlying principles transcend that moment — applicable to contexts he never imagined, by people facing problems he never encountered, in an India that would be unrecognisable to him and yet would feel, in its struggles and its potential, entirely familiar.

Here are the four pillars adapted for the twenty-first century. For New India. For you.

PILLAR 1: *Constructive Programme*

The commitment to build solutions rather than merely identify problems or protest their existence.

Gandhi mobilised khadi production, village industries, and literacy camps. Every one of these was a system — something that functioned, that produced something, that made people's lives concretely better regardless of whether the British left or stayed.

New India needs to solve more than it shouts. To create more than it criticises. To build systems that work rather than just

complaining about systems that don't. Every hour spent protesting without a constructive programme is wasted — because protest alone never built anything lasting. Protest draws attention. Construction creates change.

Ask yourself, every time you feel the urge to protest: what am I building? If the answer is nothing, you are not yet in the revolution. You are in the audience, watching it.

PILLAR 2: *Civil Energy*

The volunteer power that emerges when ordinary people contribute ordinary hours toward extraordinary collective benefit.

Gandhi mobilised millions of Indians who contributed time and effort toward independence. That contribution created ownership — because people value what they've invested themselves in building. They don't walk away from it. They defend it. They expand it. They teach it to their children.

Modern India needs a similar mobilisation. Citizens contributing time toward community improvement — rather than remaining passive consumers of solutions others provide, waiting for government or corporations to solve everything while they watch and complain. Civil energy is the multiplier that turns small efforts into large movements. It is the resource that India possesses in greater abundance than any other nation on earth — and deploys less effectively than almost any other.

PILLAR 3: *Strategic Non-Cooperation*

The refusal to participate in systems that violate your values.

Stop buying from businesses that exploit workers or damage the environment when alternatives exist. Stop voting for politicians who are corrupt, regardless of which party they represent — because a corrupt candidate from your preferred party is still a corrupt candidate. Stop participating in social practices that cause harm, even when those practices are traditional — because tradition is not justification, only description.

Your participation gives power to systems. Your withdrawal of participation removes that power. This is not dramatic. It requires no confrontation, no publicity, no courage in the physical sense. It requires only the quiet daily decision to withhold cooperation from what you know to be wrong — and to make that decision consistently, even when it is inconvenient, even when the alternative requires more effort.

Non-cooperation is the power that every person possesses, regardless of how little else they have. It cannot be taken from you. It can only be surrendered.

PILLAR 4: *Moral Persuasion*

The combination of data, storytelling, and truth and dignity converts opponents rather than merely defeating them.

When you approach disagreement with genuine respect for your opponent as a human being who has reasons for their position — even if those reasons are flawed — you

create something that force never can: the possibility of actual conversion. Where their mind changes voluntarily. Where they arrive at the truth themselves, through their own reasoning, rather than being compelled to concede defeat.

This matters not just morally but strategically. A person who has been defeated is still an opponent — waiting for the moment when they can fight back. A person who has been converted is now an ally. The most powerful army you can build is one made of people who used to oppose you and came to understand why you were right.

Truth shared with arrogance is often rejected because people hear the arrogance before they hear the truth. Truth shared with dignity is far more likely to be received — because it respects the humanity of the person receiving it and does not require them to humiliate themselves in order to agree with you.



The Modern Playbook: Five Strategies

Theory is only as valuable as what it enables you to do. Here are five strategies — practical, immediate, executable — that translate Gandhian modernity into action for anyone, anywhere, regardless of resources or position.

STRATEGY 1: *Build Before You Protest*

When you see a problem, resist the immediate impulse to

gather people for a rally or a demonstration. Start instead with constructive action that addresses the problem directly.

If public spaces are filthy, organise a cleanup before you organise a protest about the government's failure to maintain cleanliness. If roads are broken — document every pothole, map the damage, and present the data before you march. If education is failing — run one tutoring session, serve one student, demonstrate what working looks like before demanding that the system work.

Building first establishes your credibility. It demonstrates that you are committed to solutions rather than just to attention. Protest without prior construction looks like performance. Construction followed by selective, strategic protest looks like a serious, sustained commitment — and the world treats it accordingly.

STRATEGY 2: *Replace Outrage With Organising*

When something makes you angry, ask immediately: What system can I build to fix this?

Anger is a valid emotional response to injustice. It is also a resource — one that expires quickly if not directed. Anger lasts thirty minutes. Systems last thirty years.

Converting anger into organising means capturing that emotional energy. At the same time, it's hot and directing it toward building something concrete before it cools and leaves nothing behind except the memory of feeling strongly about something. That memory is not a legacy. It is not a contribution. It has not changed.

The moment you feel the outrage — write it down. Then write underneath it: what would I build to make this impossible? That question is where the revolution begins. The outrage is just the fuel. You still need to build the engine.

STRATEGY 3: *Practice Digital Non-Violence*

The internet rewards outrage and conflict and the public humiliation of opponents — because algorithms amplify content that triggers strong emotional reactions. Engagement is measured by intensity, not by quality. The most inflammatory post spreads furthest. The most balanced analysis reaches the fewest.

This is the environment you are operating in. It was designed to make non-violence harder and violence easier. Resist it consciously and deliberately.

Use digital platforms to share accurate information. To educate people who are genuinely confused rather than just wilfully ignorant. To clarify misunderstandings with patience rather than contempt. To tell the stories that the algorithm would never promote because they are quiet and honest and don't make anyone's blood boil.

Digital violence spreads faster. Digital non-violence builds more lasting change. You must decide which metric you are optimising for — because you cannot optimise for both simultaneously.

The easiest thing in the world right now is to be angry online. The hardest thing — and the most

consequential — is to be constructive. It's the hardest thing.

STRATEGY 4: *Win Without Humiliation*

When you are right — and sometimes you will be clearly, demonstrably, incontrovertibly right — resist the temptation to crush the wrong person.

You can expose wrongdoing in ways that leave room for the wrongdoer to change and grow. Or you can do it in ways that destroy them publicly and force them to double down on their position — because admitting error after humiliation feels psychologically impossible for most human beings.

Humiliation creates permanent enemies. Respect — even for wrong people, even for people whose conduct you oppose — creates the possibility of converts. And in a long revolution, converts are worth infinitely more than defeated enemies. A defeated enemy waits. A convert builds.

Choose influence over victory. Conversion over conquest. Long-term change over the short-term satisfaction of making someone feel small in front of an audience.

This is the hardest of the five strategies. Because the satisfaction of winning is real, and the satisfaction of making someone visibly suffer their defeat is intoxicating. Gandhi called this discipline the highest form of courage — not the courage to fight, but the courage to win without destroying.

STRATEGY 5: *Scale Through Replication*

Start in one village. One school. One community. One street.
Start as small as necessary to start well.

Perfect the approach through honest iteration — not through planning, but through doing, failing, adjusting, and doing again. Document it carefully enough that someone who wasn't there can replicate it without you needing to be present. Then train others. Support those replications until they succeed. Then let those people train the next generation.

One village becomes ten. Ten becomes one hundred. One hundred becomes a thousand. Not through your personal effort spreading thin across too much geography — but through a model so well designed, so clearly documented, so genuinely replicable that it carries itself forward beyond your ability to carry it.

This is how Gandhi's Salt March became a national movement. Not because one man walked to the sea — but because what he demonstrated was replicable everywhere, by anyone, with nothing more than commitment and a coastline.

You may not have a coastline. But you have a problem in front of you right now. Start there.



The Two Wells — Gandhian Modernity in Practice

Let me tell you about a village and two wells.

The village's name doesn't matter because this story has happened in hundreds of villages across India — with local variations, different names, different details — but the same underlying dynamic, and the same lesson waiting at its end.

The village had two wells that served different neighbourhoods. One well belonged to one community. The other to another. The division mattered in ways that outsiders wouldn't understand. Still, insiders felt in their bones — the residue of longstanding tensions that had their own history, their own justified grievances, their own accumulated weight.

Both wells failed within months of each other. Complicated technical problems that nobody locally could diagnose or fix. Both communities blamed the other, through reasoning that made perfect sense within the context of their shared history of mistrust. The failure of the wells was evidence, to each community, of the other's malice or negligence or both.

They fought for months. Actual physical confrontations that sent people to the hospital. Endless meetings where grievances were aired and no progress was made. Government officials visited, promised action, and disappeared. NGOs offered help with conditions attached that neither community would accept. The fight became the village's defining characteristic — the thing outsiders knew

about them, the dysfunction that prevented everything else from being accomplished, the identity that had replaced the identity of being neighbours.

Then something happened that government officials, NGOs, community elders, and meetings had failed to produce.

A group of young people from both communities decided to stop fighting and start fixing.

They didn't organise a protest demanding government action. They didn't wait for the adults to resolve their differences, which would have meant waiting indefinitely, since the adults had been failing to resolve their differences for longer than some of these young people had been alive. They didn't hold a press conference or write letters or file complaints with authorities who had already demonstrated they would not respond.

They got tools. They found technical advice from an engineer who lived in a nearby town and was willing to come. They cleaned both wells — thoroughly, publicly, together — removing years of accumulated debris and contamination that nobody had bothered to address while everyone was busy blaming each other for it. They repaired what could be repaired with the resources available. They tested the water quality. They treated it appropriately. And they did all of this publicly — so that everyone in the village could see exactly what was being done, and who was doing it, and together.

The fight ended.

Not because someone won. Not because authorities imposed a solution. Not because one community convinced the other that they had been right all along. The fight ended because it became irrelevant — once the actual problem was solved, the pretext for the fight dissolved.

Water returned to both wells. Both communities could drink, wash, and irrigate. And the young people who had cleaned the wells became informal leaders — because they had demonstrated capability and commitment and the willingness to act in ways that years of talking never had.

This is Gandhian modernity in practice.

The power of constructive action to dissolve conflicts that confrontation only amplifies. The power of building something together to create trust that argument alone cannot manufacture. The power of solving the actual problem instead of performing endless theatre around it.

The enemy was not the other community. The enemy was the dirty wells.

It always was.

It just took young people — unburdened by the accumulated weight of adult grievance — to see that clearly enough to act on it.



Non-Violence as National Advantage

This is not just the right way to build India.

It is the smart way.

Non-violence builds infrastructure — because energy goes toward construction rather than destruction. Every rupee not spent repairing what violence destroys is a rupee available to build what peace requires. Non-violence strengthens society by creating networks of trust and cooperation that violent conflict destroys — and trust, once destroyed, takes a generation to rebuild. Non-violence attracts investment — because capital flows toward stability and away from chaos. The nation that demonstrates it can resolve its conflicts constructively signals to the world that it is a safe place to build.

And then there is this formula — simple, profound, and true.

High Discipline + High Dignity = An Unstoppable Nation

Discipline produces capability. Dignity produces cohesion. Nations with one but not the other eventually fail.

Discipline without dignity creates efficient tyranny — that people resist or flee. Look at the history of every repressive state that achieved economic growth through iron control and then collapsed when the control could no longer be maintained. Efficiency built on fear is not strength. It is borrowed time.

Dignity without discipline creates pleasant dysfunction — that produces goodwill but nothing lasting. The nation that is kind and well-meaning and disorganised — that celebrates its values loudly while failing to deliver on them consistently — is also failing. Just more gently, more slowly, more apologetically.

Discipline and dignity together — that is what Gandhi was building. Not just the removal of the British. The construction of a people who were capable and cohesive, organised and moral, effective and humane. A people whose revolution was so clean that their former colonisers ended up respecting them for it.

That inheritance belongs to us.

We have spent enough time forgetting it.

It is time to remember — and then to use it.



Your Turn

Now translate understanding into action.

Three exercises. Specific. Executable. Beginning this week.

Exercise 8.1: Identify One Problem You're Angry About

Choose something that genuinely enrages you when you encounter it or think about it. Something where your anger

is justified — because the problem is real and causes unnecessary suffering to real people you could name.

Write it down specifically. Not 'corruption' or 'bad government' — something concrete. A specific road that has been broken for three years. A specific school with no toilets. A specific practice that exploits a specific group of people. Make it real enough to touch. Make it small enough to address. Make it close enough to you that your anger is not abstract but personal.

Write down exactly why it makes you angry. Get the anger onto paper where you can see it clearly — and where it cannot continue to circulate uselessly inside you, generating heat without generating light.

Exercise 8.2: Define One Constructive Action That Would Solve It

Take your anger and convert it into construction. What could you build — or fix, or create, or organise — that would address the problem directly?

Not a protest. Not a petition. Not a complaint letter that will be filed and forgotten. An actual constructive action that changes the reality you're angry about. Something concrete enough that you could start within one week. Something real enough that if you did it — the problem would be measurably better.

This is the hardest part of the exercise. Because our minds reach immediately for protest — it is faster, it requires less

sustained commitment, it delivers a more immediate feeling of having done something. Resist that reach. Stay with the harder question: what would I build?

Exercise 8.3: Build One System This Week That Addresses the Problem

Move from planning to doing. Within seven days, create one functioning system — however small, however modest — that demonstrates your constructive approach works.

Document what you did so others can replicate it without your presence. Recruit at least two other people to join you — so the system doesn't depend entirely on you, so it can outlast your enthusiasm and survive your bad days. Make it visible so that others can see what constructive action looks like in practice.

Because the two-well story didn't end with clean wells. It ended with young people who became leaders — because they had demonstrated capability and commitment in the most convincing way possible.

By doing something.

Mission Checkpoint

Before moving to the next chapter, verify honestly:

- ☐ Constructive action chosen, documented, and begun
- ☐ Digital non-violence practiced for at least seven days — consciously, deliberately

□ One system built that at least two other people can see, join, and potentially replicate

If you cannot check all three boxes — you are still operating in the old paradigm. Complaint without construction. Outrage without organising. Anger without action.

Go back and do the work.

Because non-violence is not a philosophy to admire intellectually from a safe distance. It is a practice. It is embodied in physical actions that build what you claim you want to see in the world — one well, one system, one constructive act at a time.

Gandhi didn't write about non-violence and then wait for others to practice it.

He walked to the sea.

What is your sea?: Walk toward it.

Questions for Reflection

- Why does the author believe discipline is more powerful than aggression?
- How can peaceful action create long-lasting change in society?
- What role does emotional control play in leadership?
- Why are patience and persistence important during difficult struggles?

THE NEW INDIA MANIFESTO

- Describe a situation where reacting calmly gave a better result than reacting emotionally.
- What peaceful action could young people take to improve their communities today?
- What does this chapter teach about strength and maturity?

A NATION WAITING TO BE INCUBATED

From Seed Bank to Growth Engine

India's soul is entrepreneurial in ways that most developed nations will never understand.

Because entrepreneurship for us is not a career choice or a lifestyle preference or the kind of thing that gets celebrated at startup conferences in air-conditioned venues in Bangalore. Entrepreneurship for us is a survival strategy — practiced daily by millions of people who have never heard the word and would find it slightly amusing if they did.

The street vendor who wakes at four in the morning to buy vegetables wholesale and sells them retail with margins so thin that one day of rain can wipe out a week's profit — is an entrepreneur. The woman who converts her kitchen skills into a small catering business serving her neighbourhood — is an entrepreneur. The young man who repairs motorcycles

from a shed behind his house, using tools accumulated over years of small savings and patient accumulation — is an entrepreneur. The farmer who makes seventeen decisions before breakfast about planting and irrigation and market timing and risk — has always been an entrepreneur, even when no one called him that.

We have entrepreneurial spirit in abundance. Flowing through millions of people who build businesses from nothing — because formal employment was never available to them and government assistance was never reliable enough to depend upon.

But here is the brutal truth that should disturb every comfortable person who talks admiringly about India's entrepreneurial culture.

Indian spirit does not equal Indian system.

The spirit exists despite the system — not because of it. The system actively obstructs entrepreneurship through bureaucratic obstacles and capital constraints and market access barriers that trap talented people in poverty when they should be creating wealth. We have youth with energy but no skills that markets will reward. We have farmers with land but no access to markets where they could sell at fair prices. We have women with capability but no access to credit or supply chains or business networks. We have villages with potential but no infrastructure that would allow that potential to be realised. We have talent distributed widely across our population — but incubation

concentrated narrowly in a few cities that most Indians will never access.

India lacks ecosystems, not talent.

The problem is not human capability — it is institutional infrastructure.

The problem is not individual potential — it is collective systems that would allow that potential to be channeled productively.

Until we confront this reality honestly and build the ecosystems that talent requires to become productive, we will continue wasting our greatest national resource. Not our natural resources. Not our geographic advantages. Our people. And what they could become — if given proper support.



The Inequality You Cannot Look Away From

Let me show you this clearly enough that you cannot pretend you don't understand it.

A startup in Bangalore with a presentable pitch deck — founders speaking polished English, wearing the right clothes, using the right vocabulary — can raise five crores for an idea that hasn't been tested and might never work. Five crores. For an idea.

Meanwhile, a farmer in Beed cannot raise fifty thousand rupees for a borewell that would definitely work. That would definitely improve his yield. That would definitely feed his family better.

The farmer has collateral — his land. The farmer has a proven business model called agriculture, which humans have practiced for ten thousand years. The farmer has a need that is genuine rather than manufactured. But the farmer cannot access capital — because the formal financial system looks at him and sees risk rather than opportunity. Sees liability rather than potential. Sees the wrong clothes and the wrong vocabulary and the wrong city.

A tailor in Osmanabad has been stitching clothes for twenty years with one machine. She wants to buy a second machine — so she can employ her sister-in-law and double her production. Two machines would cost perhaps thirty thousand rupees. With two machines she could take larger orders and access institutional buyers — schools and hospitals that require volume she cannot currently deliver. The return on investment is obvious and immediate.

But there is no pathway for this tailor to access thirty thousand rupees. Microfinance institutions charge interest rates that make the investment unviable. Banks won't process loans that small — because the administrative cost is higher than the interest they would earn. So she keeps her one machine. Her sister-in-law keeps waiting. The schools keep buying from the urban supplier who can deliver

volume. And a story that should have ended in growth ends in stasis.

This is what I mean when I say India is unincubated.

The problem is not lack of entrepreneurial desire. Not lack of business ideas. Not lack of willingness to work harder than anyone working in a comfortable office in a comfortable city has ever worked. The problem is the complete absence of incubation architecture — the support that converts potential into productivity, that transforms ideas into income, that turns talent into thriving enterprises.



The Three T Formula

Incubation is not complicated conceptually — even though implementing it systematically is difficult. It follows a formula that anyone can understand and apply.

Training + Tools + Trade = Transformation

Training teaches people how to do what they want to do — providing the technical knowledge and practical skills that their formal education never delivered. Tools give people what they need to actually begin production — rather than just understanding production theoretically. Trade provides market access — so that what gets produced can be sold at fair prices to buyers who need it, closing the loop that turns

production into income that can sustain the enterprise and the entrepreneur.

Many incubation initiatives fail because they provide only one T when all three are necessary. They train people without giving them tools — leaving them with knowledge they cannot deploy. They provide tools without training — leaving people with equipment they don't know how to use effectively. They facilitate both training and tools but neglect trade — leaving people with capability and equipment but no customers and therefore no income.

All three Ts must be present simultaneously. Because entrepreneurship is a system — and all components of a system must function together or the system doesn't function at all.



The Five Tiers India Must Build

If we are serious about unleashing the entrepreneurial potential that currently sits dormant in millions of people who have ideas and energy but no support system — here is what must be constructed. Not wished for. Not proposed in policy papers. Built.

TIER 1: *Rural Incubation Hubs*

District-level physical facilities equipped with the machinery and mentorship that aspiring entrepreneurs

need — not as a pilot programme in three favoured districts but as a national standard in every district.

Fabrication labs with welding equipment and machine tools for people who want to manufacture products. Commercial kitchens and packaging equipment for people who want to create value-added agricultural products. Industrial sewing machines for tailoring at scale. Computers and internet connectivity for coding and digital marketing and e-commerce. Cold storage that allows farmers to sell when prices are favourable rather than being forced to dump produce immediately at whatever the middleman offers. And business mentors — not academics who have studied business, but people who have actually built enterprises and survived the mistakes that case studies never mention.

These hubs should focus on the four areas where rural India has natural advantages but currently lacks infrastructure to exploit them. Agricultural value addition — where farmers learn to process and package their produce rather than selling raw commodities at razor-thin margins. Women's enterprises — that allow income generation while managing household responsibilities that our social structures still assign primarily to women. E-commerce — connecting rural producers directly to urban consumers without the multiple intermediaries that currently extract most of the value. And rural business process outsourcing — where educated rural youth perform digital work for urban and international clients without migrating to cities.

TIER 2: *Village Venture Funds*

Micro-equity investments of ten thousand to two lakh rupees for the smallest viable businesses — the ones too small for banks, too real for charity, too promising to abandon.

Food stalls that require inventory and basic equipment. Tailoring operations that need one or two machines to begin serving local customers. Dairy businesses that require a few animals and basic infrastructure. Mushroom cultivation that requires initial inputs and technical guidance. Logistics services that require a two-wheeler and communication equipment. Small cafes. Mobile repair shops. A hundred other businesses that require amounts larger than most poor people can accumulate through savings — but amounts that the formal financial system cannot be bothered to process.

Village Venture Funds should operate on circular capital models — where successful businesses pay back their initial investment, which then funds additional ventures. This creates sustainability without requiring perpetual external funding. And it creates accountability — because entrepreneurs know that their repayment enables others to receive the same opportunity they received. They are not repaying a bank. They are repaying their community. That distinction matters more than people who have never been poor will ever understand.

TIER 3: *Corporate Sourcing Mandates*

Large companies commit to buying at least ten percent of their inputs from rural producers — rather than only from established urban suppliers.

If major corporations shifted even ten percent of procurement to rural sources, the impact on rural economy would be transformative. Because volume and reliability are what allow small producers to invest confidently in scaling up. The farmer's cooperative can buy better equipment when it has a confirmed corporate buyer. The tailor's workshop can employ three more people when it has a confirmed school uniform contract.

Buy jaggery from farmer cooperatives instead of processed sugar from large manufacturers. Buy textiles from village cooperatives instead of only from urban factories. Buy furniture from rural carpenters instead of only from established manufacturers. This is not charity. This is enlightened procurement that builds supplier ecosystems while often reducing costs — because rural producers carry lower overhead than urban suppliers.

Corporate social responsibility should mean procurement rather than photo opportunities — where executives visit villages for carefully staged events and return to cities without changing anything structural about how their companies operate. If CSR budgets were converted to procurement commitments, the impact would be ten times larger. Because procurement creates ongoing income rather than one-time assistance. Builds capability rather than

creating dependency. Scales naturally as businesses grow rather than being limited by charitable budgets that get reviewed annually and frequently cut.

TIER 4: *University-Village Rotations*

Students spend significant time in rural areas applying their learning to real problems — rather than only studying abstract case studies in air-conditioned classrooms that bear no relationship to the India that exists beyond the campus boundary.

MBA students work on actual business problems that rural entrepreneurs face — providing analytical capabilities that those entrepreneurs lack, while learning ground realities that no case study ever captures. Engineering students work on water and energy problems that affect villages — applying technical knowledge to contexts where solutions matter immediately and visibly. Commerce students help village businesses with accounting and financial planning. Information technology students build digital infrastructure that connects rural producers to markets.

Young people cannot lead India effectively if they never understand India beyond their urban bubbles. Leadership requires empathy — and empathy requires genuine exposure to how most Indians actually live. Not poverty tourism. Not a two-day visit to a 'model village' followed by a group photo. Real immersion. Real work. Real problems with real consequences if the solutions fail.

University-village rotations create that exposure — in ways that transform students while also serving communities who benefit from the capabilities those students bring, even before those capabilities are fully developed.

TIER 5: *Outcome-Based CSR*

Companies pay only for measurable results — not for activities or intentions or the number of beneficiaries they can claim to serve without measuring whether those beneficiaries actually benefit meaningfully.

Pay a fixed amount per farmer whose income increases by a specified percentage. Pay per youth who gets trained and placed in real employment. Pay per woman entrepreneur whose business scales beyond survival level. Pay per dropout who returns to school and completes education.

This structure aligns incentives properly. Organisations running these programmes focus on outcomes rather than on maximising the impressive-sounding numbers in their annual reports. The programme that claims to have 'reached' fifty thousand people but improved the life of none is not a programme — it is a performance. Outcome-based CSR ends the performance and demands the substance.



The Multiplier Effect — Why One Changes Many

The multiplier effect of incubating entrepreneurs is extraordinary when you calculate the full chain of impacts

— rather than just the direct effect on the entrepreneur herself.

One incubated entrepreneur creates three to ten jobs depending on the type of business — directly reducing unemployment among people who might otherwise migrate or remain dependent on government assistance. When parents have stable income, school attendance improves — because families can afford fees and supplies, and the opportunity cost of keeping children in school becomes manageable rather than impossible. Women gain authority within households and communities when they generate income — shifting power dynamics that have kept women subordinate for generations without requiring anyone to make a speech about it.

Youth stop migrating when they see viable economic opportunities at home — preserving family structures and community cohesion that migration destroys. Local markets revive because increased income creates demand that supports other businesses — creating virtuous cycles rather than the vicious cycles that poverty perpetuates. Crime drops when legitimate economic opportunities exist — because most economic crime comes from desperation rather than pure criminality. And villages become investment-worthy when they demonstrate economic viability — attracting additional capital that accelerates everything.

One village transformed through systematic incubation lifts the surrounding taluka — because success in one place

proves that success is possible and provides a model that others can adapt. Transform enough talukas and you transform the district. Transform enough districts and you transform the state. Transform enough states and you change the nation.

This is not theory. This is not wishful thinking. This is demonstrated reality in every place where systematic incubation has been attempted seriously and sustained long enough to compound.



Sonal from Tuljapur

Let me tell you about Sonal.

She was thirty-five years old and had never worked outside her home. She had no formal business training and no entrepreneurial experience — at least none that anyone had ever called entrepreneurial. She could stitch clothes competently because she had learned from her mother, the way skills have always been transmitted in homes that no school bothered to reach. But competence while sitting at home generates no income. And no income generates nothing.

We provided her first machine through a micro-loan structured so repayment wouldn't become crushing — calibrated to what she could earn, not to what a bank needed to justify its administrative costs. We trained her on

how to manage a small business. Basic concepts: costing, pricing, customer relations. Things that seem obvious to educated people — which is precisely why educated people never think to teach them. We connected her to schools that needed uniforms stitched — providing the trade access that converted her capability into income, that closed the loop between what she could do and what someone would pay her to do.

Within a year, Sonal had repaid the loan and bought a second machine.

Within two years, she was employing three women from her neighbourhood.

Within five years, she was running a tailoring operation with eleven employees — holding contracts with multiple schools, generating enough income that her daughter became the first person in their family to graduate from college.

This is not upliftment — that patronising term that suggests someone was down and needed pulling up by superior people who happened to arrive with resources and benevolence and a camera.

This is transformation.

The unlocking of potential that was always present — that had always been present, in that house, in that woman, in that pair of hands that had been stitching since childhood — but needed three things: Training, Tools, and Trade. Three

T's. And someone willing to provide them without requiring Sonal to become a different person first.



The Numbers That Make the Case

If India incubates ten lakh new enterprises over the next ten years through systematic application of structured incubation, mentorship, and market integration — the mathematics of what follows is not optimistic projection. It is simple arithmetic.

- Ten lakh enterprises $\times$ an average of five direct jobs per enterprise = fifty lakh direct jobs created.
- Fifty lakh direct jobs $\times$ a typical five-person household = two and a half crore people directly supported, earning income, consuming goods, participating in the economy.
- Two and a half crore people with increased income create additional demand — for housing, food, mobility, health, education, services — generating indirect employment across every sector that serves them.

This cascading effect — direct jobs leading to household income leading to consumer demand leading to new jobs — is how real economic transformation happens. It is not built on trickle-down assumptions, where wealth eventually reaches the broad base through the patience and goodwill of those at the top. It is built on distributed capability creation. Enterprise at the base, multiplying upward.

Consider what already exists. Self-employment in India has risen from 52.2 percent of the workforce in 2017-18 to 58.4 percent in 2023-24. Roughly sixty percent of India's workforce is already self-employed — engaged in own-account work or household enterprise activity rather than formal wage employment. MSMEs contribute approximately thirty percent of India's GDP. They are the second-largest employer after agriculture. They account for around forty-five percent of India's exports.

These are not fringe numbers. They reveal the deep integration of small enterprise activity with the national economic fabric. The engine is already running. It is running rough, running unsupported, running despite the system rather than because of it.

Systematic incubation does not start this engine from cold.

It removes the weight that has been sitting on top of it.

The commonly cited timeline for India to become the world's third largest economy is around 2030 — assuming we continue the current growth trajectory, significantly driven by large industries and services and consumption demand tied to urban expansion. But if India accelerates distributed enterprise creation at scale, the growth engines spread across geography, across skill cohorts, across sectors. The base of economic activity broadens. Domestic demand strengthens. Resilience deepens across the entire economy.

An earlier emergence as a top-three economy doesn't require magic.

It requires the strategic activation of entrepreneurship at scale.

It requires three Ts for ten lakh people.

And the will to provide them.



The Farmer at the Centre of Everything

Every economic story eventually comes back to food, water, land, and labour.

Every meal begins long before a market opens or a consumer pays.

And yet for decades, the Indian farmer has stood at the end of the economic line — last to be paid, first to lose. The world around him has transformed. Technology has leapt generations in a decade. Capital flows at the speed of light. But in the fields of rural India, time feels slower. The monsoon still decides fate. The middleman still dictates price. Debt still waits patiently at the edge of every season.

When crops fail, there is no insurance of dignity. Only survival.

When hope erodes, migration begins.

People do not leave villages because they hate the land.

They leave because the land no longer loves them back.

If this continues, we will deepen the fault line between urban India and rural India — not just economically, but emotionally and culturally. Cities will swell. Villages will hollow out. The country will fracture quietly — so quietly that we will not notice until the fracture is too wide to bridge.

Entrepreneurship Must Include the Soil

Transformation happens when entrepreneurship flourishes.

And agriculture is not outside entrepreneurship — it is its oldest form.

Farmers do far more than grow crops. They manage risk. They allocate capital. They time markets. They balance ecology and economy — every single day, with consequences that are immediate and personal and unforgiving. What they lack is not intelligence or effort. What they lack is systems that treat agriculture as an enterprise rather than a burden to be subsidised and pitied.

This is where the next wave of growth must emerge.

- Agri-entrepreneurship — not subsistence farming
- Agri-tech — not monsoon gambling
- Farmer Producer Companies — not isolated individuals selling desperation
- Rural infrastructure — not seasonal relief that arrives after the damage is done

When farmers aggregate through Farmer Producer Companies, they stop selling desperation and start selling scale. When technology enters the field — not as jargon but as genuine decision support — yields stabilise, costs fall, and risk becomes manageable rather than existential. When storage, logistics, processing, and branding stay closer to the farm, value stops leaking outward to every intermediary who adds cost without adding care.

This is not romanticism.

This is economic realism.

Why Migration Will Not Stop Otherwise

Migration is not a failure of ambition.

It is a failure of opportunity.

As long as rural India cannot offer dignity, income stability, and future pathways — people will move. They will trade clean air for congestion, community for anonymity, land for survival wages. They will leave the places that formed them because those places offer no future that a young person can picture themselves in.

And cities will not absorb them well. They never have. The slums of Mumbai and the labour colonies of Delhi and the peripheral settlements of every major Indian city are testimony to what happens when migration is the only rational choice — and when the places people migrate to were never built to receive them.

The answer is not to stop migration by force or by policy.

The answer is to make staying a rational choice.

That only happens when agriculture becomes a viable enterprise. When rural MSMEs grow alongside farms. When young people can see futures that do not require abandoning their roots, their families, their languages, their land — everything that made them who they are — in order to survive.

Incubation is how we make staying rational.

Incubation is how we make rural India competitive not just with the city next door but with the aspiration inside every young person who is trying to decide whether to stay or go.



Your Turn: Become an Incubator

Now it's time to translate everything you've understood into one specific act — with one specific person — beginning now.

Exercise 9.1: Identify ONE Person to Incubate Over the Next Ninety Days

Choose someone specific who has entrepreneurial desire and basic capability — but lacks the support system to convert that into a functioning enterprise. Don't choose abstractly. Don't construct a theoretical beneficiary. Choose an actual human being whose name you know and whose circumstances you understand.

Someone whose potential you can see even if they cannot yet see it themselves. Someone who has the spark but not the structure. Someone who has been working hard in the wrong direction because nobody ever showed them a better one. Someone who, with Training and Tools and Trade, could become the next Sonal from Tuljapur.

Exercise 9.2: Provide the Three Ts Through Whatever Means You Can Access

Figure out what training this person needs and how you can facilitate it — whether through formal courses or informal mentorship or connecting them to people who have the knowledge they need. Identify what tools they require to actually begin production and how you can help them acquire those tools. Determine how you can facilitate trade by connecting them to potential customers, helping them market their products, opening doors to buyers they could never reach independently.

Provide all three Ts simultaneously rather than sequentially — because entrepreneurship requires all three working together. Training without tools and trade is education without application. Tools without training and trade is equipment without purpose. Trade without training and tools is demand that cannot be met. Together: transformation.

Exercise 9.3: Document the Ninety-Day Transformation Carefully

Keep detailed records of what you provided, what worked and what didn't, what the person learned and struggled with, what income they generated and how quickly. This documentation serves multiple purposes. It keeps you accountable for following through on your commitment. It helps you learn what actually works rather than what you hoped would work. It creates a model that you can share with others who want to replicate what you've done. And it proves — to every sceptic who says this kind of transformation is impossible — that it has been done, here, by you, with this specific person, in this specific place.

Exercise 9.4: Replicate the Model With Two More People

Once you've successfully incubated one person — take what you learned and do it again with two more. Don't wait for perfect conditions or unlimited resources. Use what you learned from the first experience to make the second and third attempts more efficient and more effective. Each replication teaches you more and proves that your model works beyond one lucky case.

Three successful incubations means you have created a replicable model that others could adopt and scale. You are no longer a person who helped someone. You are a system that can be replicated. And replicable systems are how nations change.

Mission Checkpoint

Before moving to the final chapter, verify that you've actually begun the work of incubation — rather than just understanding it conceptually.

- ☐ One specific person identified by name with clear understanding of their potential and needs
- ☐ All three Ts provided — or being actively provided — with concrete plans and timelines
- ☐ Documentation system created and being used to track the transformation in real time
- ☐ Commitment made to replicate with two additional people once the first succeeds

If you cannot check all four boxes honestly — you're still consuming information rather than creating transformation.

Go back and do the work.

Because understanding incubation intellectually while doing nothing practically makes you part of the problem rather than part of the solution. India doesn't need more people who understand what should be done. India needs more people who are doing it — one entrepreneur at a time, one enterprise at a time, one transformation at a time.

Sonal didn't need someone to write a report about the tailoring sector.

She needed one machine, one contract, and one person who believed she could do this.

Somewhere near you, right now — there is a Sonal waiting.

What are you waiting for?

Questions for Reflection

- What does the author mean by saying India's biggest resource is its people?
- Why do many talented individuals fail to grow despite having good ideas?
- How can mentorship and guidance change a person's future?
- Why are ecosystems important for entrepreneurship and innovation?
- Identify one local skill, craft, or talent in your area that deserves more support.
- If you had to build a startup incubator for your town, what three things would you include?
- How can successful entrepreneurs help create opportunities for others?

FINAL CALL

YES. I AM IN.

When Dream Becomes Decision

Every revolution has a moment. This is yours.

You have arrived.

Not at the end of a book. At the beginning of a decision.

Every revolution has a moment when you stop being a spectator and become a participant. When you look in the mirror and say with complete conviction: enough. My time has come. I will no longer wait for someone else to build what I can build myself. I will no longer watch from a safe distance and offer commentary on the courage of others while risking nothing of my own.

This chapter is that moment for you.

Everything you've read until now was preparation. Everything that comes after depends on the decision you make right here, right now — in this moment that will define whether you were serious about change or merely entertained by the idea of it.



What This Book Has Been

This book has been four things simultaneously. Understanding what it has been helps you understand what you must now become.

This book has been a mirror — showing you yourself more clearly than you might have wanted to see. Reflecting back the gap between who you are and who you claim you want to be. Making visible the excuses you've been using and the mediocrity you've been accepting and the life that is happening in the space between your intentions and your actions.

This book has been a magnifying glass — focusing your attention on problems you've been ignoring and potential you've been wasting. Making small things large enough that you cannot dismiss them as insignificant. Making the street vendor's discipline visible. Making Sonal's transformation measurable. Making the farmer's slow erosion impossible to look away from.

This book has been a megaphone — amplifying truths that get spoken quietly or not at all in polite society. Saying loudly what needs to be said even when saying it makes people uncomfortable. Even when saying it means pointing the finger not at the government or the system or the politicians but at the person holding this book.

This book has been a map — showing you the territory you must navigate and the paths that others have walked successfully before you attempted your own journey. Subhash Deshmukh's path. Arvind from Beed's path. Sonal from Tuljapur's path. Raja Mama's path. Each one different. Each one walked without a blueprint. Each one proof.

But the journey itself — the actual movement from where you are to where you need to be — that journey is yours alone. Nobody can walk it for you. Nobody can want it badly enough on your behalf to make it happen without your own commitment. Nobody can substitute their effort for yours and produce transformation in your life or your community. The journey requires you to show up fully, commit completely, persist stubbornly through obstacles that will definitely appear and setbacks that will definitely test whether you meant what you said when you said you wanted change.



Who You Are in This Story

You are not a spectator in the drama of New India.

You are a stakeholder — with power and responsibility that you cannot delegate or defer or pass to someone better positioned or better resourced or more qualified. This is not a story being written by someone else that you are watching. This is a story being written by everyone — including you — through the daily choices that accumulate into lives that accumulate into communities that accumulate into a nation.

You are the writer of your own story — determining through your daily choices what narrative you're creating and what meaning your life will ultimately have. You are the actor who must perform the role rather than watching others perform while you sit in the audience applauding or criticising but never risking anything yourself. You are the director who decides what gets emphasised and what gets cut, what matters enough to invest in and what should be abandoned because it isn't serving your mission.

You are the architect.

The person who designs what will be built — and takes responsibility when the structure stands or falls based on how well you understood the forces you were working with and against. Every action you take shifts India infinitesimally in some direction. Every thing you build raises India incrementally above where it was before you built it. Every time you sit back and wait for someone else to do what you could do yourself — India waits too.

And India has been waiting too long already.



The Twenty-Year Promise

Twenty days changes a habit — if you practice the new behaviour consistently enough that it becomes automatic rather than requiring conscious decision.

Twenty months changes a career — if you're willing to invest that time in developing new capabilities and building new networks and proving yourself in new domains. This is not a long time. It is the time between one monsoon and another, repeated less than twice.

Twenty years changes a nation — if enough people commit to sustained effort toward shared goals and refuse to quit when progress seems slow or invisible.

Nations don't transform overnight through dramatic revolutions that sweep away old orders in a single decisive moment. Nations transform gradually — through millions of daily decisions that accumulate into new patterns that eventually become new structures that finally become new realities that seem inevitable in retrospect but required tremendous effort to create. The freedom movement didn't begin on the day of Independence. It began decades earlier in the daily decisions of people who refused to cooperate with what they knew was wrong.

New India won't begin the day someone declares it arrived.

It will begin — it has already begun — in the daily decisions of people like you who refused to cooperate with mediocrity and dependency and the quiet acceptance of good enough when better was possible.

The question is not whether New India is possible.

The question is whether you will be one of the people who built it.



The New India Pledge

This is not poetry. It is not rhetoric. It is not words designed to sound inspiring in the moment and dissolve quietly once the moment passes.

This is commitment — codified into specific promises that you can evaluate yourself against honestly. Read these words carefully. Understand what you're agreeing to before you agree to it. Because a pledge taken lightly is not a pledge. It is performance. And performance — as this book has argued from its first page — is the enemy.

I pledge to be awake when others sleep.

Which means I will notice what others ignore. I will pay attention to suffering that comfortable people have learned not to see. I will remain conscious of my responsibility when others have numbed themselves to avoid feeling obligated. Being awake is not a virtue of the hours — it is a virtue of the

eyes. Of choosing to see what is inconvenient to see and then refusing to look away.

I pledge to build when others wait.

Which means I will not use other people's inaction as excuse for my own. I will start before conditions are perfect — because conditions are never perfect and people who wait for perfection are waiting for a day that never arrives. I will create solutions rather than just identifying problems. Identifying problems is easy. Anyone can do it from a comfortable distance. Solutions require presence and effort and the willingness to be wrong and try again.

I pledge to teach, because knowledge not shared is wasted.

Which means I will take what I learn and transmit it to others who can use it. I will multiply my impact by creating capability in others rather than hoarding knowledge for personal advantage. What Subhash knew, he taught. What Raja Mama learned, he passed forward to two hundred mentees. The chain of knowledge — broken anywhere — weakens everything downstream.

I pledge to attempt boldly, fail quickly, rise repeatedly.

Which means I will take risks that might not work. I will learn from failures fast enough that failure becomes data rather than disaster. I will never let one setback — or ten setbacks — convince me to stop trying. Because every person in this book who built something remarkable failed first. Not as a prelude to the story. As part of it. As the necessary cost of building anything real.

I pledge that in twenty years I will be able to say 'I did' — not 'I wish I had.'

Which means I will actually do things rather than intend to do them. I will have outcomes to show rather than good intentions to explain. I will make decisions today that my future self will be grateful for — rather than decisions my future self will have to apologise for.

I pledge to incubate one enterprise that creates economic opportunity for others.

Because job creation is more powerful than job seeking. Because entrepreneurship is the engine that drives prosperity — not for one person, but for the community that enterprise supports. Because every enterprise incubated is a Sonal from Tuljapur who might otherwise have remained at one machine for the rest of her life.

I pledge to mentor two people yearly — with genuine investment in their development.

Not casual advice that costs me nothing. Not LinkedIn encouragement. Real mentorship. Sustained engagement. The kind where I show up even when it's inconvenient, where I share what I've learned the hard way, where I open doors that I wish someone had opened for me. Because mentorship is how capability scales. Because India needs more ladders — and every person who has climbed somewhere has the ability to become one.

I pledge to build more than I break. To solve more than I shout. To serve more than I demand.

Which means my life will leave more than it takes. My presence will add more than it subtracts. My contribution will exceed my consumption. This is not sacrifice — it is the only version of a life worth looking back on.

And today, right now, in this moment — I declare with full understanding of what this declaration means:

Yes. I Am In

I am not observing anymore.

I am not waiting anymore.

I am not making excuses anymore.

I am in this revolution — completely, committed totally, determined absolutely

to build the India that I claim I want to see.



The Five Commandments

Abstract commitment is the beginning. These five commandments convert that commitment into concrete behaviour — the daily practice of a revolutionary who has stopped reading and started building.

THE FIRST COMMANDMENT: *Start Within Twenty-Four Hours*

Action delayed is action denied. Momentum matters more than perfection. The gap between intention and action is where most dreams die — not dramatically, not with a bang, but quietly, through the accumulation of days when you almost started but didn't. Take one concrete step toward your mission within one day of making your pledge. Not planning to take a step. Taking it. Not preparing to begin. Beginning.

THE SECOND COMMANDMENT: *Begin With One Person*

Revolutions scale through replication — not through mass mobilisation that tries to move everyone simultaneously. Help one person successfully. Document how you did it. Make the model teachable. One becomes ten becomes hundred becomes thousand through exponential growth that starts small but scales fast when the model works and can be replicated by people who weren't there when you started.

THE THIRD COMMANDMENT: *Build One Solution — Not Ten Half-Finished Ideas*

Depth matters more than breadth in the early stages. One working solution is more valuable than ten ideas that never got properly tested. Perfect your model before multiplying it. The temptation to start new things when the current thing gets difficult is one of the great enemies of building. Resist it. Finish what you started. Then, and only then, begin again.

THE FOURTH COMMANDMENT: *Teach What You Learn*

Teaching is the engine of scale — the mechanism that allows one person's learning to benefit thousands. When you teach, you force yourself to understand more deeply than you would if you just used the knowledge yourself. When you teach, you create others who can do what you can do — multiplying your impact beyond your personal capacity for action. Everything Subhash built, he eventually handed to someone else. That is not weakness. That is the highest form of leadership.

THE FIFTH COMMANDMENT: *Make Your Name Public*

Attach your identity to your work. Anonymity permits quitting — because there are no witnesses and no one to disappoint except yourself, and it turns out most people are remarkably forgiving of their own failures in private. But identity creates accountability. When people know who you are and what you've committed to, your reputation depends on delivering what you promised. Use that pressure. Make it work for you. Let the eyes of your community be the alarm that gets you out of bed.



The Mathematics of Five Million

The fire of five million youth is what New India requires.

And what this manifesto aims to ignite.

If five million young Indians each mentor two people yearly and build one solution that works — the mathematics of transformation become staggering.

*5,000,000 youth × 2 mentees each = 10,000,000 leaders
developed.*

*5,000,000 youth × 1 enterprise each = 5,000,000 enterprises
created.*

*5,000,000 enterprises × 10 employees each = 50,000,000 direct
jobs.*

*10,000,000 leaders + 5,000,000 enterprises + 50,000,000
employed =
transformation touching 150,000,000 people.*

One hundred and fifty million people.

Through the decision of five million individuals to stop waiting and start building.

The mathematics are not complicated. The will is the variable.

Only one army can do this. Not the military — though soldiers deserve respect for their service. Not the bureaucracy — though administrators play necessary roles. Not the corporations — though businesses create value and employment. The only army that can transform India at this scale and speed is the youth of India. Young people who

refuse to accept that the India they inherited is the India they must pass on. Who understand that every generation has the obligation to leave circumstances better than they found them. Who recognise that waiting for someone else to build New India means New India never comes.

You are that army.

Not metaphorically. Not aspirationally.

Actually.

You are the person who will either build what needs building — or explain to the next generation why you didn't. Why you read books about change but never changed anything. Why you understood problems but never solved them. Why you had dreams but never executed them. Why you were moved but never moved.



Your Turn: The Final Commitment

This is the moment of final commitment.

You either join the revolution — or admit you were never serious about it.

There is no middle ground. There is no partial commitment that counts. There is no 'I'll think about it' or 'maybe later when circumstances improve.'

Circumstances do not improve on their own. They improve because someone decided to improve them.

Exercise 10.1: Write the New India Pledge in Your Own Handwriting

Don't type it. Write it by hand — because handwriting creates neural connections and psychological commitment that typing doesn't. Write every word of the pledge slowly enough that you think about what each promise means and whether you're genuinely willing to keep it. Sign your name at the bottom. Date it. So you know exactly when you made this commitment. So you cannot later pretend you weren't sure, weren't ready, weren't certain. You were. You signed it.

Exercise 10.2: Share Your Pledge Publicly Where People Who Know You Can See It

Post it on social media. Send it to friends. Read it at a community meeting. Make your commitment visible to others — because public declaration creates accountability that private commitment lacks. You don't have to be dramatic about it. You do have to make it real. Let people know what you've committed to. Let them know what to expect from you going forward. Let them hold you to it when you forget.

Exercise 10.3: Help One Person Within Twenty-Four Hours of Taking This Pledge

Don't wait. Don't plan further. Don't prepare more. Just help one person today in some concrete way that improves their circumstances — however slightly. Buy someone a meal.

Teach someone a skill. Make an introduction that creates an opportunity. Give someone something they need. The specific action matters less than the immediacy. Begin immediately or you will find excuses to defer indefinitely. This is how you know the pledge was real and not performance — the speed at which you move from words to action.

Exercise 10.4: Define Your Ninety-Day Solution With Complete Specificity

Write down exactly what problem you will solve, in what location, through what method, producing what measurable outcome. Specific enough that ninety days from now you can evaluate honestly — without self-deception — whether you succeeded or failed. Ambitious enough to matter. Realistic enough to be achievable with the resources you can access. Not a dream. A plan with a deadline and a measure.

Exercise 10.5: Take the Pledge by Speaking It Aloud

Stand somewhere private. Look at yourself in a mirror. Speak the pledge aloud — word by word. Hear yourself making this commitment. Let the words become real by passing through your mouth and entering your ears. This might feel awkward. It might feel dramatic. That is acceptable. Awkwardness is less important than commitment. And a certain amount of drama is entirely appropriate when you are pledging to do something that has never been easy — to build a better nation out of your own daily choices, starting today, with what you have, where you are.

The Final Mission Checkpoint

The final checkpoint is the simplest — and the hardest.

You either take the pledge and begin immediately. Or you close this book and return to the life you were living before you read it.

- ☐ Pledge taken in writing — with signature and date
- ☐ Pledge shared publicly where people can hold me accountable
- ☐ Help provided to one person within twenty-four hours
- ☐ Ninety-day solution defined with complete specificity
- ☐ Yes — I am in. Completely. Irrevocably.

Questions for Reflection

- Why does the author treat this chapter as a call to action rather than a conclusion?
- What does saying "YES! I AM IN!" symbolise for the youth of India?
- Why is commitment more powerful than motivation alone?
- According to the chapter, why must change begin with individuals before it reaches society?
- What is one cause or mission you genuinely care about?
- What personal sacrifice would you be willing to make to achieve a meaningful goal?

- After reading the book, what responsibility do you feel toward your future or community?

If you checked all five boxes honestly — you're no longer a reader.

You're a revolutionary. You've transformed from someone who consumes information about change into someone who creates change through sustained action. Welcome to the army that will build New India.

We have been waiting for you.



The Question History Will Ask

When the world asks ten years from now — or twenty years from now — who built New India, when historians look back at this period and document how transformation happened, when your children or your grandchildren ask what you did during the years when India's future hung in the balance between the nation we could become and the nation we would remain if nobody acted —

You will have one answer.

Either you will say 'I did' — with the pride that comes from knowing you kept your promises and honoured your commitments and built what you said you would build. With the quiet certainty of someone who chose difficulty over comfort, commitment over convenience, creation over

consumption. With the particular peace that comes from having lived in alignment with what you believed.

Or you will say 'I didn't' — and live with the particular weight of that. Of having had the chance to matter and having chosen otherwise. Of having read the right books and understood the right arguments and felt the right emotions — and then returned to the same life, slightly more informed about the problems you chose not to solve.

There is no comfortable middle ground between those two answers.

There never was.



The revolution is not coming.

The revolution is here.

It started the moment you finished reading this sentence and decided whether to keep reading or to start building.

Your choice.

Your responsibility.

Your India.

Yes, I am in

THE NEW INDIA MANIFESTO

Are you?



*For Subhash Deshmukh.
Who never needed this book.
And built everything anyway.*

*Now it is **your** turn.*

EPILOGUE

THE REVOLUTION BEGINS

When You Close This Book, the Real Book Opens

The question is no longer whether India will change.

That question has been answered — by history, by evidence, by the story of a boy from Wadala with one damaged eye and no prospects who built factories and cooperatives and communities from nothing. By Sonal from Tuljapur, who went from one machine to eleven employees and a daughter who graduated from college. By Arvind from Beed, who arrived at his desk at four thirty every morning while more credentialed people were still sleeping and still falling behind. By the young people who cleaned two wells in a village whose name doesn't matter — because what they proved matters everywhere.

India changes. It always has. The question was never whether.

The question is whether you will be part of the changing — or whether you will spend your life explaining why you weren't.

New India is not coming from outside, like weather that arrives regardless of what you do. New India is being built — or not built — by people who either accept responsibility for building it or delegate that responsibility to others who may never fulfil it. The only variable is whether you are building or whether you are waiting.

And waiting, as this book has argued from its first page, is a choice. It feels like patience. It is not patience. It is the quiet daily decision to let the world be shaped by people with less ability than you and less vision than you and less reason to care — simply because they started and you didn't.



Why This Book Was Written

I wrote this manifesto because I was tired.

Tired of seeing potential wasted — of watching talented people trapped by systems that don't serve them, cycling through the same frustrations year after year without the framework to understand what was happening to them or the tools to change it. Tired of hearing complaints about problems from people who refuse to work on solutions.

Tired of the particular exhaustion that comes from being surrounded by intelligence that never gets deployed, energy that never gets channeled, fire that never finds its purpose.

I wrote this because my father showed me that circumstances are not destiny. That a boy from a village with a cricket ball injury and a failed eye could build enterprises and institutions and communities — if he simply refused to accept that what existed was all that could exist. That the distance between the life you are given and the life you build is not measured in talent or luck or privilege. It is measured in the daily decisions of a person who refused to stop.

I wrote this because I believe in you more than you might currently believe in yourself. Because I see potential in India's youth that our education system fails to develop and our economy fails to deploy productively. Because the gap between what young Indians are capable of and what the world is currently asking of them is the most heartbreaking waste I know — and also the most astonishing opportunity.

But belief without action is just sentiment. Potential without development is just waste. Understanding without execution is just sophisticated procrastination.

I cannot transform you. I cannot make you care more than you currently care. I cannot force you to act when you'd rather wait. I cannot build New India for you or instead of you.

I can only show you what's possible. Challenge you to make

it actual. Point you toward the path — and require that you walk it yourself.



Everything Is Here

Everything you need is in these pages.

The philosophy that guides effective action. The stories that prove transformation is possible — not for exceptional people in exceptional circumstances, but for ordinary people in ordinary places who made extraordinary commitments and honoured them. The frameworks that convert vague aspirations into specific plans. The exercises that force you from understanding to doing. The checkpoints that create accountability when motivation fades. The examples of people who started with less than you have and built more than you've yet imagined.

Everything is here.

The only thing missing is you — actually doing what you now know how to do.



The Three Paths

I know what will happen when people finish this book. I know it because I know human beings — what moves them,

what stops them, what the distance between inspiration and action looks like when mapped against real lives in real time.

There are three paths. Every reader of this book will walk one of them.

The First Path: Temporary Inspiration

Some of you will finish this book and feel something real. Genuinely real — the kind of fire that rises in the chest when you finally see something clearly that you'd been half-seeing for years. You'll feel certain, in that moment, that this time is different. That this time the feeling will translate into action. That this time you will actually begin.

The inspiration will fade. Not because you're weak — because inspiration is an emotion, and emotions are temporary states that pass without leaving structural change. Within days or weeks, the fire will cool. The comfortable routines will reassert themselves. The familiar complaints will return. The settled acceptance of mediocrity will drape itself back over your days like something you never noticed was there until the moment it lifted — and then returned.

You'll tell yourself you'll act later. When circumstances improve. When you have more time. When conditions are more favourable. Later will never come. Circumstances don't perfect themselves. Time doesn't increase. Favourable conditions are created — not discovered — by people who started before conditions were favourable.

If this is your path — this book has failed you. But more precisely: you have failed yourself. And you will know it, in the quiet hours, for a long time.

The Second Path: The Early Quitter

Some of you will start. This is more than most people do, and it deserves acknowledgment. You'll attempt one initiative — moved by the pledge you took and the specificity of the ninety-day plan and the genuine desire to be the person this book described. You'll begin.

And then it will be harder than you expected. It will take longer than you hoped. It will fail in ways that embarrass you, that make you question whether you understood the problem or whether you were ever capable of the solution. Obstacles will appear that your planning didn't anticipate. People will not respond the way you needed them to. The gap between the vision in your head and the reality on the ground will feel, in those early difficult weeks, like evidence of impossibility rather than evidence of the normal friction that all building involves.

You'll use the failure as permission to stop. As evidence that effort is futile. As justification for returning to passivity while feeling virtuous — because at least you tried. And trying, you'll tell yourself, is what matters.

It is not what matters. Trying that lasts only until trying becomes genuinely difficult is not trying. It is rehearsal for quitting, dressed in the language of courage.

Subhash Deshmukh failed. Arvind failed. Every person in this book who built something real failed first — repeatedly, publicly, without the certainty that the next attempt would succeed. They did not stop. That is the entire difference between the people who built things and the people who tried once and then explained why they stopped.

The Third Path: The Revolutionary

And then there are some of you.

Not more talented. Not more privileged. Not more confident — perhaps less confident, perhaps carrying more doubt than the people on the first two paths, perhaps more aware of how much you don't know and how much you could fail.

But you will decide.

That revolution is necessary. That if revolution is necessary, then someone must wage it. That if someone must wage it, then that someone might as well be you — because you are here, and you understand the problem, and you have what you have, and waiting for a more qualified person to arrive is another name for waiting forever.

You will start. You will persist through obstacles — not because the obstacles aren't real, but because you've decided that the obstacles are not the point. You will fail and learn and try again with adjustments based on learning rather than adjustments based on fear. You will build one solution, then another, then another — until you've created a body of work that transforms your community and gives others permission to attempt their own transformations.

And you will discover something that the people who quit never learn.

The work gets easier as you do more of it.

Not easier in the sense that obstacles disappear or challenges become less challenging. Easier in the sense that you become more capable. More confident. More skilled at navigating difficulty. The first ninety-day sprint will feel impossibly hard because you're learning while doing and questioning whether you're capable. The second sprint will still be hard — but you'll know you can finish, because you finished the first one. The fifth sprint will be hard — but you'll have developed systems and networks and capabilities that make execution more efficient. The tenth sprint will be hard — but you'll be a different person than you were when you started.

Someone who has proven to yourself and to others that you can build things that matter.

And eventually you'll look back and realise: you have become the person you needed when you were starting out. You have capabilities you didn't possess before — earned, not granted, built through the particular discipline of doing difficult things repeatedly until they are no longer quite as difficult. You have confidence earned through repeated success and repeated failure and repeated learning. You have a network of allies who trust you because you've proven trustworthy through action sustained over time.

You will have stories. The way this book has stories.

And someone will read your stories the way you read these — and be changed by them.

That is how revolutions propagate. Not through speeches or books or manifestos alone. Through the lives of people who became proof.



The Transformation That Is Available to Everyone

That transformation is available to everyone who commits to it.

It is not reserved for special people with special advantages. It does not require a particular city, a particular family, a particular educational background, a particular starting point. It happens to ordinary people who make extraordinary commitments — and honour those commitments through daily action sustained long enough that action becomes character and character becomes destiny.

You can become that person.

You can be the revolutionary that New India needs.

You can join the army — not of weapons and force, but of builders and mentors and incubators and teachers — that transforms this nation one person at a time, one community at a time, one solution at a time.

But you have to start.

You have to commit.

You have to act today rather than plan to act tomorrow.

You have to take the pledge seriously rather than reciting it as empty ritual.

You have to check the boxes honestly rather than aspirationally.

You have to become uncomfortable with your own mediocrity — and unwilling to accept it any longer.

You have to decide that you're in. Completely. Irrevocably. Regardless of what comes next.



New India Is Not Coming

New India is not coming.

New India is already here.

It is you. It is every person who finishes this book and decides that enough is enough — that their time has come, that they will build what needs building even if nobody applauds and nobody notices and nobody thanks them for it.

New India is the accumulation of millions of small acts of courage. Millions of daily decisions to build rather than wait. Millions of individual commitments to serve rather than consume. Millions of alarms set for four thirty in the

morning, not because it's comfortable, but because the work requires it and the work matters and you have finally decided that you matter enough to do work that matters.

New India is not a place you will arrive at someday.

New India is what you are creating — right now — through what you choose to do today.



Close this book: Open your life.

**Begin your revolution.
Build your India.**

The rest is up to you.



*Now.
It is your turn.*

THE FINAL MESSAGE

You are not small.

Let that sentence settle in your consciousness with the weight it deserves.

Because everything in your life up until this moment has probably been trying to convince you otherwise. Society tells you you're small — through its indifference to your struggles and your dreams, through its habit of looking past you toward people who already have what you're still working toward. Institutions tell you you're small — by making you fill out forms and wait in queues and accept whatever scraps they're willing to provide, as though your time and your dignity were less valuable than the time of the person behind the desk who holds the stamp.

The economy tells you you're small — by offering wages that barely cover survival and calling it fair compensation. Even

well-meaning people tell you you're small — when they say things like 'be realistic' or 'don't get your hopes up' or 'that's not how the world works.' As though the world were a fixed thing. As though it were not made, continuously and relentlessly, by people exactly like you — who decided that how the world worked was not how it had to work.

But you are not small.

Your impact is not small.

Every action you take ripples outward in ways you cannot fully track or measure. Every person you help becomes capable of helping others. Every solution you build becomes a model that others can replicate. Every stand you take against mediocrity makes it slightly easier for the next person to take their own stand — because you have demonstrated that standing is possible, that it doesn't destroy you, that something gets built when someone refuses to sit back down.

Your life is not an isolated incident that affects only you.

Your life is part of a larger system — where individual actions compound into collective outcomes, where personal choices create cultural patterns, where what you do matters far beyond your immediate visible impact.

The street vendor whose discipline Subhash observed — she didn't know she was teaching a lesson. The farmer who accepted eight hundred rupees to build a check dam didn't know he was demonstrating the model. Sonal from Tuljapur, sitting at one machine in a house no one had heard of — she

didn't know she was becoming proof. None of them were trying to be significant. They were trying to do the work in front of them. And significance arrived anyway — the way it always does — not through ambition, but through sustained, quiet action.



You are the founder of New India.

Not any famous leader whose name appears in newspapers. Not the wealthy industrialist whose actions move markets. Not the politician on the podium or the bureaucrat behind the policy.

You. The person holding this book right now.

You are the founder because New India will either be built by millions of people like you — doing difficult work in obscurity, building things that don't get applauded, solving problems that don't get noticed — or it will not be built at all. Grand visions announced from stages mean nothing without ground-level execution by ordinary people who become extraordinary through their willingness to show up consistently and do what needs doing. History remembers the people on the stages. History is made by the people who were never on any stage.

You are the architect of the next fifty years.

The India that exists in 2050 will be the result of decisions being made right now — in 2026 — by people who are

currently young enough to see the results of their efforts. Who have enough time remaining to build something lasting. Who possess enough energy to sustain effort over decades.

That is you.

The buildings that will stand in 2050 are being designed now through choices about what to build and how to build it and why it matters. The systems that will function in 2050 are being created now — through experiments that succeed or fail but generate learning either way. The leaders who will guide India in 2050 are being formed now — through experiences that develop capability and test character. Through ninety-day sprints. Through wells cleaned in the early morning. Through machines bought on micro-loans by women who had never before been trusted with capital. Through the long discipline of four-thirty alarm clocks that nobody rang for them — that they set themselves.



When the world asks who built New India —

The answer must be: we did.

Not I did — though individual effort matters and is irreplaceable and should never be minimised. Not they did — though we must acknowledge and honour those who came before and paid prices we will never fully understand. We did. Together. Millions of us who refused to accept that the India we inherited was the India we had to pass on.

Millions of us who understood that complaining changes nothing — but building changes everything. Millions of us who chose action over waiting, responsibility over dependency, creation over consumption. Who built enterprises no one believed in. Who incubated entrepreneurs that nobody else would invest in. Who mentored children in schools that were forgotten. Who cleaned wells in villages whose names you've never heard. Who woke at four thirty, not because it was asked of them, but because the work required it and they had decided that the work mattered.

We did this.

We built this.

We transformed this nation — one person at a time, one enterprise at a time, one community at a time, one solution at a time — refusing to quit when obstacles appeared, refusing to accept mediocrity as destiny, refusing to wait for permission or perfect conditions or guarantees of success that were never coming and were never ours to wait for.



India needs a generation that will stand up when standing up is uncomfortable.

That will step forward when stepping forward is risky. That will build boldly despite uncertainty. That will fail bravely and learn from failure rather than being paralysed by the fear of it. That will serve without demanding recognition or

reward — because service done for recognition is not service. It is performance. And performance, as this book has argued from its first page to its last, is the enemy of everything real.

India needs a generation that rises.

Endlessly.

After being knocked down. After failing publicly. After the project that didn't work and the person who didn't follow through and the plan that reality refused to cooperate with. A generation that understands falling down is not staying down. That the floor is just the beginning of a decision — and the decision is always yours.

India needs a generation that says yes.

Yes to responsibility — even when responsibility is heavier than you expected and nobody will share the weight. Yes to difficulty — because difficulty is the only path to capability and capability is the only path to freedom. Yes to service — because a life lived in service to others is the only life that, looking back from its final pages, does not feel wasted. Yes to building what has never been built before — because every thing that exists was once impossible until someone decided it was merely difficult. Yes to attempting what seems impossible — until someone proves it's possible. Yes to New India.



YES. I AM IN

That is the only question that matters now.

That is the only decision that determines whether this book changes anything — or merely entertains you briefly before you return to the life you were living before you read it.

Yes means you're committed completely — not partially, not provisionally, not 'mostly but with some reservations that might become excuses later.' Completely. Yes means you're starting immediately — not eventually, not when you feel ready, not when the timing is better. Immediately. Yes means you're in regardless of obstacles or setbacks or people who tell you you're wasting your time on things that can't be changed by one person in one lifetime.

Yes means you've transformed.

From spectator to participant. From consumer to creator. From someone who talks about change to someone who

builds it — quietly, stubbornly, without applause, without the guarantee of success, without the certainty of arrival — only the certainty that the trying matters, that the building matters, that the daily decision to show up and do the work is itself the revolution, happening now, in you, through you.



When you close this book — the real book opens.

The book where you are the author. Where your life is the narrative. Where your actions determine the plot and your choices create the meaning. That book is being written right now — through what you do today and tomorrow and every day after. That book will be read by the next generation, who will judge not what you intended but what you built. Not what you understood but what you changed. Not what moved you but whether you moved.

Write a good book.

Write a book worth reading.

Write a book that makes the people who come after you grateful that you were here — and did what you did — when you did it.

Write a book that proves one person committed to action can change more than a million people committed only to understanding, or opinion, or critique. That the person who builds something imperfect and real has contributed more than the person who perfectly identified why building was

Yes. I Am In

difficult. That showing up — day after day, without applause, in the unglamorous hours when nobody is watching and the work is harder than you thought — is itself a form of greatness.

The revolution is not coming someday when conditions improve.

The revolution is here.

Now.

Waiting for you to join it.

Your choice: Your responsibility.

Your India.



For you.

*Who has everything you need.
And must build everything now.*

